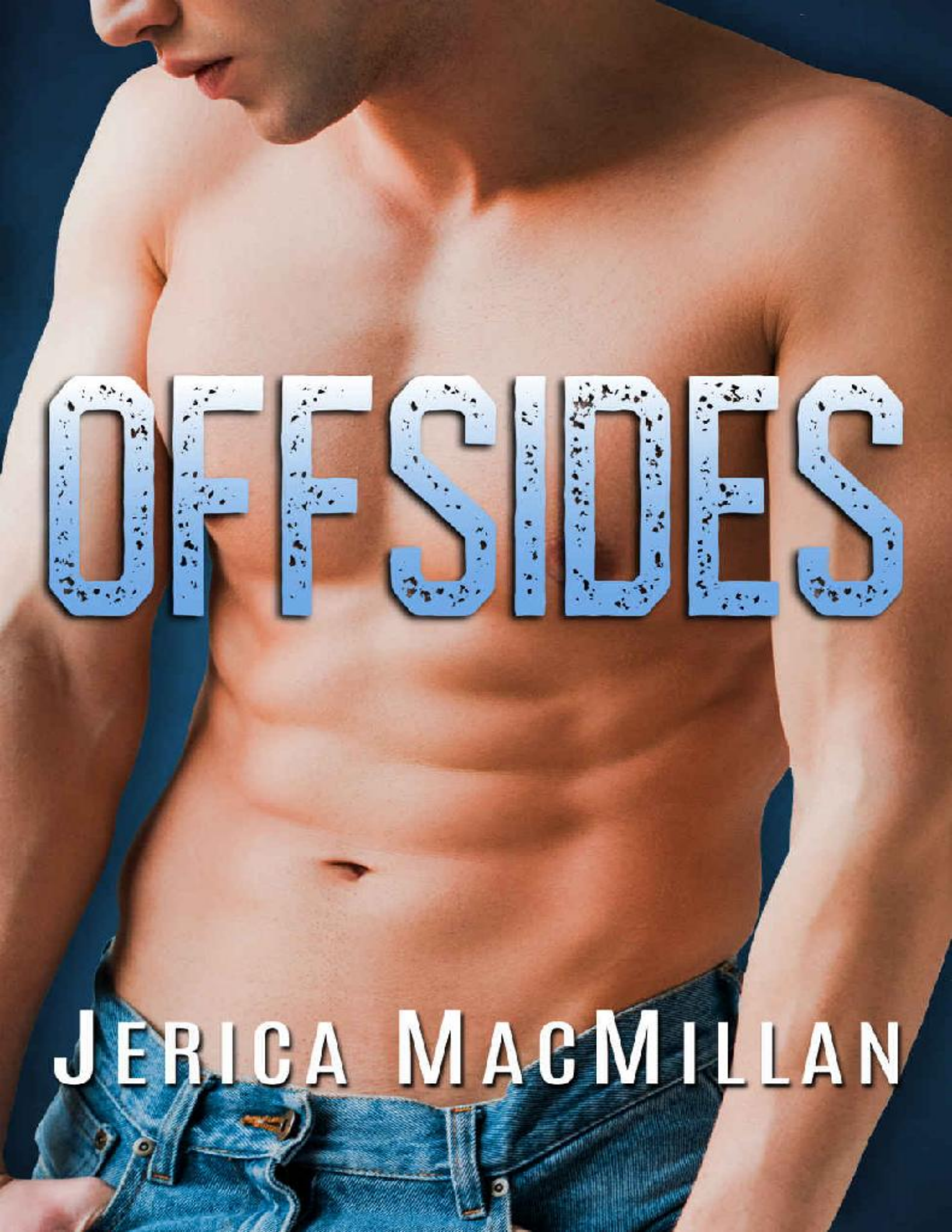




OFFSIDES

JERICA MACMILLAN

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Offsides

Jerica MacMillan

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CHAPTER ONE

Eli

I hit pause on my game, scooping up my phone from the seat next to me and glancing at the screen before answering. “Hey, man. What’s up?”

“Dude. I know you said you didn’t want to come, but you should get down here.” Jackson’s voice vibrates with laughter over the background noise of karaoke night at Neon.

His girlfriend Autumn texted him earlier and let him know she and Dani were going out for a girls’ night—just the two of them since their other roommates, Ellie and Piper, aren’t back from Christmas break yet—and he decided to crash it.

I told him not to and that I wanted no part in butting in on a girls’ night. Of the two of us, I feel like he should know better than me about that since he grew up with a single mom *and* an older sister. Even *I* know that the only reasons worth interrupting a woman’s girls’ night is death or dismemberment. Or maybe I realize that more because my mom was the only woman in a family of men—my dad, my younger brother, and me.

Regardless, there was no way he could convince me to go along with him. His girlfriend might seem all sweetness and light, but if you cross her, she’ll cut off your nuts and hand them back to you with a smile. I prefer to keep my nuts firmly attached to my body, thankyouverymuch.

But his laughter and command to come anyway? Now I’m curious.

Standing, I stretch my arms overhead. “Oh yeah? Why’s that?”

“You need to come see Dani.”

My whole body stands at attention, blood rushing south. I mean, I knew she'd be there. This isn't actually a surprise. But why do I need to come see her?

Concern grips me, though. What if I need to rescue her? Maybe there are douchebros making life difficult for her. Autumn's safe since Jackson is there, but since Dani doesn't have a guy with her ... "Is something wrong? Is she in trouble?"

Not that Dani really needs rescuing. She's a complete badass. But we all know that drunk assholes don't handle being told no very well. And even the most badass women need backup sometimes.

Another chuckle from Jackson. "No, no. She's ... fine. Just ... come see for yourself. I promise it'll be worth it."

"Alright. I'll head over."

"Hurry, though. I promise, you don't want to miss this."

Glancing down at my sweatpants and old high school football shirt with a hole in the armpit, I figure I should probably change.

In my room, I strip everything off and pull a fresh pair of jeans out of my drawer. Lifting my arm, I give myself a quick sniff test. Eh, not the greatest. No time for a shower given Jackson's insistence I hurry or else I'll miss something, but I can at least swipe on fresh deodorant. My hand hovers over the new sweater my mom gave me for Christmas, but given that I'm going to a bar, I opt for a steel gray button down instead. Chicks love it when I roll the cuffs up to my elbows.

Shoes, jacket, wallet, keys, and I'm out the door.

* * *

I move through the crowd at Neon, my jacket slung over my arm, searching for Jackson, largely ignoring the hot chick on stage belting out some older girl-power breakup song that I've heard a few times, something about starting a fight.

"Eli!" Jackson barks out, and I turn, moving to a table closer to the stage where he's sitting with Autumn, her chair pulled up close enough so they can touch each other, both of them facing the little stage. "We weren't sure you'd make it in time."

Confused, I look at Autumn, who gives me a wide grin, then looks meaningfully at the stage.

I glance at the stage for a second, a defensive smile tugging at the corners of my mouth. “If you’re suggesting I go next, that’s gonna be a no.”

She rolls her eyes and smacks her palm lightly on the table, but it’s Jackson who answers. “Dude.” There’s that laughter in his voice again. “Pay attention. Look at who’s singing.”

Returning my attention to the stage, I take in the girl with long, black wavy hair wearing a shimmery tank, a tight little skirt, and strappy heels, a crystal dangling between her tits. She’s pretty. Definitely my type. But I don’t get what the big deal is.

Autumn cackles. “He doesn’t recognize her. And she calls you her best friend.”

Blinking hard, I swear I almost swallow my tongue, because that’s when it hits me what they’re on about. “Dani?” I croak.

More cackling from Autumn. “She’s been rocking up there all night. Thought you might like to see her shine.”

I drop my jacket on one of the chairs, my hand hanging onto the back to hold myself up, because holy shit.

Ho. Lee. Shit.

She looks ... amazing. Beyond amazing. I always think she looks great, but whatever she’s done to herself tonight is next level. She normally dresses in jeans or joggers and a hoodie during the school year, with the exception of the warmer weather times. But that’s a pretty small part of the school year, really. We work out together, so I’m not entirely unused to seeing her in formfitting clothes, but it’s workout leggings and a loose-ish racerback tank. No matter what, her hair is always in a ponytail, and she’s never wearing makeup.

Tonight, her hair is down, falling in waves around her shoulders. I had no idea her hair was wavy. And while her makeup is fairly subtle, the smoky eye and redder lips and cheeks are the giveaway—though I admit the flushed cheeks could be from drinking.

But she’s fucking glowing up there. It’s not just the clothes, it’s not just the makeup, it’s the way she’s owning the stage and performing that song, giving it everything she’s got. You’d think she really is the rockstar she’s claiming to be in the lyrics.

See? Badass.

Dani is an absolute badass no matter what she does. It's one of the things I love most about her.

When she gets to the bridge, though, something changes. The lyrics talk about how the guy was never really there for her, and that seems to hit something deep inside Dani, because she gets choked up, her voice breaking in a way that cracks my heart right along with it.

I'm moving before I even realize it, my hands balled into fists at my side. Because I know she's gotta be singing about that douchebag she keeps getting back together with.

What did he do this time?

She always gets mopey when they break it off, and I take her to the weight room and cheer her on as she sweats it out and then we play video games until she's happier. But I've never seen her actually get choked up over him.

I move to the edge of the stage so she knows I'm there supporting her, ready to hop in and finish for her if necessary. Her eyes widen when she notices me, and I don't know if it's me being here or just her own inner reserves, but she pulls it together and finishes the song.

Once the final notes fade away, she sets the mic back on the stand and makes a beeline for me. I hold my arms open on instinct, and she falls into them in a way she never has before.

Sure, we've hugged. I've comforted her multiple times over the years. But it was usually her leaning on me while we sat on the couch, and our frontal hugs were quick goodbyes. Not this, where it seems like I'm supporting her more than she's supporting herself.

But I just hold her, letting her hang onto my strength, secure in the knowledge that she'll fill me in on whatever's causing this show of emotion when she's ready and able. Somehow the middle of karaoke night at Neon doesn't seem like the best time or place.

The MC gives us a funny look as he takes the stage and calls out the next name. Once the drunken, off-key singing by a group of frat guys starts, Dani lifts her head, wiping below her eyes surreptitiously with her thumbs and glancing over her shoulder at the group enthusiastically—if badly—singing their rendition of that “I would walk five hundred miles” song.

She lets out a spluttering laugh, but she seems like she's still overly close to tears.

Leaning in close, I put my mouth right next to her ear so I don't have to shout. "Want me to take you home?"

When her dark eyes meet mine, they're liquid, fathomless, and so vulnerable it makes my chest clench. My fingers tighten where they still rest on the curve of her waist. It's an intimate hold, far more intimate than normal for us, but I can't bring myself to regret it. I'd love it if I could hold her like this all the time. Or at least as often as she wants to be held.

Again. Badass.

But even badasses need support now and then.

Every once in a while she gets cuddly, especially if she's been drinking, and I live for those nights when she comes over and snuggles into my side to watch a movie or catch a football game. Hell, any kind of game. We have similar tastes in movies and sports, so it makes choosing something to watch easy, but if she only wanted to watch Shakespeare or ... cheesy rom-coms or ... black and white flicks from the 50s, I'd watch those too if it meant having her pressed against me.

I mean, I'd probably complain eventually if that's *all* she wanted to watch. Another thing I love about her is how awesome she is. Unassuming, supportive, has great taste in movies, knows as much about football as I do, and can squat me easily.

She's literally the perfect woman.

I've thought so for a long time. And seeing her all dressed up like this tonight?

God, it only makes me want her more.

The truth is that I'll take her any way I can get her. Dressed up, dressed down, not dressed at all ...

I shift to make sure my hips aren't anywhere near hers so she doesn't feel the growing chub in my pants at the thought of peeling her out of these uncharacteristic clothes. Giving her one of my T-shirts or something to lounge in after I've mapped out all her curves with my hands and tongue if she doesn't want to lounge naked.

Clearing my throat I stop that train of thought, though not before the image of her standing in my bedroom wearing my jersey and nothing else flashes through my mind. It's an old standby fantasy. She always wears my

number when she comes to my games, and it's one of my favorite things ever. But after the first time she did that, the fantasy of her wearing *only* that jersey entered the spank bank and still holds top billing.

"Yeah," she says, her voice hoarse. She straightens, meeting my eyes. "Yeah, let's get out of here. I'll get my jacket and let Autumn know we're taking off."

I trail behind her to the table where Autumn and Jackson are still sitting. Autumn gives me a knowing look over Dani's shoulder as Dani leans down and fills her in on our plan, complete with a wink and a finger wave. This chick. She's too much sometimes. But I have to admit that she's been good for Jackson, and even though she's not who I would've picked for him by any means—and sometimes I'm still shocked that he picked her for himself—she's actually pretty cool, even if she likes to share far too much about their sex life. And ask pointed questions about everyone else's too.

Dani puts on her coat and gives me a wan smile over her shoulder as I grab my jacket before we head for the door. We walk in silence, Dani following my unspoken directions to where I parked. Good thing I only paid for an hour at the meter. I open the car door for her, and she gives me a funny look before shrugging and climbing into her seat.

I guess it is kind of a funny thing to do, something you do for a date or your girlfriend, and Dani is neither of those things. She's just a friend.

Always just a friend.

I always thought it was douchey when guys would bitch about being friendzoned. I still do, really. But I also kinda get it, because I've been in the friend zone with Dani from day one. I don't know if she's ever even thought of me as more than just a friend. Like late at night when she's lying awake and can't sleep, just thought briefly about what it might be like if we got together? Or when she's maybe had just a tad too much to drink? Not that she drinks often or very much when she does. She's strict about her calorie intake and alcohol is just empty calories. Plus, it can interfere with your workouts. But every once in a while, she'll loosen up and have a drink.

"How much did you drink tonight?" I ask quietly once I'm in the car. She rolls her eyes like I'm ridiculous for asking, and I can't help laughing. "What?" I protest as I turn on the car and hit the buttons for the seat warmers. "Look at you! You're all dressed up like I've never seen before. Did you let Autumn curl your hair on top of the clothes and makeup? And

then I find you belting out a breakup song at karaoke night.” I shake my head in mock dismay. “Who even *are* you right now? The only possible answer is that Autumn forced a bunch of liquor down your throat.”

Dani cracks up. She doubles over laughing, wiping her eyes again when she sits up, though tears of mirth this time at least. “Thanks, Eli. I needed that.”

A small smile curves my lips as I pull into the street and start heading to my place. I may not be everything for her, but at least I can be this.

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CHAPTER TWO

Dani

My emotions bubble just beneath the surface. I'm doing my best to keep them under control, but something about the karaoke seems to have rubbed me raw, scraped down my outer layers so that the surface is far too easy to break through.

I'd picked "So What" by P!nk, because the song was supposed to make me feel powerful. Strong. Like I'm not actually devastated by the way Luke broke my heart.

And it's ridiculous. On some level, I realize that. We'd broken up, like we always do, and he got together with someone else.

It's just that while we've broken up multiple times before, he always got back together with *me*.

We only ever broke up because while he left Bradford, Montana to go to the University of Michigan, I came to Washington to attend Marycliff University. He always said maintaining a long-distance relationship was just too difficult. Eventually, anyway.

We'd get back together when we were both home from school. He'd promise me we'd stay together each time. And within a couple of weeks he'd call and ask to take a break again.

I always assumed it was because he wanted to get laid. And I can't really blame him. Sometimes I wanted that too, so it's not like I was a nun while we were on a break either. But those were always no strings hookups. I was never looking for another relationship or really even open to the

possibility. And I definitely never brought a guy home with me for Christmas and paraded him around town right under his nose.

Maybe I should.

I glance at Eli out of the corner of my eye, his profile lit by the blue glow of the dashboard lights. I could ask him to pretend to be my boyfriend. To come home with me on the next break. Maybe spring break? That's a whole week. And over two months to figure out a game plan before then.

I could bring him home and show him off to everyone, especially Luke. Let him know that I've moved on too. And with a Division I football player, no less, who's been tapped to be one of the captains next year. Much more impressive than a weightlifter with a tendency to choke at the most important parts of the competition. Sure, his team is one of the best collegiate weightlifting teams in the country. Doesn't mean he's anchoring it, though.

And Eli has always encouraged my lifting. Luke liked to play the superiority card, talking about how he'd go to the Olympics one day, and since I was *only* into powerlifting, I'd never be able to do that. And I was never serious enough about it for his liking.

Just enjoying myself and competing because my dad pushed me to and I couldn't come up with a good enough excuse not to was never good enough for him. Because if you're going to do something, you have to be the best and to be the best you have to compete and blah blah blah.

Honestly, he was a lot like my dad that way. My dad pushing me to compete is the only reason I ever did it. It's not like it was a school sport or anything. I first started lifting because my dad suggested I sign up for strength training for a PE credit and hinted he'd be really proud of me for doing it. And since making my dad proud was one of my main goals growing up, I did it immediately. Once I finished the semester of strength training at school, he signed us up at the local gym and hired me a coach. Dad thought it would be a fun "bonding" activity for us. We could train together and travel together to competitions and all that.

While I loved getting my dad's attention, I hated the competition part.

I like picking up heavy things and putting them down again. I like watching the amount of weight on the bar increase. And I like the feeling of power I get from knowing I'm strong enough to do pretty much anything. But I hated the strict dieting and the process of making weight for each

competition. And I hated how pushy and mean Dad got, especially as time went on, no matter how hard I tried to make him happy.

And here I am realizing that so many of my choices have been more about making my dad happy than anything else.

He wanted me to sign up for strength training. *He* wanted me to compete when I expressed an interest in powerlifting, even though I wasn't really that excited about the competition.

Luke was similar in a lot of ways, now that I think about it. The content of his complaints and nudges were different though. According to him, powerlifting was the inferior strength sport because it lacked the prestige of competing at the Olympics. Which, considering I've never actually cared about competing, didn't really hold much weight with me. But that never stopped Luke from making comments comparing and contrasting powerlifting and Olympic weightlifting at every opportunity, debating bar placement on back squats with me whether I wanted to engage or not.

But with both Luke and my dad, it's always this sideways kind of bullying, where if you call them out on it directly, they act affronted and offended and injured because they were just making observations and statements of fact. And while maybe from someone else that would be true, from them it's always done with the intention of getting me to do what they want.

And to be honest, it works often enough that it keeps them doing it.

Well, not anymore. At least not with Luke. And since I'm several hours away from my dad, that reduces his ability to interfere with my life too.

But the sharp contrast of the guys from my hometown and Eli hits me hard tonight, especially after the way he caught me at the end of my song

...

Why was I ever with such an asshole?

I need to find someone like Eli. Not him, obviously. He doesn't see me that way. We're just friends. I'm just one of the guys. Which is fine, really. As cute as Eli is—and I'd have to be blind not to see that with his warm hazel eyes, his compact and muscular physique, and the cute dimples that flash when he smiles—there's never been any chemistry between us.

When we first met in the gym, I'd kind of hoped ...

He was my gym crush for that first semester. And then we had a biology class together the next semester—which honestly only seemed more

perfect. I'm a biology major with plans to become a physical therapist, and he's a biochem major with plans to either play football or work for a pharmaceutical company like his uncle. Both of us are into science and using it to help people in some capacity. On paper, it seems perfect.

But when we studied together, he never made a move, always friendly, but never flirty.

So I set my crush aside and accepted that we're destined to be great friends. Because he is a great friend.

"How did you know where I was?" I ask after I've managed to get myself under control a little better, the tears deeper beneath the surface, not so close that they might escape if I let my guard down for even a second.

Eli glances at me out of the corner of his eye as he pulls into the parking lot for his apartment complex. "Jackson called me and told me I needed to come down and see you sing." He pauses for a moment, but there's expectation in it, so I wait to see what else he says. "You were pretty amazing up there. I didn't know you could sing like that."

I let out a deprecating chuckle, uncomfortable with the praise. "Thanks."

"I mean it," he insists. "You were great up there."

"Right. Until I got choked up and could barely keep singing. I *know* you were there for that part." It's easier if I criticize myself first, after all. Acknowledging my own mistakes robs other people of the power to make me feel small. Or at least mitigates it somewhat. It's a trick I've learned over the years.

Eli's lush lips press into a firm line. He really does have a nice mouth. Expressive and always ready with a smile. I'm not used to seeing the kind of censure on his face, though—hard mouth, nostrils flaring. At least not directed at me. Sometimes when game play is intense, he gets a similar look. Or when he's frustrated with one of his friends.

I guess I'm just not usually one of the friends he gets frustrated with.

"You don't have to do that, you know. Not with me."

"Do what?"

He pulls into his parking spot and cuts the engine before giving me a look that speaks volumes. But he doesn't answer my question. Not directly, anyway. "Why are you unable to accept a compliment?"

I splutter, holding out my hands. "I can accept a compliment."

Shaking his head slowly, he unbuckles his seatbelt. “No, Dani. You can’t. Not once in the years I’ve known you have you accepted a compliment without pointing out some perceived deficiency on your part, however small. You’re perfectly able to compliment me when you think I deserve it without offering criticism—well, not that you never give criticism, because you definitely do when you think it’s merited. But you’re also capable of giving only compliments. Why aren’t you able to accept them?”

I splutter again and look away, focusing on unbuckling my seatbelt and climbing out of the car as a way to give myself some time and space to come up with a response. I know the answer, of course. Because I’ve never been given unqualified compliments. There’s always a *but* ... And I learned years ago that it stings less when I supply the *but* ... myself.

I’m not sure how to say that out loud, though. Or if I even want to.

Eli climbs out of the car and follows me to his door, reaching past me to unlock the deadbolt, his body so close to mine that he blocks the cold, making the air around me several degrees warmer.

Once we’re inside, he shucks his leather jacket, and I take my time looking him over in his untucked button down, sleeves cuffed at the elbow. He has lovely forearms. I’ve noticed plenty of times before, of course. Capable hands with long fingers, perfect for wrapping around a football. Or a barbell.

Or me.

I blink hard, dispelling that last thought. It’s just the lingering effects of heartbreak and alcohol making me go there. And the way he held me when I clung to him at the end of my song. Eli doesn’t like me. Not like *that*, anyway. He’s my friend. He brought me here because he’s concerned about me. And how could he not be after my near breakdown on stage?

The door of his apartment opens into the dining area. He drops his coat on the back of a chair and moves into the kitchen, pulling down two glasses and filling them with water from the sink. “How much did you have to drink tonight?”

I roll my eyes at his protector role. But he knows I’m a lightweight. I don’t drink often, and when I do, one’s usually my limit.

He hands me one of the glasses of water, keeping his eyes focused on mine, and for some stupid reason, heat rises to my cheeks. “You know me,”

I say, trying to make things lighter. Because they feel really heavy right now. There's a weird tension between us that's never been present before.

He dips his chin in a nod, his throat working as he takes a drink from his own glass. "I do know you. But I also know Autumn."

That has my hackles rising. Autumn's a good friend. Sure, she can be a little out there sometimes, but she's never not been there for any of us when we've needed her. "What's your problem with Autumn?"

Sighing, he sets his glass down on the table and crosses his arms. "I don't have a problem with Autumn. I just know that she likes to ... push at comfort zones. So while I know that you normally only have one drink, and I'm sure Autumn also knows that, she may have convinced you that you needed more than one tonight to cope with ... well, with whatever got you up on that stage singing a breakup song." He raises one dark eyebrow, inviting me to fill in all the blanks.

Rolling my eyes again, I turn and head for the living room. "I had two, *Dad*," I toss over my shoulder. He snorts behind me, almost close enough that I can feel the huff of breath accompanying it.

I flip my hair over my shoulder as I spin and take my usual seat on the couch. "I'm *fine*. We were there long enough, and I had a glass of water between drinks." I'm feeling looser than normal, maybe, a little less reserved. But I'm not *drunk*. Not even close.

Eli hums, settling on the couch as well, leaning forward to set his glass on the coffee table. He turns, propping his arm on the back of the couch, his leg bending and coming up between us. "So what happened?"

CHAPTER THREE

Eli

Dani takes a long moment to answer. Her mouth opens and closes, and she looks down at her glass of water before saying, "Luke and I broke up."

I shift in my seat, unsure exactly how to respond. "Didn't you guys break up a while ago?"

She rolls her eyes and shrugs her shoulders. "Yeah, but you know how we are. We always end up getting back together."

"So what was different this time?"

She clears her throat, and when she speaks her voice is quiet. Small. Vulnerable in a way that I don't know I've ever heard before. It makes me want to pull her close and wrap my arms around her. But she's holding herself stiffly, separate and apart like she doesn't want to be touched.

"He has a new girlfriend. He brought her home for Christmas."

"Ohhhhh." Yikes. That's rough. I want to say something comforting, but I have no idea what to say.

"Ohhhhh," she mimics, rolling her eyes. "Yeah."

I clear my throat and shift closer to her, wishing I could hug her like I did at the bar. She looks up at my movement, her eyes studying mine and taking in my posture. Then she sets her glass on the coffee table and collapses against me.

I settle my arms around her gently, stroking her back.

She lifts her head and looks up at me, her eyes dark pools. Her lips part. Her face is so close to mine. If I bent my head a couple of inches, I could

kiss her.

We stare at each other, her eyes never leaving mine, and time seems to stop, like that moment when you toss up a ball and it's suspended in midair before gravity reasserts itself and it falls once more. When time resumes, my head moves almost of its own accord, and then my lips are on hers.

She barely responds at first. She lets me kiss her, but she's not really kissing me back. I bring one hand under her hair, tilting her head so that I can give her a better kiss. This time when I press my lips to hers, she kisses me back. But only for a second, and then she jerks away.

"Eli!" Her hand flies to her mouth, covering her lips as though to hide them from me. "What are you doing?"

Before I can respond, the front door flies open and Autumn and Jackson enter.

"Hey, guys!" Autumn practically shouts, stumbling through the kitchen and into the living room. "What are you guys doing?"

Dani shoots to her feet, yanking her hand away from her face and balling it into a fist at her side. "Hey, Autumn!"

Her greeting is way too bright, especially considering how we left the karaoke bar, but Autumn's either too drunk to notice or is pretending not to for Dani's sake.

"I knew I'd find you here," Autumn declares, stabbing her finger in the air in Dani's direction. "I'm gonna stay the night here with Jackson. You can drive my car home when you're ready."

Jackson holds out a set of keys that I know must be Autumn's because of the wire wrapped crystal attached to the key chain as well as a couple smaller silver charms.

With a forced smile at Autumn and Jackson, Dani steps forward and retrieves them. "Perfect timing. I was just thinking that I was about ready to go home."

She gives me a tight smile and a finger wave before disappearing into the kitchen. Standing, I follow her, but she doesn't give any of us a second glance before she grabs her jacket and purse and is out the door.

I stand and stare at the closed door for a moment, trying to figure out what just happened.

I mean, I know what happened. I was here, after all.

I kissed her.

I kissed my best friend.
And apparently ruined everything.

* * *

They at least wait until the next morning before they start the interrogation. Autumn comes in and sits down across from me, her hands folded primly on the table like she's sweet and innocent. Her pointed chin and cute nose and her whole airy fairy vibe with her turquoise and pink streaked hair and off the shoulder boho sweater makes her easy to underestimate. But I know she's anything but harmless.

"Soooooooo," she says, drawing out the word. "What happened with you and Dani last night?" She shifts in her chair, bringing one hand under her chin. "I expected her to hang out for a while, but she took off like the demons of hell were after her."

I roll my eyes, hoping I can ignore her. But she just sits there, staring at me, like if she stares at me long enough she can read the answer on my face. I scarf the last of my food, stand, and take my plate to the sink. "Nothing happened," I tell her, even though I know that we both know I'm lying.

I can practically hear Autumn roll her eyes at me in disdain. "So that's what you're going with, huh? Nothing happened? *Clearly* something happened."

Turning, I brace my hands on the counter behind me, staring at Autumn, who's turned in her chair, returning my stare like she doesn't have a care in the world. And knowing Autumn, she probably doesn't.

Sure, she's smart and does well in school, or at least Jackson says she does, and he'd definitely know. She helps out with game nights and keeps things running smoothly, which I definitely appreciate.

That doesn't mean I want her meddling in my personal life.

But then it hits me. The reason she's acting like this. This isn't just her normal meddling. "You know. Dani told you, didn't she?"

"Told me what?" Her faux innocent look doesn't fool me.

"Uh huh." I move to the table and sink into my seat, leaning back, propping one ankle over the opposite knee and crossing my arms. "We're

not going to both play dumb. If you already know what happened, just tell me. If not, I'm not filling in the blanks for you."

"Fine," she huffs, dropping her hands into her lap. "I texted Dani last night to see if she was okay and find out why she was running away from you. She told me you guys kissed."

"That's what she said, huh? That we kissed?"

Autumn stares at me for a moment, as though contemplating how much to reveal. "Well ..." she hedges. "She said that you kissed her."

I stare at Autumn a moment again. "Did she say anything else?"

She props her chin on her hand again, surveying me like I'm a biology specimen pinned to a board. "Is there a reason you're asking me this instead of her?"

I let out a harsh breath. "I texted her last night after she left, but she didn't respond. I don't think she wants to talk to me right now." And until Autumn sat down across from me, I'd been hoping I could just pretend it never happened.

That's my new plan.

After asking Dani if she would talk to me and getting crickets, I've decided to go back to ignoring my insane desire to kiss my best friend. To pretend I don't know the way her lips feel under mine—soft and plush and velvety. To pretend I don't know how she sucks in a shocked breath when I take her by surprise. To pretend that I haven't heard that sound in a thousand other contexts, but now I only ever want to hear it when I kiss her for the rest of my life.

Autumn lets out a thoughtful hum. I raise an eyebrow, but she only shakes her head, her lips pursed, her hands once again layered on top of the table in front of her. "I'd like to give you advice, but I'm not really sure what the best approach here is, to be honest. Dani didn't give me any more than you are right now, so I don't know what she wants." Her chin goes back to her hand, and a small smile tugs at her lips. "Though I'm guessing that since you kissed her, you're hoping for something more than the current arrangement?" Her eyebrows rise up her forehead to illustrate her question, but I remain stoic.

She sighs, shaking her head again without lifting it from her hand. "You're impossible. But regardless, I'm going to tell you what I think." Now she does remove her hand from beneath her head, using it to point at

me instead. “I think you’ve been pining for Dani for a while now.” She cocks her head to one side. “Has it been the whole time you’ve known her?” Her eyes flit around, taking in my face and my body while I keep my expression neutral. “Yeah. Pretty much. Jackson wasn’t sure, but yeah.” She moves her finger up and down, indicating my whole body, though I’m not sure where she thinks she’s getting her answer from, because I haven’t even twitched. I’ll never admit it to her, but she’s not wrong.

Jackson has said she’s basically psychic before. I scoffed, because that’s patently ridiculous.

But maybe it’s not?

Because everything she’s saying now is spot on.

“So you’ve been smitten for how long? When did you meet?” This time she just stares at me, eyes bright, clearly waiting for an answer.

And stupidly, I want to tell her. I shouldn’t. It goes against all of my better judgment, but despite that, I find my gravelly voice admitting, “Freshman year. We met first semester in the weight room, but really got to know each other in our biology class second semester.”

“Ah.” She nods sagely, like it’s all coming together for her. And hell, it might as well be.

Her eyes narrow a fraction, and she leans forward, her mouth opening like she’s about to speak, but she clamps her lips shut and shakes her head, her brow furrowing.

“What?” I demand, the word sounding more like a bark than anything.

She raises her eyes to mine, surprise replacing her thoughtful frown. Then she laughs. More of a chuckle, really, but a laugh all the same. Leaning back in her chair, a half grin on her face, she looks me up and down once more. “You’re in worse shape than I thought.” She waves a hand. “So you’ve been in love with your best friend for years, and obviously she has no clue.”

Obviously. I mean, I’d kinda hoped she’d have at least thought about the possibility of us, even if she was still hung up on that douchebag Luke. And maybe it makes me a shitty friend, but I can’t help but be grateful that I won’t have to keep hearing about him if they’ve actually broken up for good.

About fucking time.

I can't imagine being jerked around like that for years. Letting myself be jerked around like that. Or doing it to anyone else.

What's even the point? Either you want to be with someone or you don't. Or just call it what it is—an ex you still bang when you're both in town.

Who's the one who insisted on the labels? My guess is Dani. That seems like something that might be important for her.

Maybe that's why she was so shocked about our kiss? And ... upset? I'm assuming she was upset since she won't talk to me but has apparently talked to Autumn. Though Autumn never clarified if Dani said anything else ...

"You sure are thinking hard over there," Autumn murmurs.

I snort.

She grins, spreading her hands in front of her. "If you share, I might be able to help you."

"How, exactly, do you think *you* can help me?"

Lifting one shoulder in a shrug, her smile turns coy. "I have my ways. Dani's one of my roommates, after all."

I snort again. "And it's not like you spend a lot of time with her. She's here as much as at your place. For that matter, so are you."

She tilts her head from side to side. "True. But that doesn't mean we don't talk. As evidenced by the fact that she's already filled me in on the events of last night. You don't think having me in your corner could be beneficial?"

My jaw works as I chew on her words. "What are you offering?"

A shrug and another sly smile is all the answer I get.

Knocking my knuckles on the table, I shake my head and stand. "Thanks for the offer, Autumn. But I think I'm okay on my own."

Another shrug as I stand. "Suit yourself," she calls after me as I walk away.

Thanks, Autumn. I think I will.

CHAPTER FOUR

Dani

I wake up the next morning and lie in bed for a while. Even after the press of my bladder forces me out of my cozy cocoon of blankets, I climb back into bed and laze around.

This is unlike me. While I'm not one to hop right out of bed wide awake, I usually only allow myself five or ten minutes of acclimating to waking life before I'm up and getting my day started. There are always plenty of things to do between school, lifting, working, etc.

But my job as Dr. Howard's lackey doesn't start up again until school does, which is still almost a week away. If I were still at my mom's house, like I'm supposed to be, there'd be noise and activity and my mom would've knocked on my door already and told me to come eat breakfast before I missed it entirely, and since making sure I eat enough calories and protein are priorities, missing breakfast is not an option.

Plus, I love breakfast. The only times I skipped was when my dad forced me to cut leading up to a meet. Then I had to do fasted workouts first thing in the morning because he said it maximized fat loss.

Fasted workouts suck donkey balls, though. My energy is always worse and my numbers suffer, which of course prompted lectures about giving it my all no matter what and blah blah blah.

I got really good at tuning those lectures out after a while. Paying attention with half my brain so I could nod and *uh-huh* at appropriate intervals, but largely ignoring everything he said. He'd hired me a coach for

a reason, after all. And my coach never said any of those kinds of things to me. He understood that fasted workouts are never as good as when you've eaten. It's basic biology. Which you'd think my dad would understand, considering it's also common sense and he's worked out and been athletic enough throughout his life, but pushing me to do and be my best was always more important than reality, I guess.

He was disappointed that I didn't follow Luke to Michigan to participate in their programs. He even got me an Olympic lifting coach to see if I would change my focus, or at least add to it. And while it's fun to have some variety, and I still occasionally toss in a few snatches or cleans and jerks into my routine for fun, powerlifting is my favorite hands down. I mostly include the Olympic lifts because it gets a big reaction from the football players I work out with these days.

Which draws my thoughts back to Eli. He loves when I do a clean and jerk, clapping and whooping in the weight room, telling me how awesome it is, then making me give him pointers to try to do it too. He's actually gotten pretty good at it, with his weights overtaking mine now that he's mastered the moves.

He's always been my most supportive friend. Hyping me up at every turn, whether it's with school or in the weight room.

When he showed up last night, I wasn't even surprised at first. He's always there for me when I need him the most. Going home with him felt like the most natural thing in the world.

While I've thought he was cute many times over the years, we've always just been friends. Strictly platonic. It's easy to be friends with a guy when you know he's not attracted to you. I saw the type of girls he goes for when we started studying together and he invited me to hang out with him at game nights and parties.

The girls he hooks up with are flirty. Pretty. Made up. Forward.

Basically, everything I'm not.

I exist in jeans or joggers and sweatshirts most of the year, the summer being the real exception to that. Sometimes I'll rock booty shorts in the gym, but it's mostly leggings and loose tank tops because it's most comfortable, especially in the colder weather. But I don't wear makeup, my hair's almost always in a bushy ponytail or messy bun, and I don't think I know how to flirt to save my life.

Last night, I had on makeup. My hair fell around my shoulders in sexy waves. I didn't even know I could look like that, to be honest.

I spent so much of my teenage years focusing on strength sports and competitions and trying my hardest to make my dad proud—though never quite feeling like I managed it, even when he said he was proud of me—that I skipped over all the usual clothes and makeup and hair care knowledge all the other girls I know seem to have absorbed. Including my younger sister.

But I eschewed all of that, taking pride in the fact that I was Low Maintenance and Not Like Other Girls.

I was One Of The Guys. I've always had guy friends and felt more comfortable with guys than with girls. I never really fit in with any of the girls I knew, even the athletic ones. They were all into team sports and had that sense of camaraderie that develops out of that, while I worked out on my own. No team. Just my dad and my coach and eventually Luke.

Living with Piper helped me turn a corner. She's into football and sports too—though she doesn't lift like me—and she likes to dress up and wear makeup and do her hair. Though she'll rock a messy bun, leggings, and hoodie when she feels like it too.

She's opened my eyes to the reality that there's the possibility of in between. It doesn't have to be all girly makeup and skirts and high heels all the time or never. Getting a house with her plus Autumn and Ellie over the summer only made that more obvious, though I never tried out makeup or doing anything else with my hair. Every time I thought about it, I just felt overwhelmed. Like I missed out on learning all of those things—how to dress up like a girl, how to put on makeup, how to do anything other than brush my hair and put it in a ponytail. Which is why when Autumn insisted on dressing me up for karaoke, I let her.

It was the perfect opportunity to try out all those things I've become more curious about, but don't have the knowledge or confidence to try to pull off on my own.

My hair, though frizzier and flatter, still boasts the waves from last night. I smooth the sheet next to my pillow. Could I make a little change? Start wearing my hair down?

It always gets poofy and bushy when I brush it. But that's what you're supposed to do, right? Brush it? But Autumn only raked her fingers through my hair to get it all going the same direction, smoothed it with what she

called the praying hands technique, and then, in her words, scrunch scrunch scrunched until it formed into waves.

“There,” she said last night, sounding smug and satisfied. “I thought you were hiding waves in that ponytail of yours. Look at you. You’re a goddess.”

Her compliment had made me itchy and uncomfortable. I don’t get complimented on my looks. Smarts, strength, capability, how easygoing and levelheaded and low-maintenance I am, sure. Never, ever my looks. Luke did a few times, but rarely.

Traveling to powerlifting meets—he competed in both powerlifting and Olympic lifting like my dad wanted me to do—we spent so much time together. We got along. He said I looked hot in my singlet, which made me laugh. He also grinned when he said it, but he never took it back. And then he asked me to dinner and a movie and kissed me when he took me home junior year of high school, and we’d been a couple ever since.

Well, until now. Even though we “took breaks” because being long distance was too hard for him—ha—I always thought of us as a couple. Expected us to end up together again eventually.

We were in love.

Or so I thought.

Autumn made a lot of good points, though, while we were at the bar last night. She didn’t tell me what to do or berate me for my choices. That’s not her style. But she asked questions. Uncomfortable questions. Things like, “If he loved you, why didn’t he make some kind of effort to see you between school breaks?” And, “What did you love most about him?”

I didn’t have an answer to the first, opening and closing my mouth and feeling like I needed to defend him like I did so many times over the last two and a half years, but when I started to, Autumn placed her hand on mine and with a soft look in her eyes said, “Dani. It’s not your job to defend him. It never really was, and it sure as hell isn’t now. He didn’t make an effort because he was more important to you than you were to him. His behavior is evidence enough of that.”

That’s when she followed up that gut punch with the question about what I loved most. And I didn’t really have an answer to that one either.

I loved the fact that he seemed to notice me.

We were friends first. I was one of the guys. We'd hang out and have fun and work out together and then competed together. And since everything is divided up by both gender and weight class, we never had to compete against each other. So we could freely cheer each other on no matter what.

But when I decided to go to Marycliff—where my mom graduated from and close to my grandparents—Luke was pissed. He didn't understand why, if I was going so far from home anyway, I wouldn't just follow him to Michigan. If I loved him, I should, right?

Autumn said something similar, actually.

Maybe I always knew somewhere deep down that he didn't love me the way I loved him. And me refusing to follow him, choosing to interview for a scholarship at Marycliff and then taking it when it was offered, was my way of choosing me over anyone else. Maybe for the first time ever. Since my parents divorced right before I turned nine, I've been chasing after my dad's approval. Some tiny part of me thought—hoped—that if I managed to make him proud enough, he'd come back.

It's a ridiculous thing to think. At twenty-one, I can see that now. But it became such a part of my day-to-day existence so early that I never stopped to examine it until I was planning out where to go to college.

It's not like I can make a career out of powerlifting. Or even Olympic lifting. And if I did switch, Dad would push me to try to make the Olympic team. And how would I train for the Olympics and also get good enough grades to get accepted into a physical therapy program after I graduate? Especially when *I* don't even want to go to the Olympics? It would only be to make my dad—and my boyfriend—happy.

And I know that if I made the US Olympic team and Luke didn't, he'd be furious.

So no. No, thank you.

Even so. Even with that kind of red flag present, I still expected to end up with Luke eventually. I'd finish my degrees and return home to Bradford and be a physical therapist. He'd go to the Olympics and come home and do ... something. And we'd be together and happy and have a couple of kids and live the dream life I always thought I wanted.

Now? I'm not so sure.

And my current best guy friend kissing me feels far too much like the start of my relationship with Luke with a heaping helping of him only kissing me because I was dressed up for once added in. With Eli, I'm one of the guys. We work out together. Hang out. Have fun. Play video games. Talk sports.

The big difference is his support has always felt open and honest and genuine. No backhanded compliments or side of criticism that I'd normalized from my dad like Luke gave me. And it's been so refreshing.

But I've never been the kind of girl he'd hook up with—which was fine. Because I'd want more than just a hookup. Especially with him.

Until last night. Apparently dressing up and wearing makeup and doing my hair and, per Autumn, looking like a goddess means that now I am that kind of girl.

And I don't know what to do about that.

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CHAPTER FIVE

Dani

Not long after I finally drag myself out of bed and put on my workout gear, Autumn breezes through the front door.

Her smile is friendly, belying her searching gaze. “Hey. How are you this morning?”

I lean against the kitchen counter and eye her over the rim of my coffee—the caffeine gives a nice boost when working out—trying to decide exactly how much to say.

Autumn settles into a dining room chair, her turquoise hair showing off more of the pink streaks right now with it piled in a messy bun on top of her head. She has on one of Jackson’s Marycliff football sweatshirts, and it looks more like a dress on her, especially with the black leggings peeking out beneath it. Very quintessential football player girlfriend vibe.

Setting my mug down on the counter next to me, I turn it just so before finally answering. “I’m okay, I think.” I pause, and Autumn waits, her chin propped on her hand, seemingly willing to wait as long as necessary for me to continue. Or not. I feel like she’d be okay if that’s as much as I decided to share. “Eli texted earlier. He says we should pretend that last night never happened.”

Autumn gives me no reaction, her expression and posture remaining neutral. After a solid minute of silence has passed, she lifts her chin off her hand and says, “And how do you feel about that?”

I look away, staring blankly at the wall adorned with some kitschy 70s kitchen decor we found at a thrift store that Piper decided we absolutely had to have. I never thought that thrift store shopping to decorate a house would be as much fun as it was, but with Ellie, Autumn, and Piper, we had a blast.

As much as I would enjoy dwelling on those memories, that doesn't answer Autumn's question. And I owe it to myself as much as to her to actually give her an answer. Autumn's good people. She's a good listener, and I've never gone wrong when taking her advice. Given my discombobulated feelings about everything, confiding in her seems like the best bet.

Taking a deep breath, I refocus on her. "I'm not really sure," I admit at last. "I was confused last night. About the kiss. What it might mean. Why he decided to do it at all, and especially why he decided to do it *then*."

She cocks her head to one side. "Why do you think he decided to do it then?"

Another deep breath, and I look away again, crossing my arms even though I'm far too aware that it's a defensive posture. It's not that I feel attacked, *per se*. Not by Autumn, at any rate. It's just that talking through this, even if I'm sure it'll help, makes me feel vulnerable. And vulnerability always makes me want to put up some kind of physical barrier, even if it's just the meager protection of crossed arms.

"Obviously I can't really read his mind," I start slowly. "But I have my suspicions." Shaking my head, I meet Autumn's eyes, hating that there are tears stinging the backs of mine. One shoulder moves in a half shrug, almost without my conscious direction. "You had me all dressed up. I looked like one of the girls he'd usually go for. I think he just got confused."

That actually provokes a reaction from Autumn. Not a large one, of course. That's not Autumn's style, not when she's in her helping friends work through their problems mode, but her eyebrows jump up her forehead. "Oh?"

I wave a hand, as though dissipating smoke or stink from the air. "I'm not blaming you or anything."

That gets another tiny reaction, this time a small smirk. "That's good," she replies drily, "because I wouldn't be accepting that blame anyway."

Snorting, I shake my head again. “Anyway, I’m just saying that he’s never seen me all made up and looking like anything other than”—I gesture up and down my body—“this.”

“And what exactly do you think is wrong with”—Autumn moves her hands up and down in front of her, indicating my body as well—“this?”

I roll my eyes. “Nothing. Absolutely nothing is wrong with my body. But you have to admit, I’m not the most feminine girl on the planet.”

Autumn shrugs. “So?”

“So the girls Eli normally hits on are. And last night I looked much more feminine.”

“Is that a good thing or a bad thing?”

That question stops me in my tracks. I wasn't expecting her to ask that. "I'm not really sure about that either."

"Would you like to try dressing that way again sometime?"

“Yessss.” I draw the word out slowly, testing how it feels as I say it. It’s true, though. I’ve thought about it more and more. Ellie and Piper both have gorgeous straight hair that falls around their shoulders in perfect curtains. Autumn has waves and, with her wild colors, looks like she could be a mermaid.

My ponytail always looks kind of bushy and unkempt, even when it’s freshly brushed. I even thought about getting a flat iron for a hot minute, but then I realized how much work it’d be to flat iron tiny section by tiny section of my long, thick hair. Hard pass. I want my hair to look nicer, but not enough to spend an hour or more doing that to it. I can’t even stand blow drying my hair because it just takes way too long, and I never mastered the brushing technique necessary to make it not look extra frizzy.

But what Autumn did to my hair last night didn’t take a ridiculous amount of time. Sure, it was more than my usual run a brush through it and put it in a ponytail, and we did spend a fair amount of time with the hair dryer, but she used a diffuser, and I ended up with bouncy waves rather than crazy, poofy frizz.

Picking up my coffee, I move to the table and sit across from her. “I’d like to learn how you did my hair last night. Even now, my ponytail looks a lot nicer than normal.”

Autumn beams. “Oh good! I was kinda hoping you’d ask. I’ve been dying to see how much curl your hair really has, but I know you’re not

usually into hair and makeup stuff, so I didn't want to push."

My cheeks heat a little, and I bury my face in my coffee mug to cover my twinge of embarrassment. Autumn's not pointing that out in a mean way. It's an observation with no judgment and also an acknowledgment of personal boundaries. She's noticed I've never bothered with those things, so she's assumed I'm not interested.

"I spent all my time with guys in high school," I mutter after a moment. "They all made fun of girls who spent too much time on their hair and makeup." I roll my eyes. "Of course, they only ever dated those kinds of girls too, so ..." I shrug again as I let the sentence trail off.

Autumn grins. "Yeah. Typical guys. Whatever. I think they're just jealous that we're allowed to care that much about our appearance and it's normal and expected while they have to pretend not to care while caring just as deeply. Plus, they think it makes them look more manly if they shit on 'girl stuff.'" She makes air quotes with her fingers on the last part. "Most guys like when girls go to the effort to dress up and wear makeup, even if they bitch about it. So you really can't win, can you? If you don't do those things, you get shit on for not being girly. If you do, then you get shit on for being girly. So who gives a fuck what they think? If you want to wear makeup and do your hair or whatever, do it for you. If you don't, then don't. If you want to sometimes and not others, that's cool too. Do what makes you happy."

That hits me in a soft and tender place I wasn't expecting. Wasn't even fully aware of, really, and I let out an involuntary grunt.

"I'll send you some links," Autumn continues, "so you can look up the stuff I did on your own time. I'll also send you the names of the products I used. Nothing too over the top. Just a mousse and a lightweight gel. With your waves, you don't want anything super heavy. That'll just weigh them down."

I run a hand lightly over my ponytail. "I feel like it's less frizzy than normal."

She nods. "Yup. They help with that too. Frizz happens. It's not a bad thing. But you can make it a little less all over the place." She waves her hands around her head, and I laugh, which makes her grin. "But back to Eli. Are you okay with pretending the kiss never happened?"

That has the lingering smile dropping from my face. “I guess so.” Finishing my coffee, I stand and move to the sink. “It’s easier, right? To just ignore it? Chalk it up to ...” I wave a hand around, searching for a way to finish that sentence. Nothing comes to me, though. He wasn’t drinking last night, so we can’t blame it on that. I was, but I didn’t make the first move. He did.

“Your hotness?” Autumn supplies, and a laugh splutters out of me. “What?” she protests. “It’s true. You’re smokin’. And you looked amazing last night. Didn’t you think so?”

I bobble my head from side to side. “I guess.”

She scoffs. “Of course you did. You don’t have to be modest with me.”

“Fine. My hotness drew him in, and he couldn’t help but kiss me. But we’re friends. He’s one of my best friends. And I don’t want to screw that up just because he thought I looked prettier than normal last night.”

Autumn holds up a finger. “One, you always look pretty. And two, if you don’t want anything to happen between you, then just continue treating him like you always have. No harm, no foul, right?”

The word foul makes my mind go to football. That was a foul. He moved before the play, as it were. Though I’m not sure I realized we were lining up on any kind of line of scrimmage.

I didn’t even know we were playing a game.

I just thought my friend had come to comfort me after a breakup. And now ...

I’m more confused than ever.

CHAPTER SIX

Eli

Autumn texts me that Dani's headed to the gym, so I toss on some workout clothes and head over there.

She still hasn't returned my text from last night. Or the one I sent this morning.

Did she see them? They said delivered, but she doesn't have read receipts turned on since she's not a psycho. It's possible she shoved her phone in a drawer and ignored it. It's equally possible she's just ignoring me.

And who can blame her?

I royally fucked up.

What the fuck was I thinking? She wasn't giving me signals that she wanted me to kiss her. She was just letting me hug her because she was upset. About a *guy*. A different guy. A guy she's been with for-fucking-ever. Of *course* she'd be upset that he brought some other chick around when they'd always gotten back together when they were both back in Montana before. She probably went home expecting to get laid on the regular for a few weeks by the guy she's got loads of history with and instead went home to a slap in the face.

Nothing signals a relationship is well and truly over like your ex bringing home another woman to meet his family.

Especially if you never really considered him your ex, and I know Dani didn't. She always called him her boyfriend, even when they were

technically on a break.

When I get to the gym, Dani is already in the squat rack. I can tell she's still in her warm-up sets because she doesn't have much weight on the bar. The rack next to her is occupied, so I opt to do chest today. There's an open bench press behind Dani's squat rack, and I toss my towel on the bench and set my water bottle on the floor next to it.

With my eyes on Dani, I begin my mobility drills before starting my warm-up sets. She finishes her set, places the bar on the rack, and begins to change her weight. It's not until she moves to replace the plates on the other side that she finally sees me.

Her eyes widen a fraction, but that's all the reaction she gives me. She lifts her chin in greeting, but doesn't say anything, returning her focus to the iron plates and ignoring me.

Annoyed, I finish my mobility drills and lie back on the bench, doing a set with just the bar to warm up. So she's not going to talk to me? That's the way this is going to go?

My frustration bubbles up as I place weights on the bar for my next warm-up set. Dani continues her workout without acknowledging my presence at all.

Normally we work out together, following similar routines, sharing equipment, and chatting between sets.

I decide to go for a personal record today, even though I'm not even supposed to be working chest right now. And I'm definitely not supposed to be pushing this hard. The season is over. We didn't make it to a bowl game this year. We're supposed to be taking it easy until spring semester starts.

I don't give a shit what my workout plan calls for right now though. I'm too frustrated to take it easy and do half weight sets. I need the challenge to give me somewhere to focus my energy.

I can't decide if I'm more frustrated with myself or with Dani. Obviously I fucked up last night. But can't we just go back to how things always have been? Why does she have to ignore me? Was I really that bad?

If I were a different guy, I might be worried that I was a bad kisser. But I've kissed enough girls and had no complaints, so I'm pretty sure that's not the problem.

As I finish my final warm up set and add more weight to the bar so I can go for my top heavy single, Danny whirls around, trying to murder me with

her glare.

"What do you think you're doing?" she demands.

I shrug in response and continue adjusting the weight on my barbell.

She stomps over to me, her shoulders hunched, her eyes narrowed. Her finger pokes me in the chest, the physical manifestation of an accusation.

"You're going for a PR."

I dip my chin in a nod.

"Without a spotter?"

You'd think I was trying to jump out of a plane without a parachute from the way she says it.

Another shrug. "Yeah. I was leaving off the collars. I can dump the weight if I have to."

She snorts. "You're *such* a dumbass, Eli." She moves around to the head of the bench in the spotter's position. "You think I'm gonna let you do this without spotting you? Seriously?"

Unable to decide if I want to laugh or snarl, I rub a hand over my mouth to hide my warring expressions and study her. Her usual nimbus of frizz surrounds her head. She has on one of her snarky workout tanks today—a black one that says, "Dear Autocorrect, at no point have I ever meant ducking"—and dark green leggings. Her face has been scrubbed free of last night's makeup. This Dani with the ponytail, no makeup, workout clothes, and a fierce expression on her face is the girl I'm used to. The one I fell in love with.

The one who apparently hates me now. But not enough to let me risk stupidly hurting myself.

That's something, I guess.

Provoking her wasn't my plan when I decided to do this today, but I'm not sad about it.

I just give her another shrug, though. "If you want to."

"If you want to," she mimics in the dumb sounding voice she uses when she thinks I'm being an idiot.

I'm grateful that I have to turn my back on her to get in position, because it gives me a second to hide my smile before forcing it off my face.

Ignoring the fact that she's the source of my frustration—or at least one of the sources—I lie back, place my hands on the bar, set my feet, then lift my ass. Dani helps me get the bar off the pins, balanced above my face.

Back arched, I bring my ass back to the bench, breathe out, then pull in a deep breath, brace my abs, and lower the bar to my chest. With my gaze focused on a spot on the ceiling, I'm peripherally aware of the position of the bar and Dani's hands hovering nearby, ready to help if I get stuck.

The bar touches my chest, and I push it away again to return to the starting position. There's a moment, a half a second, where the bar pauses on its path, and I grunt with the effort of getting past the sticking point. But I make it. My arms straighten, the bar back between my eyes and the ceiling.

Dani lets out a whoop behind my head, then her hands are on the bar, guiding it back to rest on the pins again.

When I get up from the bench, she throws her arms around me. "You did it! Eli! You just got a new personal record!"

I hug her back, enjoying the return to normalcy and the way her body feels pressed against mine. It's different than last night, since we're in a gym dressed in workout clothes and she's got her tits strapped down in a sports bra, but this is what I'd really like to have. With her. All the time.

Easy affection, supporting each other, and kissing. Is that really so ridiculous?

But if her reaction last night is any indication, yeah, apparently it is.

"Alright," she says, pulling away. "I need to finish my workout. Good job, man." She holds up a hand for a high five, and I give her one. "Proud of you."

"Thanks, D." I grin, hopeful that maybe we can return to normal. I still feel like we need to clear the air, though. "When you're done, can we grab a snack or something? And talk?"

Her expression immediately shutters. "What do you want to talk about?"

I busy myself with the weight plates so I don't have to look her in the eyes. "I just want to clear the air. About last night."

"That's not necessary." Her words are clipped. Rushed. Like they're stumbling over themselves to get out of her mouth.

Uh-oh. That's really not a good sign. Maybe I was premature in my thinking we could get back to normal so easily.

She takes a step back. "I just ... I need a minute, you know? I can't ..." She looks away, her eyes blinking rapidly.

Shit, did I make her cry?

“Dani—” I reach out a hand, but she steps back, farther out of reach. I let my hand drop back at my side, my fist clenching in frustration.

When she looks at me again, the naked pain there has me sucking in a breath. “Right. Okay. You need a minute. Well, I’ll ... I’ll go, then. Let me know when you want to hang out again.”

I don’t even bother wiping down my bench. I can’t. I have to get out of here right now, because apparently me being here is making Dani want to cry, and that’s the last thing in the world I want.

Motherfucking hell. How did I manage to fuck everything up so badly and so fast?

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CHAPTER SEVEN

Dani

It's been almost a week since I talked to Eli. I think this might be the longest we've gone without speaking in ... maybe ever? Even in the early days of our friendship, we saw each other in the weight room several times a week and would talk there. Since we started hanging out, we've talked almost every day. Summer break and Christmas time being the only exceptions, and even then there's usually only a day or two where we don't at least text and check in with each other.

God, he's been more like a boyfriend than my actual boyfriend all this time.

That thought stops me in my tracks. Literally. I'm walking from my car to the grocery store, and I stop in the middle of the parking lot.

Eli's been acting like my boyfriend. For years.

Is that why he kissed me the other night?

Was it not about me looking pretty for once and more about me suddenly being actually available?

But ...

Wouldn't he have said something? Anything? Ever?

This isn't the first time Luke and I have broken up. It's not like it was the only opportunity Eli's had to try to actually be my boyfriend if that's what he wanted.

Shaking my head, I resume walking, my mind still whirling as I grab a cart and head down the aisles, grabbing food almost on autopilot.

I feel shitty for shutting out Eli for the last six days. Especially when it was clear he wanted to talk at the gym last week.

But I didn't have it in me to hear what he wanted to say, no matter what it was.

There were really only two options: *I really like you and want to kiss you more* or, *I'm sorry I kissed you. Let's just be friends.*

The first one, on the surface, sounds really nice. Who doesn't want to be wanted? But given the nature of our first kiss, I'd always wonder at the back of my mind if that's what he really wants more of. More of the girl who does her makeup and dresses up and knows how to do her hair. Because even if I'm interested in learning more about those things, I don't actually know any of them right now, and I don't want to feel pressured to do it more just for a guy.

The second one, well ... that's the one I have my money on, if I'm honest. And after such a recent rejection, I don't have the strength to be rejected like that again.

So I've taken the coward's way out and just ... ghosted, basically. Which is shitty. I know it's shitty. I need to have a conversation with Eli. It's just that it gets harder to initiate that contact with each passing day.

But apparently the universe has decided to solve the problem for me, because I turn into the produce aisle and nearly collide with Eli.

His face lights up at the sight of me in a way that makes my heart squeeze. And then he shuts down again just as quickly, which makes my heart hurt.

"Hey." He offers the simple greeting in the same way you'd approach a strange dog. Gently edging closer, hand out, voice soft to show that you're a friend.

"Hey," I return just as softly. "Sorry about—"

He waves a hand, cutting off my apology. "No need to apologize. Things have been a little ... strange." He gives me a small smile. "How are you doing?"

"Alright."

He eyes my cart. It's about half full of paper towels—it's my turn to supply those—plus most of the produce for my meal plan this week. I still need to hit the dairy and meat aisles, plus a couple treats. Ellie and Piper got back yesterday, and I told Ellie I'd grab some of the creamer she likes. "Are

you almost done with your shopping? Would you ... I mean, can we finish shopping together?"

"Yeah." It comes out strangely hoarse, so I clear my throat. "Sure. Yeah. That would be nice."

I hate this. I hate how awkward I feel around him now. And while I can blame him for some of it—he kissed *me*, after all—the fact that I've been avoiding him for a week is part of the reason for it, and that's all on me.

Reaching past him, I grab a bunch of carrots and a few other veggies. I need to hit the freezer section for a few more things since there are slim pickings for fresh veggies in January. Or at least ones that taste decent and weren't shipped from halfway around the world.

Eli falls in step with me and follows me around the store, grabbing groceries from his list as we go. For a second it almost feels like old times. We've gone grocery shopping together a ton. Eli's a bit of a foodie, and every so often he'd get a wild idea to make something and off we'd go to the store.

He cracks a few jokes, and I force myself to smile and laugh like normal, then follow him through the store for his last few items before we head to the checkstands.

He's all smiles and flirting with the middle-aged cashier, which I know is his default, but for some reason it really irks me.

Like how dare he have the audacity to kiss me last week and then flirt with another woman in front of me today?

I know he's not actually hitting on the cashier. He's being his usual self. This is how he is with everyone, which is why I thought he was flirting with me when we first met. Until it became abundantly clear that this is just his default setting, and actual flirting with him involves much more touching. And kissing.

Which is what makes last week so confusing. He barely touched me. At least not the way I see him touch other girls he's trying to hook up with, and when he did, it was well within the bounds of our normal relationship. But then he kissed me.

Why did he kiss me?

What does it mean?

Does it mean anything?

Do I even want it to mean anything?

Yes ... no ... I don't know.

And then he texted that he wanted to pretend it never happened!

I don't even have to open my phone to read it. The text is burned into my brain.

Eli: Sorry I kissed you. Can we just pretend it didn't happen?

How am I supposed to react to that?!

So here we are in this awkward dance. I was afraid to talk to him last week after the gym because I worried it would ruin our friendship. And here I am, ruining our friendship anyway.

Uggghhhhh.

After Eli pays, he stands at the end of the checkstand, leaning on his shopping cart full of grocery bags. I'm entirely conscious of his eyes on me as I interact with the cashier.

Once I've paid, I follow him outside, keeping my eyes on his back clad in a red hooded sweatshirt and black puffy vest and resolutely away from the way his joggers mold to his round, tight ass.

I've spent way too much time staring at that ass in the gym the last few years. It's hard not to when he's right in front of me doing squats or deadlifts. All the football players have delicious booties. That's one of my favorite parts of working out with them.

Now, I'd never admit that out loud to anyone. Not even my roommates.

The automatic doors open, allowing in a whoosh of frosty air as we head into the night. There are patches of snow here and there where it got piled up around the edges of the parking lot and sidewalks, but it hasn't snowed in a couple of weeks at least. It's cold tonight, though, with frost showing on the edges of the windows and sparkling under the streetlights.

Eli turns to face me, shoving one hand into his pocket and clearing his throat.

I reflexively clear my throat as well. "Well, um, it was good bumping into you."

He ducks his head in a quick nod. "Yeah, it was. I've missed you, D."

Warmth fills my middle at his nickname for me. It's not much of a nickname, really. But he's the only one who's ever called me that, and it's

always made me feel special.

“I’ve missed you too,” I confess. “I’m sorry for ...”

He shakes his head. “I already told you no apologies. I do wish we could go back to normal, though? Is that ... is that possible?”

My throat feels clogged, and I clear it again as I nod. “Yeah. Sure. Of course. I’d like that too.” I think. I mean, yeah. I want to be able to hang with Eli again and not have it be awkward. But some part of me wants him to kiss me again too. Just ... not when I’m all dressed up. I want him to kiss me because we’re curled on his couch and watching a movie and the moment is right. Or I’m over playing video games and I win, so he gives me a celebratory kiss that maybe turns into ... more.

But I don’t want to just be a hookup for him. And I’m not sure Eli wants more than that with anyone. And I’m afraid that asking about that would put us back into Awkwardville. Since we’re just stepping away from there, I don’t want to risk pushing us back to that place again.

Eli greets my agreement with a relieved smile. “Good. I’m so glad. I was—” He waves away whatever he was going to say. “I didn’t want to lose you, Dani.” Stepping around the carts, he wraps me in a hug. I bury my face in his sweatshirt, breathing in the mix of spice and clean laundry he always smells like when he’s freshly showered.

“I’ll call you,” he says as he releases me. “Game night is starting again next week. I expect you to be there.”

“Alright,” I agree with an easy smile. “I’ll be there.”

* * *

Eli and I resume texting, but things still aren’t quite back to normal. When my roommates inform me that Dylan Thompson, the second string safety, is hosting a Spring Semester Kickoff Party on Saturday night, I’m unaccountably anxious.

It’s ridiculous to be anxious. I’ve been to a million of these parties. And for the last year or so, I’ve shown up with Piper and Autumn and Ellie. We usually arrive as a group but go our separate ways. Ellie and Piper started dating football players last year, though their boyfriends have since graduated, so they usually stick together and have fun with whoever’s

around. Autumn, of course, pairs off with Jackson for the most part. I usually end up either hanging with Eli or going home by myself.

I guess that's the hangup, though, isn't it?

Always before, I was equally okay with either of those options for ending the night. If I were having a rough time, Eli would forego a hookup to spend time with me and make me feel better.

... and there I go again realizing he acted more like a boyfriend than just a friend all along, didn't he?

Anyway. Tonight I don't know which option I like better. Both seem bad for different reasons.

If I end up hanging with Eli here or at his place at the end of the night, I worry he might try to kiss me again. Or that he won't. Both of those things seem equally bad.

And if I go home alone because he's hooking up with someone else, well ... that would hurt my feelings.

Even now, just thinking about it, jealousy rises inside me like a sick wave.

But it also means that he never would've wanted more from me than a hookup. After he rescued me from my karaoke debacle, he was probably just horny and caught up in the moment.

It pisses me off, though. Because if he hadn't done that, we wouldn't be in this situation. I wouldn't wonder why he kissed me. I wouldn't have to worry about what our every interaction has ever meant.

Gah!

But we agreed to go back to normal, so that means going to the party.

"Hey!" There's a quick knock, and then Autumn's head pokes through my cracked open door. "You getting ready?"

I glance down at my joggers and threadbare hoodie. "Uhh ..."

Autumn laughs, tossing her mermaid hair over her shoulder as she fully enters my room, surveying me with her hands on her hips. "Do you want to go to Dylan's party looking like that? Or do you want to dress up a little?"

"Wait, what?" Ellie, who was apparently walking by, backs up so she can peer through my open doorway. "Dani's dressing up?" Her face brightens, and she claps her hands. "Are we giving her a makeover?"

"She can hear you," I put in sarcastically.

Ellie wrinkles her nose and grins. "Obviously. So are we?"

I glance at Autumn, who raises her eyebrows, inviting me to make a decision. "It's up to you," she adds. "I can take Ellie if she tries to pressure you. But if you want to, we'll help."

"We?"

Bouncing on her toes, Ellie has her hands clasped under her chin. "Piper will want to be involved too, of course. She's the master at that girly-sporty combo. You definitely want her help."

And this is why I love my friends, even if they can be overwhelming at times. They're excited to help me, but only if I want their help and only as far as I'm willing to go. Girly-sporty could work for me. Isn't that kinda the best of both worlds? And Ellie's right. Piper's awesome at pulling that off. If anyone could help me create a new style that still fits my personality, it would be her.

"Okay," I say slowly, holding up a hand when Ellie lets out a shrill squeal of excitement. "Nothing too crazy, though."

Her short brown ponytail flies back and forth as she shakes her head. "No, no, of course not. Piper!" She stands half out of the doorway. "Piper! Get to Dani's room now!"

"Oh my god, Ellie," Piper grumbles seconds later. "I'm right here. The house isn't that big. You don't need to shout loud enough for everyone across town to hear you."

Ellie's not deterred in the slightest by Piper's good-natured scolding. "Dani's going to let us dress her up for the party tonight."

Piper's eyes go wide, and a smile stretches across her face. Crossing her arms, she looks me up and down. "Oh yeah? Are you really?"

Lifting one shoulder in a half shrug, I scoot to the edge of my bed and stand. "I let Autumn dress me up a couple of weeks ago. It was kinda fun. Figure I might as well try it again."

Ellie and Piper start talking over each other, asking too many questions and making a million comments about how they wish they could've been there for that, but at least they're here now and on and on until Autumn claps her hands sharply.

"Right. If we're all going to get ready in time, we need to get started. Dani, go get in the shower. I'm assuming you're good with me styling your hair again?" At my nod, she gently pushes me toward the door. "Go shower. Leave your outfit to us."

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CHAPTER EIGHT

Eli

Jackson and I go to Dylan's place together. His family has money, so he lives in a swanky condo downtown. He doesn't even have a roommate, though he let Gardner crash with him for a while last year when he was having trouble finding a place to live.

I think Dylan prefers to live on his own, though. I can't blame him. Jackson and I get along great, but it would be nice to have my own place. It's just a lot more expensive to rent a one-bedroom than to split the rent on a two-bedroom. At least Jackson's not a pig. Miller and Weaver, for example, are disgusting. They try to host parties sometimes, and I never stay long, because it's just too gross for me.

Maybe living with Jackson has rubbed off on me, because I don't remember being this fastidious in high school. Though my parents made me keep a certain level of cleanliness in my room even then. I'm not as organized as Jackson by any stretch, and I don't mind leaving my clean clothes in laundry baskets for days, but I definitely prefer not to live in unrelenting chaos.

It's still funny to me that he ended up with Autumn, though. Because she is the living embodiment of chaos.

Speaking of, she's the first person who greets us once we're in Dylan's apartment. A wide smile on her face, her wavy turquoise hair French braided over one ear and held back with a jeweled pin on the other side, she

reaches us first, pressing on her toes and pulling Jackson's face to hers for a kiss.

Even though it's been months, some part of me is still surprised that my shy, blushing roommate is now okay with PDA.

But he wraps his arms around her and kisses her back, even going so far as to lift her off the ground so that she picks her feet up, her sparkly flats glinting in the low light. Yeah, my little boy's all grown up now.

Since Autumn's here, that means her entourage, including Dani, is likely nearby. I scan the open-concept apartment, taking stock of the cluster of people near one wall but quickly looking past it. Dani doesn't hang with the crowds. Usually I can find her curled up in the corner of the couch or on an out-of-the-way chair if she beats me to one of these.

My quick scan turns up nothing, though, prompting me to step farther into the living area and take a closer look at the seating. Ellie and Piper are perched on the end of a couch chatting with some other girls. But Dani's not with them. I scan the couch more closely, then the loveseat and armchair grouping ... but no Dani anywhere I'd expect her to be. Maybe she's in the bathroom?

Brow furrowed, I turn back to find Autumn smirking at me with her arm hooked around Jackson's waist, and from the placement of his arm, his hand is likely in the back pocket of her jeans. Suppressing the urge to sigh, I focus on Autumn, narrowing my eyes at her knowing smirk.

"Did Dani come with you guys?" I ask, despite hating myself for needing to. Shouldn't Dani have texted me if she wasn't going to come? We agreed on going back to normal. Normal Dani and Eli interactions include letting the other know if we're skipping an event we'd usually attend.

Of course, even though we bumped into each other at the store that night, things really haven't been all the way back to normal. Our conversations are stilted, lacking the easiness we've had from the beginning.

"Yeah, she's here," Autumn says, the smirk as evident in her voice as on her face.

I scowl at her. I can't help it.

She just laughs, because apparently my reaction is hilarious. Then she gestures toward the cluster of people by one wall. "She's over there."

Turning my head, I aim my scowl at the group by the wall. Half the team appears to be clustered there. She's in the mix?

"Where?" I demand.

Another laugh from Autumn, and I glance back to see Jackson trying to hide a smile in the top of her head. "Probably in the middle. She's causing quite a stir."

"What the hell does that mean?" But I'm moving toward the group without waiting for an answer. Autumn appears to take my question as rhetorical, because she doesn't try to answer anyway.

I'm stuck on the outside edges, trying to see what's going on, and that's when I hear Dani's voice. She's currently analyzing Dylan's performance this last season. And the guys are eating it up like nachos and ice cream at the end-of-season free-for-all once we can relax our meal plans for the off season. They react in a chorus of "Oooohs" at a particularly scathing point from Dani.

"Me next!" crows one of the starters from this season—Murphy, one of the tailbacks.

Dani laughs, throaty and low. "I think I need another drink if I'm going to keep this up." And the guys shift, all vying to be the one to get her a drink, and that's when I finally see her.

She has her hair in sexy waves again, like she did that night at the karaoke bar. Her makeup draws attention to her eyes. It's subtle—a slight shimmer on her eyelids and I'm not sure what else exactly because I'm no makeup pro, but it turns up the volume on her natural features, making them more striking, attention-grabbing in a way that doesn't slap you in the face. Unless, like me, you're so used to looking at her bare face that the fact she's wearing makeup is immediately obvious.

Even her lips are pinker. Plumper. Juicy.

Dear god, *juicy*? Did I really just think of my best friend's lips as juicy?

Yes. I did. As juicy as her ass looks in the formfitting mini skirt and wedge heels. What's she doing wearing those at this time of year? Does she want to slip and fall on the ice?

And don't even get me started on her top with its plunging neckline displaying her luscious tits that I'm sure have all these assholes salivating.

They might be acting like they're gathered around her for the football commentary, but let's be honest. She's turned herself into eye candy.

Before she can get far, I reach out my hand for her cup. “Let me get you something. What are you drinking?”

Water. She’s drinking water. Because she absolutely doesn’t need any alcohol with these dicks trying to get in her panties.

Is she even wearing any under that skirt? Dammit, she better be.

Jealousy pumps through my blood, harsh and savage. I want nothing more than to grab the coat I left at the entrance, wrap it around her, and hustle her out of here.

But that’s definitely not within the bounds of our normal friendship. Regular Eli would never do that to regular Dani.

But regular Dani would NOT dress like this!

Still. I’m not such an idiot as to think she’d respond favorably to me demanding she cover up and leave.

Dani’s eyes widen when they clash with mine. “Eli,” she says, her voice sounding breathless in a way that has my blood rushing to my cock. I can’t count how many times I’ve dreamed of hearing my name in her voice like that. Except the circumstances were entirely different. There were far fewer people around, for one. Like, zero besides us. And far fewer clothes too.

Clenching my jaw, I make a grabby motion toward her cup. “I’ll get you some water.”

Her brow furrows. “I actually wanted to try the hard cider Dylan was telling me about. He said it’s kiwi strawberry. That sounds good.”

All I do is grunt, because fuck that noise. She doesn’t need some girly sounding cider that she’ll probably suck down like juice and then fall into bed with whoever’s nearby—Dylan, probably. If he’s the one telling her about the drink choices, it’s likely that he’s planning on sticking to her ass like glue all night.

“I can get my own drink,” she says, her voice noticeably cooler. But I’m not going to be shaken off that easily.

I follow her to the breakfast bar where Dylan has mixers and liquor on the counter plus an assortment of beers and, apparently, hard ciders. She grabs one, but I take it from her before she can find a bottle opener.

“Hey!” she protests.

“Dani. Come on. What are you even doing?”

She crosses her arms and looks me up and down. I try my best to keep my eyes on her face and not let them dip to where her posture has her tits

smashed together and pushed up like she's presenting them for inspection, because I *know* she absolutely isn't doing that. But I can't help it. My eyes betray me, dipping for a glance followed by a longer, lingering look.

"Oh my god," she huffs, throwing her arms in the air. "You're as bad as they are!" She thrusts her arm to the side, indicating the group of guys she just extricated herself from.

"What are you even doing with them?" I crowd closer, hating how accusing I sound but unable to stop myself. "And looking like that?"

Her chin tips up, defiance in every inch of her body—and lord help me, I'm noticing so many things about her body. "Looking like what, exactly?"

There's clear warning in her tone, and I know I need to tread carefully. Tearing my eyes from her, I shove a hand through my hair and clear my throat. "Please. You know what I mean. Looking like *that*."

"No, Eli. I'm afraid I don't know what you mean. What exactly do I look like?"

"Like ... like ..." Both hands are in my hair now, gripping it in frustration. "Like a *girl*!"

I know as soon as the words leave my mouth that it's absolutely the wrong thing to say. But I'm not sure if there was any chance of there being a right thing to say.

Her face closes down. Completely. I've never seen her look so stony.

"I see," she says quietly. "And what, precisely, do I look like the rest of the time?"

I make a variety of strangled noises before finally stammering out, "That's not what I meant." In response, she arches one perfectly manicured eyebrow. The question plain. *What did you mean then?*

Taking a deep breath, I do my best to calm the raging storm of jealousy and frustration I'm experiencing. "Come on, Dani," I return just as quietly. "You know you don't usually dress like this. And you have to know that's why you're getting the kind of reaction you are."

She nods slowly, and I breathe a sigh of relief.

"Right. The reaction where I learn my best friend is actually a misogynist asshole."

Apparently my relief was too soon. "What?" My eyes practically bug out of my head. "How am I the asshole? And a misogynist?"

Scoffing, she shakes her head. “Honestly, Eli, I expected as much from Dylan and his crew. But I thought better of you. I thought that my *best friend* would have my back. Support me. See me for me, regardless of what I’m wearing.”

“What do you mean?” I interject. “I do!”

She shakes her head again. “Obviously not. Or else we wouldn’t be having this conversation. I shouldn’t be surprised, though, should I? Not after karaoke night. You saw me dressed up, realized I was a girl, tried to get in my pants, and when I didn’t go for it, you decided we should just ‘pretend it never happened.’” She makes sarcastic air quotes around the last bit.

I splutter some more. “I thought that’s what you wanted!”

Stepping in closer until I could easily kiss her again—and my dumbass dick perks up, thinking maybe she’ll kiss me this time—but with fury stamped on her face, she hisses, “I wanted a friend who’s not an idiot. Who doesn’t see me as ‘one of the guys’ for our entire relationship and then the one time I dress up like a girl—as you so eloquently put it—you try to put the moves on me. There is no pretending it never happened. Because it *did* happen. And it means something, whether you want to admit it or not. Either you’re an asshole who only thinks with his dick just like the majority of your teammates and kissing me really meant nothing to you once you finally saw me as just another pussy, or you’re an asshole who’s too afraid to mean it because it might backfire.”

She steps back. “Whichever it is, just own it. Quit pretending like we’re just friends, though. Because obviously we aren’t. Not anymore.”

With that parting shot, she walks away. I watch her make her way to Autumn, who’s now on the couch with Jackson, and bend to talk to her. And fuck me, her skirt rides up enough that I can *almost* see if she’s wearing panties tonight or not.

Autumn shoots a glare at me as Dani moves away. But I’m not in the mood to deal with Autumn tonight.

Instead, I turn back to the array of drinks next to me, grab the bottle of tequila and a cup, give myself a heavy pour and a squeeze of lime and down it like water.

If I’m well and truly fucked—which I clearly am—I might as well do what I can to numb the pain. At least for tonight.

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CHAPTER NINE

Dani

Furious, I stomp into the night, angry at everything. At my stupid heels. At my eyes prickling with tears. At the cold wind blowing right up my tiny skirt.

But most of all at Eli.

Some best friend he turns out to be.

How is it that I've lost both the guy I always expected to end up with and the guy who I'd inadvertently made my stand-in boyfriend in the space of a month?

What the fuck is happening with my life right now?

I make my way to Autumn's car, grateful that she let me take it. I promised I'd come back and pick her up if she wanted, but she waved me off and said she was sure she could find her way home somehow.

Whatever Eli's problem is with her, she's always been a good friend to me. To all of us, really.

God, do I just have terrible taste in guys all around? First Luke and now Eli? Or are all guys just raging assholes and there's no such thing as choosing a good one?

Climbing into her yellow Camry, I sniff loudly as I put the key in the ignition. I really don't want to cry. I *hate* crying. But I'm not sure I'm going to be able to keep this one down no matter how hard I try.

Fucking Eli, with his fucking moody glares. He looked hot, actually, and at first I was happy to see him. I'd stupidly thought he was going to

rescue me from the frothing group of football players who suddenly realized I have tits.

Instead, he made me feel like a whore for showing up at a party looking like a girl. Not just a girl, but a *girl*, said like it's the most offensive thing I could possibly be. As though I'm not actually a girl anyway.

And what's wrong with being a girl? What's wrong with *me* being a girl? Why are other girls allowed to be girls, but when I actually look like one, it's this astonishing, stupefying thing?

Not astonishing and stupefying in a good way, mind you. Astonishing in the same way as if a bear showed up at your door and asked to be invited in for tea.

Angry tears leak from my eyes, and I swipe them away, frustrated at myself and the whole stupid night.

I should've known better. I should've known that I wouldn't be able to show up at a party dressed up like this without everyone noticing. And not just noticing, but commenting and acting like the world's turned upside down.

I guess it has, though, hasn't it?

In what world would I, a dedicated joggers and sweatshirt enthusiast, show up in public with my hair styled, wearing makeup and skimpy clothes?

Is this what a quarter-life crisis feels like? I mean, it's a few years early, but ...

With a grunt, I sniff, blink away the tears still trying to escape, and head home.

* * *

The next morning I wake up with eyes gritty and puffy from crying. I drowned my sorrows in Ben & Jerry's Phish Food ice cream that I picked up at a gas station on the way home while watching some old rom-com on Netflix.

Too bad real life doesn't turn out like nineties teen movies where the girl gets a makeover, everyone thinks she's stunning, and she gets the guy in the end.

In real life, you let your friends give you a makeover, your best guy friend turns into a giant douchecanoe, and everyone else acts like you've grown a second head.

Rolling out of bed, I pull on a sweatshirt over my pjs of boxers and a tank top and add a pair of fuzzy socks to keep my feet warm on this chilly January day. No one was home yet when I dragged myself to bed to cry over my pathetic mess of a life, and I don't know if anyone will be here now.

Ellie's in the kitchen pouring herself some coffee when I get there. She turns at my entrance and gives me a smile, her eyes full of sympathy. "Hey. How're you feeling?"

I lift one shoulder, not quite trusting myself to give voice to anything right now. I might just start blubbering again. The tears are still unpleasantly close to the surface. And while I'm consciously aware that Ellie wouldn't judge me for crying and would, in fact, offer sympathy and support, the lifetime prohibition against crying in front of anyone is hard to overcome.

Crying makes you weak. At least that was the message I always received, especially from my dad, whose approval meant everything to me. Especially after my parents split. He left. And I think in some part of my poor ten-year-old mind, I thought that if I tried hard enough, became what he wanted, that maybe he would come back. That he would miss me enough to fix whatever went wrong.

Of course that didn't actually work. And while I know that my parents' divorce isn't anything I could've ever fixed *now*, that didn't stop little kid me from trying.

"Coffee?" Ellie asks, holding up the coffee pot.

I muster up a wan smile. "Please." At least I can manage that much.

She grabs another mug from the cabinet and fills it for me, setting it in front of me before claiming the adjacent chair with her own mug. Hers is a light caramel color, because she takes it with copious amounts of creamer.

I taught myself to drink it black, because calories. I will sometimes splurge on a latte, though.

Ellie examines me as she sips her coffee, then wraps both hands around the mug. "So last night was ... uh, something."

Shaking my head, I offer another smile. “We really don’t have to do this, Ellie.”

I like Ellie. She’s kind and sweet and funny. But she and I aren’t that close. Piper and I are probably the closest, just because we lived together in the dorms and got to know each other when she was going through her phase where she pretended to be a loner and only studied and went to class. Before she met Cal, who’s Ellie’s brother, and now one of the backup quarterbacks for the Colorado Bison.

It’s crazy to me that I know two pro football players. That I live with the girlfriends of two pro football players, actually, because Ellie’s still dating Simon, the former left tackle at Marycliff University who got drafted by the Georgia Rebels. Piper’s brother is playing pro ball too, but I didn’t really spend as much time with him as I did with Cal and Simon. They came to the game nights at Eli’s because Piper came with me. Then when she started dating Cal, she became better friends with Ellie, who started coming too and brought Simon and Autumn into the mix.

And now ... it looks like they’ll all get to continue going, especially since Autumn is dating Jackson, Eli’s roommate. And I’ll be the odd one out. Because after last night, I don’t think I can handle going to game nights again.

Ugh, I’m going to have to change my workout schedule too. I don’t want to see Eli at the gym anymore.

“What’s that face?” Ellie asks.

Rolling my eyes, I shake my head. “Just realizing some things.”

She leans her chin on her hand. “Such as?”

This time my smile’s a little more genuine. “You’re not going to let this go, are you?”

“Nope.” She lays her hand on the table. “Look, I know you and I aren’t the best of friends or anything. But I do care about you. And obviously something went down last night. I only got the half-overheard thirdhand version from Autumn, so I’m not really clear about what happened. I just know you left very early and now you look like you spent half the night crying. If you want to talk about it, I’m here, okay?”

Ellie’s kind words have a fresh wave of tears rising, and I duck my head, embarrassed at the ridiculousness of my own emotions. Blinking

rapidly, I clear my throat a few times and then sip my coffee. “Where are Piper and Autumn?”

“Autumn stayed the night at Jackson’s, and Piper was going to get in the shower. Would you rather talk to one of them?”

Honestly? Kinda. But I don’t really want to talk to anyone, so I shake my head.

Ellie gives me another sympathetic look. “Boy trouble?”

I snort. “Yeah. You could say that.”

“Well, I’m pretty familiar with boys. I grew up with an exceptionally dumb one.” She leans forward and lowers her voice. “Don’t tell Piper I said that, though. She’d get pissed. But let’s be real, Cal’s no genius. Even if Piper’s too blinded by love to see it.”

That makes me laugh, and judging by Ellie’s satisfied smile that she unsuccessfully tries to hide behind her mug, that’s exactly what she was going for.

“Are all guys just dumb?” I ask before I can think better of it.

Ellie squints one eye and stares into the middle distance, her face screwed up in thought. “Hmmm. Well, Simon’s not that dumb.”

I give her a doubtful look. “Or are you just too blinded by love to see it?”

Laughing, she lifts her mug in a toast. “Touché.” After taking another sip, she sets her mug in front of her and studies me again. “Is there a particular guy who’s being dumb right now?” Before I can do more than contemplate the idea of responding, she asks, “It’s Eli, isn’t it?” Her eyes sparkle. “Did something happen between you?”

I narrow my eyes at her. “Has Autumn been gossiping about me?”

Ellie’s mouth drops open in shock. “Autumn? She’s the farthest thing from a gossip.” Her gaze drops to her mug and she spins it around. “But she may have enlisted Piper’s and my help ...”

“Help with what exactly.”

She waves a hand airily. “Oh you know, nothing big. But she mentioned that she suspected there was something between you and him”—she cuts her eyes to me—“something more than friendship, I mean, and that if we saw the opportunity to ... help things along, we should take it.”

Sitting back in my chair, I let my hands fall to my lap. “And is that what this is? You ‘helping things along,’ as you put it?”

Ellie's eyes go wide. "No! This is me being a concerned friend. You're obviously upset about something. Sometimes it helps to talk it through and get some outside perspective."

All I can do is hum noncommittally, not sure how I feel about Autumn apparently making me her new project. Last semester, Jackson was her project. And I know she credits herself with the success of all the relationships in our circle, or at least having a hand in helping them along.

Now she's decided I'm the one who needs helping?

Standing, I take my mug to the sink. "I appreciate the offer, Ellie. I'll keep it in mind if I decide I need someone to talk to." And with that, I head back to my room. That seems like the safest place to be right now.

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CHAPTER TEN

Eli

I let out a groan when I come into the kitchen to find Autumn sitting at the table, her eyes lighting up as I walk in.

“Just the person I wanted to see,” she says in a voice that’s far too chipper for my current mood.

“Oh god,” I mutter, and Jackson throws me a sympathetic smile before handing me a mug. “What do you want, Autumn?”

“I’m glad you asked, Eli,” and she sounds like she means every word. She *is* glad I asked. Because she’s impervious to my bad attitude and bad mood. “I want to help you.”

“And if I don’t want your help?”

I ask the question with my back turned, but she waits for me to turn and face her before she says, “Too bad.”

That makes me splutter out an unexpected laugh. “Too bad?”

She nods decisively. “Yes. Too bad. You clearly need my help, whether you want it or not.”

Despite myself, my curiosity is piqued. “Help with what, exactly?”

Autumn scoffs and throws her hands in the air. “With Dani, of course. I’m not sure exactly what you did last night, but it’s clear you royally fucked up. So you’re going to sit down”—she pats the table in front of the spot adjacent to her—“and fill me in on what happened last night, and then we’ll brainstorm a way for you to fix it.”

“And why would I do that?”

She rolls her eyes. “Because you’re in love with Dani and have been for years. And she clearly cares about you too. Otherwise she wouldn’t have been so upset by whatever happened last night. But, no offense, you don’t seem to have any clue what to do to move your relationship from where it’s been to where you want it to be. And all you seem to be capable of is blowing things up in your face.”

“And you think that you can make it so I stop doing that?”

Her eyes narrow, and she shifts her mouth to one side, cocking her head and looking me over. “I can’t make any guarantees, but I have a feeling I’m your best shot.”

“She’s right, you know,” Jackson chimes in from his spot propping up the counter next to me. “You definitely need help, and Autumn’s your best chance.”

“Why her, though?” I know it sounds bitchy to ask that, especially right in front of her.

“Why not her?” Jackson counters. “She lives with Dani, so she’s got an in. She’s a chick, so she understands how chicks are. She’s actually really good at figuring people out. And for some reason I really don’t understand, she’s decided she wants to help you.”

I furrow my brow on that last one. “Why shouldn’t she want to help me?”

Jackson guffaws, and I hear Autumn laugh too, though I don’t look her way. “Dude. Seriously? You haven’t exactly been that nice to her.” He shakes his head. “And anyway, you were just questioning why she should help you a second ago. And now you’re questioning why she wouldn’t want to? Are you even listening to yourself?”

Crossing my arms, I harrumph, annoyed that he’s right. About all of it. I haven’t been that nice to Autumn, even though I’d like to think I’ve been more tolerant of her since they officially started dating. Though now that I think about it, who wants to just be tolerated?

I take the spot Autumn indicated, folding my hands on the table in front of me and facing Autumn. “I’m sorry I’ve been a dick to you.” Because let’s face it, I really have. “There was no reason for it, and I’d like to think I’m a better person than that, though my behavior obviously doesn’t reflect that. You make Jackson happy, and that counts for a lot in my book.”

Autumn studies me for a moment, her pixie face still and solemn for the moment. "You know," she starts thoughtfully, "apologies only work when they're accompanied by a change in behavior."

Just as solemn, I nod once. "I understand." This chick really doesn't pull any punches, does she? Somehow that makes me respect her more already.

She cocks an eyebrow as though waiting for me to continue. I return her even stare, then it dawns on me what she must be waiting for. "Autumn, will you please help me?"

Autumn purses her lips as though considering my request. Seriously? She's acting like she's not going to help me now?

After a moment, her lips pull wide in a shit-eating grin. She reaches across the space between us and shoves at my arm. "Of course I'll help you, Eli. What do you think I've been trying to do all along?"

I blow out a breath. "So what's my first step?"

She narrows her eyes and looks at the space over my shoulder, considering my question. "Hmmm. Fill me in on what happened last night first."

Burying my face in my hands, I shake my head. "I was a jackass."

Jackson snorts, and Autumn laughs. "Yeah," she says wryly, "I kind of figured that out on my own."

"Of course you did." I drop my hands to the table but can't bring myself to meet her eyes. "I was jealous. I didn't like the way all those guys were gathered around her, drooling over her like she's just another jersey chaser. She's Dani. *My Dani.*"

"Meaning you're the only one who gets to drool over her?"

That has my gaze jerking to Autumn's. Jackson snorts again from his place behind me. Whipping my head around, I glare at him. "If you're not going to be helpful, fuck off."

Jackson widens his eyes in surprise. "I'm not sure that's your call."

Autumn chuckles again, patting the table to draw my attention back to her. "Ignore Jackson. And anyway, you can't complain too much given the way you treated him over me."

I grunt, unwilling to acknowledge that she's right. But also unwilling to insist on my way. I've been enough of an asshole to everyone, the whole point is to stop. That's why she said verbal apologies aren't enough, right?

To let me know that I need to put in the effort to make things right, not just with her and Jackson, but also with Dani.

"Why does your teammates drooling over Dani upset you so much?"

My brow furrows, my frustration mounting. "I already explained that. I don't want her to be treated like she's just another jersey chaser. She's smart. She's dedicated. She's so much more than some chick who just wants to fuck a football player."

"And what about me?" Autumn asks, her voice deceptively innocent. "Did I deserve to be treated like just another jersey chaser?"

I clear my throat, well aware that her question is a trap. "No," I rasp. "You didn't."

Leaning her chin on her hand, she asks, "And what about the other girls?"

"What other girls?"

She spreads her hands in front of her. "Any other girls. *All* other girls. Are there any girls who deserve to be treated like just another jersey chaser?"

"Ummm. Well..." I hem and haw, considering her question. Do any girls deserve to be treated like just another jersey chaser?

Before I can answer, Autumn poses another question. "And what if a girl wants boys to look at her? To drool over her? What if she's dressing that way on purpose to get attention?"

My brows pull together again. "Would Dani do that though?"

"Why wouldn't she? She's single. She's gorgeous. While she doesn't often dress to provoke attention, she's experienced some major changes in her life lately. Maybe she's wanting to try something new. Maybe she's wanting to break out of her shell. She's always had a boyfriend before. Even when they weren't actively dating, she still considered him her boyfriend. But now?" She spreads her hands in front of her again. "Now things between her and Luke are well and truly over. Maybe she wants to find out what she's been missing all this time."

I slump in my seat, not really excited about the idea of Dani wanting to find out what she's been missing. Especially when that exploration doesn't seem to include me.

Autumn leans her chin on her hand again, a small smile tugging at her lips. "Are you wishing that she realized *you* are what she's been missing all

this time?"

All I can do is grunt. We both know that's what I want. Otherwise why would we even be here having this conversation? But I know I can't say that out loud. Not to Autumn. Not right now when she's actually offering to help me. And not after I just apologized for being a jerk to her. I have to actively not be a jerk if I want her to keep helping me.

Her smile grows wider, and she lets her hand fall back to the table. "Alright, so you want Dani to consider you as a potential romantic partner."

I nod.

"And all you've managed to do so far is alienate her."

I nod again like she asked a question even though she's just listing facts at this point.

She taps her finger on her pursed lips, staring into the middle distance once again. "So we need to come up with a way for her to not only forgive you, but also realize that you're what she really wants."

"That about sums it up," I quip.

Autumn skewers me with a look. "Don't be glib," she scolds.

"Sorry," I mutter.

She drops her hands on the table. "All right, let me think about this for a bit. I'll let you know when I've come up with a plan." Without another word, she stands, reaches for Jackson, and they leave the room hand in hand.

I stare after them, wondering what I've just agreed to. And hoping that this won't just make everything worse.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Dani

"Come in!" I yell in response to the knock on my door.

Autumn's head pokes through the doorway, and she gives me a friendly smile. "Hey! How are you feeling today?"

Letting my phone fall to the side and my head loll to look at her, I raise my eyebrows. "How do I look like I'm feeling?"

Cocking her head to one side, Autumn examines me with narrowed eyes. Then she shrugs. "You look like someone wallowing who doesn't usually wallow." She steps through the door and closes it behind her, her turquoise-and-pink streaked hair still piled on top of her head in a messy bun.

I push myself to sitting and circle the air in front of her. "How do you do that?"

Her eyebrows jump. "Do what?"

"Your hair. How do you get it to do that and stay that way?"

She grins at me again. "Are we giving Dani another makeover?"

Scoffing, I shake my head. "I hardly consider a ridiculously high messy bun to be much of a makeover, do you? Considering my signature style is a ponytail?"

Her grin doesn't budge, and she lifts one shoulder. "It's still a change from your usual. Here, I'll show you." Reaching up, she frees her hair, letting it fall around her shoulders in waves. She fluffs her hair with her fingers close to her scalp, and I watch semi-amazed at how easy this is for

her. Like walking or snapping her fingers. Something easy that she's been doing forever.

Whenever I do my hair, even my signature ponytail, I still feel like an awkward idiot. Like I'm missing some fundamental thing where it comes to the typical feminine pursuits of self care. I mean, don't get me wrong, I know the basics. I can brush all the tangles from my hair, I know how to shampoo and condition and shave without cutting myself. But even my ponytail often takes a few tries to get smooth, without wonky bumps here and there sticking out around my head. And don't even get me started on the baby hairs that twist around and half the time look like devil horns.

Bending at the waist, Autumn flips all her hair upside down and starts gathering it. Once she has it secured in one hand, she turns right side up again as she twists it, wrapping her hair around itself then securing it with the hair tie stored on her wrist. "Ta-da!" she says with a little flourish.

She doesn't seem bothered by the fact that her hair isn't smooth along her scalp. That she has frizz in a halo around her head.

"Huh."

She lifts one eyebrow. "Huh, what?"

"Well ..." I shake my head. "I just ... when you do it, it looks effortless and sexy. But I feel like when my hair is loose and bumpy like yours, I just look frumpy and messy."

That irrepressible grin takes over her face again. "That, I think, is a matter of perception. But also, my hair is wavy. It doesn't like to do the straight hair thing where it's all sleek and flat against my skull." Her eyes narrow. "Yours is wavy too, with a few curls here and there if you do it right. I bet your hair doesn't like to do that either." Another shrug. "It's easier to just accept your hair texture and work with it instead of against it. It doesn't like to lie flat? Stop trying to make it. Plus, I use these coily hair ties, and they're just not as tight as the rubber band style. They don't leave a ponytail bump, which is another plus, and it's really hard to get a smooth ponytail with one, so I don't bother to try anymore. I have an extra if you want to try it."

"Oh, I—"

But before I can finish my protest, Autumn holds up a hand and cuts me off. "Be right back."

She slips out the door, leaving me blinking at the cheap wood, wondering what in the world is going on.

When she comes back, entering again after drumming her nails on the door to alert me to her return, she crosses to the bed and sets the clear circle that looks like an old school telephone cord on my knee. "Here. Give it a try sometime. You'll thank me later, I promise."

Chuckling, I pick it up and set it on my nightstand so I don't lose it. "Alright. Thanks, Autumn."

She sits on the foot of my bed, her face serious as she looks me over. "Seriously, though. You were really upset last night. Do you want to talk about it?"

I let out a heavy sigh that has Autumn's eyebrows climbing her forehead in surprise again. Waving a hand, I shake my head. "Sorry. It's just that Ellie tried to drag the story out of me this morning too. No, I don't actually want to talk about it." I mean why would I want to talk about the fact that my best friend basically treated me like a whore? A stupid, diseased whore that he doesn't want corrupting his friends, no less.

"You know," Autumn says, smoothing her hand over my blanket and tracking its progress with her eyes, "I stayed the night with Jackson last night."

"Uh-huh. Ellie mentioned that this morning."

Autumn glances at me. "I spoke to Eli."

My gut churns. "Neat."

Her eyes meet mine, and there's something like amusement on her face. But why would she be amused? Autumn's not usually one to indulge in schadenfreude or take pleasure in someone else's discomfort. "Neat?" she repeats on a chuckle.

I blow out a breath and shake my head. "If he asked you to apologize to me—"

She shakes her head, cutting me off again. "No. He didn't ask me to convey any messages to you."

"Oh. Well. Okay, then." Somehow that disappoints me. I'd been all ready to pull my righteous anger around me again like a cloak. If she were here trying to talk to me on Eli's behalf, I could stay mad at him for longer.

As it is, I'm starting to miss him. Even as I can't get over what a bonehead he really is after all.

I miss what we had. What we were. But that all went poof as soon as he kissed me that night. And no amount of pretending can make time reverse and things go back to how they were.

Add in last night's nonsense?

Am I really about to lose my entire social life? Because up until now, it's all revolved around the football team, more or less. Between Eli and my roommates who are all involved with football players ... I won't be able to go to game nights or any of the football parties. Not anymore. Not with Eli being such an absolute douchenozzle.

And for what? What purpose does his behavior serve at all? It doesn't benefit him. It doesn't benefit me. It doesn't benefit *anyone*. I just don't get it. At all.

"Do you want him to send messages through me?" Autumn asks, breaking into my thoughts.

"No," I answer immediately. I don't.

Autumn doesn't seem to buy it, though, with another of her patented expressions of disbelief—pursed lips, eyebrow arching high over one eye. "Are you sure about that?"

Sighing, I shake my head. "Yes. Positive. I don't want you to be the intermediary. I don't want us to even need an intermediary."

Autumn hums thoughtfully, propping herself up with one hand. "What do you want?"

I throw my hands up in the air. "I want things to be how they used to be!" It comes out more forcefully than I meant, my frustration getting the better of me. "How dare he?" I toss my blankets back and climb off the bed, needing to move. "How dare he kiss me? How dare he then suggest we pretend it didn't happen? Like it meant nothing! Like *I* mean nothing! And *then*. To compound everything, to treat me like he did last night? Like I was just there to taunt and titillate? Like I didn't have every right to be there? Like I wasn't *invited*?"

Watching me placidly, Autumn idly kicks one rainbow sock clad foot, bouncing it off the leg of the bed. "Did you kiss him back?"

"What?" I jerk around, blinking hard.

"Did you kiss him back? That night after karaoke. You said he kissed you. But did you respond?"

My mouth drops open, and I blink rapidly. "Uh, I, uh, um, I think so?"

“You only think so?”

Tearing my eyes from Autumn, I think back to that night. We were sitting on the couch. I was telling him about Luke. Then he scooted closer, and I leaned in for a hug. When I looked up at him, he kissed me. Did I kiss him back?

“Not at first,” I say slowly. “But yeah, I did.”

Autumn looks thoughtful. “Hmm. Who ended the kiss?”

“Me.” That part I remember very clearly. When I realized I was *kissing Eli*, I flinched away like his lips were made of lava or he had venomous spit or something.

“Was it a gentle separation?”

An unintentionally sarcastic laugh slips out of me. “No.”

“I see.”

I look at Autumn again. “What do you see?”

She tilts her head side to side like she’s debating what or how much of what she sees to share with me. “I think he felt rejected.”

“What?”

Leaning forward, her eyes bore into mine. “Think about it. Put yourself in his shoes. He worked up the guts to kiss you, something I suspect he’s been wanting to do for a long time, and you A—didn’t respond immediately and B—when you finally did respond, you ended it by jerking away. Jackson and I walked in immediately after that, right?” At my nod, she nods too. “Right. And then you took off like Hades had just released Cerberus to drag you back to the Underworld and wouldn’t return his texts for the rest of the night.”

She thinks Eli has been wanting to kiss me for quite a while? Why in the world would she think that? I think back over our years of friendship to see if I can find any merit in her assertion. But Eli has always treated me like one of the guys. Like a buddy. He’s never ever reacted to me the way I’ve seen him treat other girls—girls that he’s actually interested in. Not until he took me home from karaoke night anyway.

“What makes you say he’s wanted to kiss me for years?”

Autumn laughs. “Are you serious right now?”

My head jerks back. “Of course I’m serious. Why wouldn’t I be?”

Autumn’s laughter dies as she examines me closely. “Oh my god, you really are serious.”

"Of course I'm serious," I repeat. "Eli and I have been friends for years. Just friends. He's never looked at me like a romantic interest. Much less a sexual conquest. Not until he saw me dressed up like a *girl*." I put all the horrified emphasis on the word *girl* that he did last night.

Wrinkling her nose, Autumn looks me up and down. "Why do you say it like that?"

"That's how Eli said it to me last night. He asked me why I looked like a girl. Like looking like a girl, much less actually being a girl, was a terrible thing. I'm not sure if it's a terrible thing in general, or just a terrible thing for me."

"Oh, Dani." Autumn rises from the bed, her face a mask of sympathy. "I can't believe he said that to you. I can't believe he'd make you feel that way. Being a girl is awesome. And the fact that he made you feel less than for embodying your divine femininity makes me want to punch him in the throat."

The ferocity of her statement surprises a laugh out of me. "Autumn! I can't believe you'd say something like that. Aren't you usually all about love and light?"

"Never forget that light can also blind." She stands with one hand on her cocked hip, the picture of taking no shit from anyone.

"Look at you. Who knew there was a fighter beneath all that hippie disguise."

Autumn laughs. "Disguise, huh? And here I thought it was just a fashion statement."

I join Autumn's laughter. It feels good to laugh, especially after the drama and frustration of the last day.

With both hands on her hips, Autumn looks me over again. "But what are we going to do about Eli?"

"Who says we have to do anything?"

CHAPTER TWELVE

Eli

"Well?" I ask as soon as Autumn walks in the door with Jackson.

She drops Jackson's hand and crosses her arms over her chest, one hip cocked to the side. Her cool gaze takes me in, dissecting me like a bug under a magnifying glass. "You said that you don't want her to look like a girl?"

"What?" I ignore the prepubescent shrieky quality to my question. "I never said that!"

Autumn arches one eyebrow in response. "Are you sure about that? Because Dani says that you said her looking like a girl was bad for some reason. Would you care to elaborate on that?"

I might have dug myself a shallow grave, but I'm not so stupid that I don't realize this question is a trap. "I have no idea what you're talking about." Denial seems like my best option.

Shaking her head, Autumn lifts one finger and wags it back and forth as well. "No no no. Here's what we're not going to do. We're not going to play dumb. And we're not going to pretend like we don't know what I'm talking about. You got jealous about the attention Dani received from your teammates. You followed her to the drinks and then you made her feel badly about how she dressed that night. She said that you said she looked like a girl as though being a girl was the worst possible thing in the world. Her biggest question was whether being a girl was bad in general, or if it was just bad for her."

My mouth opens and closes. I know I probably look like a fish. But I have no idea how to respond to that. "It's not—it's not—I don't think being a girl is bad. For anyone. Not you. Not Dani. Not any of the girls I know. I love girls."

Autumn scoffs. "Please. Do you know how many misogynist assholes claim they love women? Oh, they *loooooove* women. Women are their favorites. They especially love poking their dicks inside of women's warm, welcoming orifices. Are you that kind of asshole, Eli? Are you a misogynist? I mean, I know I'm not your favorite person. But I really thought better of you than that. One of your best friends is a girl. Or maybe I should say *was* a girl. Because I'm not so sure you can claim Dani as a best friend anymore. Or at least I'm pretty sure she doesn't consider you one."

Autumn's words hit me like a punch to the gut. Or worse. Like a defensive tackle taking me out. A piledrive shoulder pad straight to the gut. "Dani doesn't consider me a friend anymore?"

Lifting one shoulder in a shrug, Autumn examines her fingernails. "Can you blame her?"

I mean ... I have been pretty awful to her lately. I guess I can't really blame her if she doesn't consider me a friend anymore. It still hurts, though. I miss her. I miss our friendship. I miss hanging out with her, talking to her, listening to her. I just miss her.

Collapsing into a dining room chair, I bury my face in my hands. "Is there anything I can do? Or does she hate me forever?"

I hear another chair's legs scraping the floor. Then Autumn's warm hand rests on my shoulder. "I don't think she hates you. I'm not so sure she likes you very much right now, but I don't think she hates you. I think she misses you. And I think she's really sad that someone she considered her best friend seems to resent the fact that she's female. I think that if you have any hope of recovery, you'll need to grovel. A lot."

It's not a lot, but there's at least a little bit of hope in that statement. I grab onto it with both hands. "Grovel? How exactly?"

Autumn ruffles my hair then pats my shoulder before withdrawing her hand. "Well," she says thoughtfully, "how serious are you?"

I raise my head to meet her eyes. "About which part?"

“Do you just want your friend back? Or do you want her to be your girlfriend?”

“Will that change our plan?”

“Oh, yeah,” Autumn laughs. “It definitely, definitely changes our plans.”

I swallow hard. “Do you think I have a chance at getting her to be my girlfriend?”

Pursing her lips and tilting her head to the side, Autumn considers my question. “I can't say for sure. But I will say that she admitted to kissing you back. And I can tell that she still cares about you. I also think that this is probably your only chance. So if this is what you really want, now's the time to go for it. You've already fucked up your friendship anyway. You might as well go for what you've always wanted.”

“You really know how to get a guy's hopes up, don't you?” I mutter. Sarcasm aside, she makes very valid points. Things with Dani will never be the same no matter what I do. I've had a crush on her for years. I've never been brave enough to do anything about it. One could make the argument that as soon as I did try to change our relationship, everything fell apart. However, I moved too early. The play was not fully set. The ball was not in motion. I committed an offside foul. This—this hell of my own making—is my penalty.

“I'm not here to get your hopes up.” I didn't actually expect Autumn to respond to my snark. But I guess I shouldn't be surprised that she did. “You asked for my help. I wouldn't be helping you if I gave you false hope or bad advice.”

Narrowing my eyes, I look her over. She returns my gaze evenly. “You never did say why you want to help me.”

“Is there a question in there?”

I bark out a laugh. “Why are you even helping me, Autumn? You've said several times that you know you're not my favorite person. So why even offer to help me at all?”

Her mouth moves from side to side like she's swishing her answer before spitting it out. Finally she shrugs. “I like Dani. I think she's a cool chick. And I think she deserves to be happy. And for whatever misguided reason, I think being with you would make her happy.”

Deciding to ignore the misguided reason bit, I focus on the fact that Autumn thinks I'll make Dani happy. All I've ever wanted is to make her happy. So I'll do whatever it takes to make that happen. Even if it means groveling.

"So what's the plan?"

I head to the biology lab, a gift card for a major makeup store burning a hole in my pocket. I'm about to implement phase one of my plan to win over Dani. Right now, groveling will consist of showering Dani with gifts. All of those gifts need to show that number one, I view her as a woman. And number two, that I support her exploring what Autumn refers to as her divine femininity.

I feel like Dani would laugh her ass off if I said the words "divine femininity" to her face. Autumn uses that term with a straight face, but I don't think I can manage it.

Nevertheless, I'm giving Dani this gift card. Autumn assures me that Dani is exploring makeup and hair care products, and that this will show her that I support her finding this new part of herself. Clearly, this was Autumn's idea.

I can't say I disagree with it, though. She's probably onto something.

And it's not like I don't support her desire to do whatever she wants. Obviously I do. I just don't think she *needs* these things. There's nothing wrong with the way she looked or dressed before. I've always thought Dani was hot. One of my favorite parts about working out with her is predicting which leggings she would wear on any given day.

Deadlift day in the warm months is my favorite. She always wears old-school running shorts with the little white trim and everything and white knee socks with colorful stripes at the top. Sometimes they're red stripes, sometimes they're blue stripes. It's always fun to see what color she's chosen. And she usually matches either her shorts or her top. She looks like she belongs in one of those super old magazine spreads from when Arnold Schwarzenegger was a competitive bodybuilder. I think that might be my favorite outfit of hers ever. It's ridiculously cute, and it shows off her legs and ass in the best way.

Of course she can't dress that way all the time. It's too cold in January for one thing. And she did look hot in the mini skirts and low-cut tops Autumn dressed her in for karaoke night and that party the other day. She's stunning with her hair and makeup done. But she's gorgeous no matter what she wears.

I just need to make it obvious to her that I feel that way. According to Autumn, Dani has no clue that I have feelings for her. Apparently even our kiss didn't fill in those blanks for her. I guess she thought I only saw her as another groupie or something. And everyone knows that you don't have serious long-term relationships with groupies. Including Dani.

I didn't see her as a groupie, though. I saw her as available for the first time since I've known her. I've spent the last two days since talking to Autumn kicking myself for jumping the gun with that kiss. I should've gone about things entirely differently. I should've asked her out on a date. Or at least just talked to her and told her how I felt and asked if maybe she felt the same way.

Or maybe that would've blown up in my face just as badly. From the sounds of it, Dani has never seen me as a potential romantic partner.

My heart races as I enter the classroom, standing in the doorway to see if Dani's arrived yet. We usually sit next to each other, but if she's pissed at me, will she have switched seats? Or will she have told someone to take my regular seat?

Both of our spots are open, and I don't see her anywhere else. With a sinking feeling, I realize there's a third option—she might just not show up.

What'll I do if that happens? I need to give her this gift card. And I need to do it somewhere I can talk to her for at least a few minutes to give some kind of explanation ... though I still haven't quite figured out exactly what I want to say. I know for sure I want to offer to take her shopping. And ... I dunno. Tell her I appreciate her? Or that I want her to look however she wants? And do whatever she wants? But also without making it seem like my approval should matter at all, because Autumn made it very, very, very clear that any such implication, intentional or otherwise, would mean my death.

I'm still not entirely sure if *she's* the one who'd kill me or if she meant Dani would do the honors. It's actually possible she meant they'd team up and do it together.

As I'm ruminating over the possibilities of my demise at the hands of my best friend and her roommate, Dani arrives.

The elephant on my chest finally moves, and I draw in a deep breath, watching as Dani stares at her usual seat and bites her lip, then scans the room, obviously contemplating if she wants to sit next to me or risk irritating someone else by stealing their spot.

No, seats aren't assigned. But we all know that where you sit is pretty much set in stone by the end of the first week of classes. We're still early enough in the semester that it wouldn't cause too much drama for her to change things up now, but it wouldn't be drama free, either.

Her shoulders slump, then she draws in a breath and pulls them back as though steeling herself before crossing the room to the seat next to mine.

Where she puts her things down and pretends I don't exist.

Greeeeat.

* * *

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CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Dani

I swear I can feel Eli's eyes boring into me the entire class.

I shouldn't have sat here. I should've risked the wrath of the Lisas and taken one of their seats. At this point, we're all bio and biochem majors in these classes. We all know each other. And we all sit next to the same people in approximately the same areas of the classroom. The Lisas started sitting together our freshman year when they hit it off, first bonding over their shared name, and then their shared interest in goth fashion and gaming in addition to biology.

They're nice, actually, and probably would swap seats with me without too much fuss. But I know I'd get cornered with a million questions about what happened between Eli and me that made me move, and soon it would be the gossip of the entire science department.

And I'm not up for dealing with that. Not now. Not on top of everything else that's gone wrong.

But I'm also not up for dealing with Eli. I'm not sure what he expects from me after how he's been acting, but he's not going to get anything.

Forcing myself to ignore the weight of his attention, I keep myself focused on the lecture, typing anything and everything that the professor says and ruthlessly deleting all of the times my nonstop typing swerves into stream of consciousness rambling about Eli and what's his problem anyway?

Delete delete delete delete.

It's a relief when the lecture ends a few minutes early with Dr. Howard clapping his hands together and saying, "Welp, we got through everything fast today. Not a lot of need for questions if you understand it all already, amiright?" Booming chuckle. "See you next time."

In the metallic clicking of laptops shut, bag zippers opening and closing, and the general shuffling of humans and their various objects, I don't hear Eli approach. Or maybe my determined ignoring of him prevents me from noticing until I glance up and jump in shock, because he's standing right in front of my desk, between me and the back of the seat in front of me.

He gives me a boyish grin, his hands shoved into the pockets of his joggers. "Hey. Got a minute?"

"Uhhh ..." He knows I don't have a class after this. We often grab a coffee together now. Is that what he's expecting? "Um ..." I hem. Stellar work, D. You're acing this prevarication and escape thing.

"Look," he interjects before I can cobble together any kind of convincing lie, "I know you're mad at me. And you have every right to be. I've been a complete dick, and I'm really sorry." He bends a little at the knees, catching my eyes with his warm brown ones, radiating sincerity and what appears to be genuine remorse. "Truly. I won't make excuses for my behavior, because there really are none. You're the coolest chick I know, and I shouldn't have ever done or said anything to make you think I feel any differently."

His cheeks are turning pink the longer he talks, and that has me sitting back in my seat and taking notice more than even his words. It's a good apology, I'll give him that much. I'm not quite ready to forgive and forget, but it's softening me toward the idea at least.

But why is he embarrassed?

"Um, I, uh, I got you something." He's lowered his voice, and his eyes dart around the room.

I cock my head to the side, my eyebrows raising in question. From his reaction, I'm scrolling through a zillion guesses, each worse than the last. Did he get me ... like ... a sex toy?

No, surely not.

But ... why else would he be so embarrassed?

His hand comes out of his pocket, and he drops something on the desk in front of me. It's a pink paperboard envelope with the name of a beauty

store emblazoned across it. I glance at him, my forehead wrinkled in confusion, then open the envelope to find a fifty dollar gift card inside.

Wide-eyed, I look up at him again. He scratches his cheek. “Uh, well, um, I’ve noticed that you’re”—he gestures at me with one hand—“y’know, like, uh, doing some different stuff. With your look. I thought if you wanted to keep experimenting or whatever ...” He shrugs one shoulder. “That might help. I could, um, take you. One night this week or over the weekend. Or whenever. Just let me know.”

Carefully, I fold the envelope closed around the gift card and hold it in both hands, blinking at Eli. “You ... want to take me shopping? For ... makeup?”

“Yeah. Or, like, hair stuff? I mean, whatever you want. Or need. Or ...” Another jerk of a shrug. “Sorry. I feel like an idiot. I just ... I l—” He clears his throat. “I like you. You’re one of my best friends. I know you had a rough breakup, and I managed to make everything worse. I’d like the chance to make it better.”

I bite the inside of my cheek and look down at the gift card in my hands, my mind catching on the stuttered L sound that he ... corrected? ... to like. Or is that what he meant to say? And he’s feeling choked up? That’s why he stopped and cleared his throat?

“Um, I’m not quite sure what to say,” I manage after a moment. “Thanks? I mean, genuinely, thank you, both for the apology and the gift card.” Standing from my seat, I sling my backpack over my shoulder and hold up the card. “You really didn’t have to do that, but I appreciate the thought.” He stares at me hopefully, and I feel a little bad for not just trying to go back to normal and saying, *Hey, let’s grab a coffee*. But I can’t do that. Not yet. Maybe not ever. I really don’t know. And this, while nice, doesn’t actually clarify anything for me.

He steps back and points at the card. “Yeah, sure. Of course. You’re welcome. And, um, just let me know when you want to go. Okay?”

“Umm ...” I nod. “Yeah. Okay.” I don’t know if I mean it, but I feel like saying anything else would just drag this out for longer, and I need to get out of here.

He flashes a quick grin, relief coming over his features. “Good. Great. I look forward to it.”

I stand in the middle of the classroom as he moves to the door, holding up a hand to wave goodbye before exiting. With a wan smile on my face, I wave back, then stare at the gift card again.

What the fuck am I supposed to do with this? And if I were going to go shopping for makeup, why would I bring a *guy*?

* * *

I'm sitting on the couch reading for my World Lit class tomorrow when Autumn gets home.

Her face lights up when she sees me. "Dani! How was your day?"

"Good." I mark my place in my textbook with my finger, somewhat surprised by her enthusiastic reaction to seeing me. Not that Autumn isn't enthusiastic to see me at other times, it's just that this feels ... different, somehow. And I'm not sure exactly how or why. "How are you?"

She grins, setting her crossbody bag on the floor and toeing off her Ugg boots before claiming her spot in the armchair and tucking her legs under her, fuzzy socks in muted rainbow colors covering her feet. Even I know that Ugg boots aren't particularly fashionable. Somehow Autumn makes it work, though, with her dedication to cozy chic—chunky, oversized sweaters, scarfs in every color, fingerless mitts that she wears in and out of the house, plus the boots. In the spring and summer she favors long, dangly earrings, but she dials that back in the winter to simple drops and hoops, I'm guessing because the long chandelier styles would get caught in her knits.

"I'm great," she says, wrapping her hands around one knee. "You had your bio class today, right?"

I narrow my eyes. "Yees," I say slowly. "Why?"

Her smile turns coy. "No reason. Anything interesting happen?"

Reaching for a pen, I use that to mark my place and set my book aside, placing my feet on the floor and leaning forward. "What do you know, Autumn?"

"Moi?" She even goes so far as to lay a hand on her chest, as though so shocked that I would accuse her of anything. "What makes you think that I know anything?"

I circle my finger in the air in front of her. “Allll of this. You’re being very sus right now. Why would you care at all about my bio class, for one thing? And why would you ever ask if anything interesting happened? You’ve never asked me that before. Not like this anyway. Unless you have reason to believe something interesting was supposed to happen ...”

I’m well aware that Autumn likes to meddle in people’s lives. She says she’s helping. And who knows? Maybe she is actually helpful. But now that I’m the recipient? I’m not sure I like it.

“Autumn.” I put all the command behind her name my father always does when he’s trying to get me to do something. It’s almost always worked on me, after all. “What did you do?”

She waves a hand, as though brushing away my question. Unfortunately, that voice never worked particularly well on my sister, and Autumn is a lot more like Anita than me.

“Oh, nothing,” she says breezily. “But I was at Jackson’s the other day, and Eli said he felt bad about what happened at the party over the weekend, and”—she shrugs—“I may have made a suggestion or two about how he could make it up to you.”

Her bright, mischievous eyes give away that she did more than make a suggestion or two. She’s scheming. And I’m somehow caught in the middle of this.

“You suggested he get me a gift card so I can buy makeup?”

“Maaaaybe.”

I roll my eyes. “You realize that never fools anyone, right?”

She huffs and smacks a hand lightly on the arm of the couch. “You realize you’re picking this apart and ruining the fun, right?”

“How is this fun, though?” I ask, pulling the card out from under my book and brandishing it at her. “Shopping and makeup and stuff has never been my idea of fun.”

“Please. Everyone likes treating themselves. I think you could make it fun if you decided to. Take someone you’ll have fun with and even boring chores can be fun.”

Frowning, I stare at the plastic rectangle in my hand. She does make a good point, actually. Dishes and chores around the house are more entertaining when we all do them together. Usually Piper turns it into some kind of competition where we divide the common areas between us and see

who can finish cleaning the fastest. She has some kind of metric she uses so we all get a similar amount of mess, rather than a similar amount of space. Some spaces get messier than others, after all. Most of the time Piper or I win, but every once in a while Ellie manages to get through her section fastest. I don't think Autumn's ever won. She cleans, still. But she's not so motivated by a competition whose only reward is bragging rights.

"Besides," Autumn puts in, breaking into my thoughts, "you've let me do your hair and makeup twice now in a matter of weeks. You can use that to get some of your own products. I'll help you, either by going with you or making a list of products you might want if you decide to take ... someone else." The last bit is accompanied by an eyebrow wiggle, Autumn's version of a wink and a nudge.

"Ha. And what 'someone else' might you be referring to?" I ask, my voice dripping with feigned innocence.

Smirking, she shakes her head. "I'm sure Eli offered."

"Because that was part of the suggestion, I'm assuming."

Autumn sits up straight, her tone prim. "I can neither confirm nor deny anything."

"Uh-huh. That might as well be a written and signed confession."

She says nothing, just stares at me with that same mischievous expression, her lips pressed firmly together.

Sighing, I look at the card again. "You think I should go with Eli?"

She shrugs.

"He wouldn't know what I should get, though."

Another shrug. "I offered to make you a list," she reminds me softly.

"True." I contemplate that for a moment, then raise my eyes to hers again. "What would you do? If you were me, if your best guy friend had treated you the way Eli's treated me, how would you respond to this?" I hold up the card again.

She opens her mouth, sucking in a breath to answer, then her eyebrows crimp and she deflates, her mouth closing. Her brow still furrowed, she props her chin on her fist and looks me over. "You know? I don't really know."

With a sharp laugh, I stand, my book in one hand, the card in the other. "Thanks, Autumn. Glad you cleared that up for me." Shaking my head, I go to my room. I need to think on my own to figure out what I should do.

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CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Eli

My phone rings, and I'm swamped by a mixture of surprise and relief propelled by a chaser of adrenaline when I see Dani's name on the screen. It's funny that she's calling me. We usually just text. Wait, does that mean this might be bad?

Idiot, idiot, I chastise myself as I push myself to sitting on my bed. *Just answer the damn call and find out.* I smash the answer button with my thumb and hold the phone to my ear. "Hey! Uh, I mean, hi. What's up?"

Dani snorts softly with amusement. "Hey. You alright there?"

"Yeah." I chuckle. "Yeah. I'm good. How are you?"

"Good. Um, hey, so... um. About that gift card ... uh, did you still want to take me to use it?"

I sit up straighter, pulling my feet under me. "Yeah!" I clear my throat as she laughs softly. *Rein in the enthusiasm, dude.* "Yes. I would like that. When are you wanting to go?"

"Ummm, I dunno. Maybe tomorrow? After class?"

"Yeah. I can do that." I scoot to the edge of the bed like I'm about to get up. Like she didn't just say tomorrow. Like I need to get my things and go pick her up right now. When I realize what I'm doing, I have to force myself to relax and lean back on my elbow on the bed. "My last class ends at three tomorrow. When are you done?"

"Two."

"Do you want me to pick you up? Or do you want to meet at my place?"

She doesn't respond for a moment, then I hear a soft hum. "I think... Why don't you pick me up?"

"Okay. Three thirty work?"

"Sounds good."

After we hang up, I drop my phone on the bed next to me and flop back on my pillow. Blinking at the ceiling, I can't quite believe what just happened. Maybe Autumn knows what she's talking about after all.

* * *

The next day at three thirty on the dot, I'm outside Dani's front door. My stomach gurgles with nerves. Which is completely ridiculous. I've hung out with Dani a million times. We've gone shopping before. Okay, never for makeup or whatever we're getting today. Still. It's not the first time I've been to her house or picked her up for some reason.

This isn't a date. Much as I might like it if it were, we are nowhere near that point yet. I talked to Autumn again this morning when I discovered her at our kitchen table. She was surprised and happy to find out that Dani asked me to take her shopping.

"I really wasn't sure what she was going to do," she said when we talked. "When I talked to her the other day, she didn't seem to know what she wanted either. I almost expected her to ask Piper or me to take her. Or to just sit on the gift card and not use it for a long time." She grinned and clapped her hands. "Oh! This is exciting. Okay. Here's the plan." And then she launched into a lengthy lecture on all the dos and don'ts of both getting Dani and me back to a friendly place, and also how to go from there to a more-than-friends place.

I'm honestly skeptical about half of what Autumn suggested. But I was skeptical about the gift card suggestion, and that's working out so far. So maybe I should listen to what she has to say.

Raising my hand, I knock firmly three times.

When the door opens, Dani stands on the other side. She looks me up and down and laughs. "What are you doing? You never knock on the door and wait for me to answer. Why didn't you just come inside?"

With my hands in my coat pockets, I shrug and give her a lopsided grin. "I wasn't sure how you'd feel about that, given ... everything."

Her own grin falters slightly. "Well, I guess that's a good point. Thank you for being considerate."

"You're welcome. You ready to go?"

"Yep. Let me just grab my jacket and phone."

She leaves the door cracked while she puts on a white puffy coat, then stuffs a couple of things in her pockets and comes out the door. She gives me another smile, this one a little more forced. "Alright. Let's go."

With my hand on her back, I walk her down her front steps to my car. It might be a risky move, as it's more of a date or a boyfriend gesture, but Autumn emphasized that I should be bold. But not too bold.

It's a delicate balance.

Especially where Dani is concerned. She has to have some inkling that my feelings for her are more than platonic. Otherwise why would I have kissed her that one night? Surely she doesn't think I would throw away our entire friendship for a quick fuck?

But kissing her too soon was obviously a foul. Even so, I need to make it clear that I'm interested in her, while also respecting her boundaries.

She throws me a surprised look over her shoulder when my hand stays on her back, but she doesn't object. I'm going to count that in the win column.

When we reach my car, I drop my hand from her back so I can open her door. That earns me another surprised look, but once again she doesn't say anything. Once she's safely inside the car, I close the door, and move to the driver's side to climb in.

The drive to the store passes in relative silence, but it's not awkward or uncomfortable. I'm glad. The last time we sat in extended silence, it was very awkward. This feels more like how things have always been between us. We've never had to talk just to fill the silence. We've always been comfortable just being together.

Which is part of the reason that I've always wished that we could be more. If I'm going to be in a relationship, I want it to be with someone who doesn't require me to entertain them twenty-four-seven. Someone who understands the demands of my schedule, especially during football season, but even during the off-season. Dani understands the need for training no

matter what time of year as well as the need for a proper nutrition plan. Hell, she follows one herself. And she trains just for the fun of it since she's not competing anymore. Although, some part of me wonders if she would enjoy competing again if she had the opportunity.

I wait until we reach the store to bring up my question. We're wandering through aisles of cosmetics, skin care, and more types of shampoo than I ever knew existed. Dani seems almost as lost as I am. Every once in a while she glances at her phone, squints at a product, replaces it on the shelf, and moves on.

"So, uh, I was wondering ..."

She glances at me, a small jar of something in her hand, her eyebrows raised. "Oh, yeah? What were you wondering?"

Clearing my throat, I pick up a tube of something, glance at it, and put it back. "Well, I was just wondering about lifting competitions."

She puts the jar back down, then walks to the next aisle. This one seems to claim her attention more, she stares at the rows and rows of products, as though searching for something in particular. Squinting at her phone again, she crouches down and pulls a bottle from the shelf, flipping it around and squinting at the tiny print on the back. "What were you wondering about lifting competitions? Are you thinking of entering?"

Laughing, I shake my head. "No. I was wondering when the last time you competed was."

Her head jerks up sharply, and her eyes narrow, the bottle in her hand forgotten, at least for the moment. "Why?" Her voice drips with suspicion. She stands again, crossing her arms, the bottle now trapped near her armpit. "Did my dad call you?"

"What?" I hold up my hands, palms out. "No! Why would your dad call me?"

"I don't know, dude." Her brows pull together, confusion and irritation projecting from every line of her body. "You're the one who brought up competitions. Why else would you bring it up? I thought my dad might've decided that getting my friends to harass me was a good tactic to bully me back into doing what he wants."

"Christ, no." She relaxes at the denial. "Jesus. Would he really do something like that?"

Frown still in place, she pulls the bottle out from under her arm to peer at it again and shrugs. "Yeah. He might. I'm kinda surprised he hasn't yet, actually. I don't know if it's because he didn't think of it, didn't think it would work, or realized it might be crossing a boundary, even for him."

"So I'm guessing you don't want to compete anymore then?"

Dani starts laughing. Not just a soft chuckle either, but full-on belly laughing in the middle of the store. I join in, more out of reaction than from finding any humor in the situation myself. Is her dad really that controlling? That she honestly thinks he might try to contact me? In order to get her to do something that he wants?

Does that mean she never wanted to compete at all? I know she said that her dad was the driving force behind her competing, but I figured she must've enjoyed it at least some. Otherwise why wouldn't she have protested ages ago? But I guess it's hard to resist your patently, especially when they're apparently highly manipulative.

After a moment, Dani's laughter dies away, and she reaches up to wipe her eyes. Shaking her head, she lets out one last chuckle. "No. No, I never wanted to compete. That was all about my dad. I enjoyed lifting. I still do. And I have nothing but respect for people who participate in strength sports—or any sports for that matter—but that level of dedication and discipline is not for me. I enjoy being able to eat whatever I want sometimes. To pig out when I have PMS. To not push my body when all it wants to do is rest. When I was competing, I had no leeway for any of those things. And if I had tried to take a day off that wasn't scheduled, Dad would have a fit. He'd yell and scream and tell me what a disappointment I was until I caved and went to the gym like he wanted me to."

She takes a deep breath, her eyes still staring at the bottle in her hand, but I don't think she's actually looking at it. "He wanted me to go to Michigan with Luke and try to get on the Olympic lifting team there. Luke had a scholarship. Dad was convinced I could get one too. Even though I was a powerlifter and only did Olympic lifting for fun occasionally, and even that was to appease both my dad and Luke. I mean I had fun doing it too. I didn't mind when those lifts were in my program. But again, I never enjoyed the competition part of it."

Unable to help myself, I wrap an arm around her shoulders and pull her close. She turns into me, her free hand gripping the open half of my coat.

"He dreamed of me competing at the Olympics. Powerlifters don't do that. So powerlifting wasn't good enough anymore. Not when there's a world stage available. But that was his dream. And by the time I'd graduated high school, I knew I didn't want to live his dream anymore. So I came here. To Marycliff. And I still supported Luke because he always enjoyed the competition. Guess I don't have to do that anymore."

I wrap my other arm around her, hugging her now. I'm not sorry. I can't handle seeing her upset or sad, and I especially can't handle it if I'm not allowed to do anything about it. Even if the only thing I can do is give her a hug. I lean my face into her hair, wanting to kiss the top of her head, but holding myself back. I learned my lesson about kissing already. But at least she's letting me give her comfort. I don't know what I would do if she pushed me away right now.

"What's your dream, Dani?"

She sniffs, and I want to pull back so I can look in her face to see if she's crying. I hate it when she cries. It's so rare that I always assume that someone must be dead or dying. But when she finally answers, her voice is steady and reassuring. "I've always wanted to help people. I'm fascinated by the human body and the things it can accomplish. And it's always bothered me to know that when people get hurt they often don't regain their full level of ability. I know, I know that it's not always possible. But I want to give people a chance. A chance to feel like themselves again, and maybe even improve on it depending on where they started."

Dani's always been supportive and cheered me on anytime we discuss football or my desire to put my biochem degree to work in a lab, helping people by developing new antibiotics against resistant strains. Or maybe curing cancer. Or some other lofty goal of creating a new drug that will save lives and make the world a better place. How come we never talk about her goal of becoming a physical therapist and how much she wants to help people?

Have I always been such a selfish ass?

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Dani

Eli's arms around me feel good. Solid. Comforting. Some part of me hates the fact that I'm taking comfort in his arms. This boy. This boy has been such a source of frustration lately.

This is the kind of comfort I should've received on karaoke night. This is how I wanted him to react to me when I was sad about the fact that my on-again off-again relationship was over once and for all. I wanted a hug from my best friend. Instead I got a kiss. A good kiss, if I'm being honest with myself. And yes, I did kiss him back after I got over the initial shock. And I guess I would've been okay with that type of comforting too. Maybe. I've been so lonely for such a long time. And I had expected Luke to fulfill that need for human contact.

My friends are great. But we all know that nothing is really a substitute for that kind of intimate touch. And while hookups can fill that void to some degree, it's not the same as being with someone who knows you, who cares about you, who loves you.

But did Luke ever really love me?

I thought so.

Maybe I was just deluding myself. I mean, he said he loved me. But if you love someone, why would you break up with them over and over and over again? I mean yeah, long distance relationships are no picnic. But I was willing to do it. He was the one who always insisted that it was too

hard. And I knew what that meant. I knew that meant he was horny and wanted to hook up with somebody but didn't want to cheat on me.

And in a way—a weird, stupid twisted way—I thought that meant he respected me. That he cared about me enough to not want to cheat on me.

But why would you want to cheat on someone you love anyway? I didn't want to cheat on him, no matter how lonely or horny I was.

At least Eli isn't trying to put the moves on me anymore. But can we really go back to how things were? Can I just forget that kiss ever happened? Do I even want to?

What might've happened if Jackson and Autumn hadn't walked in when they did?

I guess that doesn't really bear thinking about. Besides, Eli is the one who said we should pretend the kiss never happened. And he's trying to make up for being a dick. That's why we're here after all. And this hug actually does go a ways toward accomplishing that.

When I lift my head, he gives me a soft smile. “You alright?”

I return his smile with one of my own and nod. “Yeah. Yeah, I’m okay. I just haven’t thought about any of that stuff in quite a while.”

He smooths a hand over my ponytail. “Sorry for bringing it up. Usually you sound pretty neutral when you talk about competitions. I thought maybe it was because you missed it and were trying not to let it show.”

With a snort of amusement, I shake my head. “No. Not at all. In fact, every time I go home, Dad tries to convince me to register for some competition or other that he's found. And every time I say no. And every time he spends my entire visit trying to convince me to register. He offers to pay the fees, he offers to pay for a coach, he even offered to pay me once. On top of all of the other fees, he said that he would pay me a dollar for every pound I lifted in competition.”

Eli blinks, his face blank with shock. “Wait, like, total? For every lift? Is he counting each attempt as its own lift? Or just total weight per lift?”

Laughing at his barrage of questions, I nod. “I know, right? I'm honestly not sure exactly what he meant. He started to explain the logic, but I'm pretty sure it was a dollar for every time I successfully lifted every pound. So each attempt would count, as long as it was successful.”

Eli blinks some more. “Holy shit,” he says softly. “And you turned that down?”

“Trust me, it wouldn’t have been worth it.” I pat his chest, then step back and replace the bottle in my hand on the shelf. I have absolutely no idea what kind of hair product it was. Something purporting to be for curly hair, but Autumn gave me a list of ingredients to avoid, at least to start with, and I think I saw one or two on the back of that one.

“Seriously?” Eli presses, following me as I stroll farther down the aisle.

There’s a collection of bottles that look like the ones Autumn uses. That’ll probably be a good choice for me too.

“Seriously,” I confirm, checking the list of products Autumn said I should get for my hair. “My dad would’ve been checking on me a million times a day, checking with my coach, trying to micromanage everything from hundreds of miles away. He’s bad enough just trying to convince me to compete. He’s a thousand times worse when he succeeds. A few hundred bucks isn’t worth it to me.”

“A few hundred bucks,” he mutters behind me. “I’ve seen you lift, dude. It’d be well over a thousand by the end of the competition.”

“Still not worth it,” I singsong back, putting a few things in the basket I grabbed when we came in.

I turn and head back toward the maze of makeup. It’s so overwhelming, and Autumn gave me far less guidance on this, only making a couple of color suggestions for eyeshadow and eyeliner, nothing about brands. And no warning about how much of a labyrinth the store would be.

But she’s also right that I want to experiment more with makeup. And if I’m going to learn to do my own, I need something to work with.

Eli chuckles when I take a deep breath, and I give him a sharp look. “What?”

Shaking his head, he laughs more. “You act like you’re about to go into battle.”

“Well?” I gesture at the vast array of makeup. “I feel like I have to hack my way through dense forest in search of hidden treasure. I don’t know what I’m looking for, exactly. Just a few vague suggestions of things I might want according to my roommate whose brilliant idea this whole trip was.”

“Hey, now,” Eli protests, “I’m the one who bought the gift card and offered to bring you. I’m pretty sure this was my brilliant idea.”

“Uh-huh,” I agree sardonically. “And we all know that Autumn’s the one who put you up to it. She all but admitted it to me, so you don’t have to try to pretend otherwise.”

He huffs, but doesn’t deny it.

“I’m a little surprised, actually,” I say as I read the labels on the row of store brand eyeliner pencils. The one thing Autumn said about brands was that I couldn’t go wrong with the store brand. Good basics, she said. And I’m definitely in need of basics.

“Surprised about what?” Eli asks as I pull out a bronze pencil and a black one. Those seem like good starting options. I hope.

Everyone uses black, right? And the bronze said it has a little shimmer. And that might be fun.

Turning, I search for the eyeshadow. Shouldn’t it be near the eyeliner? I mean, it seems like all the eye makeup should go together, right?

I spot some a little farther down. “That you’re getting ideas from Autumn. I thought you didn’t really like her.”

“Uh ... I mean, that’s not ...”

A glance over my shoulder reveals Eli rubbing the back of his neck then scratching his cheek—sure tells of embarrassment or uncertainty—his face a fascinating shade of red. Biting my lips, I stifle a laugh.

“It’s not that I don’t like her,” he finishes lamely. “It’s not!” he protests at my look of doubt.

A laugh burbles out of me despite my best efforts to stifle it. “Okay, Eli. If you say so.”

He sighs. “I never said I didn’t like her. She’s fine. I never had a problem with her, per se. I just didn’t really think she was the best fit for Jackson.” He holds up his hands as though to fend off a protest from me even though I haven’t said anything. “I don’t think that anymore. I mean, obviously they work really well together. But when he used to blush anytime anyone even mentioned kissing? Someone like Autumn just didn’t seem like the best choice.” He drops his hands to his sides, suddenly looking like a sad little boy. “And I know I was judging her unfairly based on rumors and how she’s been with others. She’s been good for Jackson. And I’m happy they’re happy.”

“Awww, Eli.” I pat his chest. “I’m proud of you for growing and being able to admit when you’re wrong.” At least with Autumn. Though, to be

fair, I guess this whole day is part of his apology and making up for his behavior to me. So maybe his ability to admit wrongdoing and change his behavior extends to me as well.

Turning to him I give him a squinty-eyed look. “What are we doing here, Eli?”

He looks at me, his eyes widened in surprise. “Shopping? I thought that would be kind of obvious since we’re, you know, in a store, and you’re looking at things that I assume you intend to purchase. Do you need anything else? Or are you ready to check out?”

I roll my eyes. “Well, yes, I mean, obviously we’re shopping. But why here? Why did you pick this store for a gift card? And why did you want to come with me?”

Eli opens and closes his mouth a couple of times. His hand goes behind his neck, and he gives it a squeeze. His cheeks turn a little pink again. “Well, I mean ... You’ve been wearing makeup a couple times lately. And when I talked to Autumn—”

“Ah ha!” I put my finger in his face accusingly. “You did talk to Autumn!”

He bats my hand away and rolls his eyes. “I’m pretty sure we already covered this. Yes, I talked to Autumn about what I should do to make up to you for the fact that I’ve been a complete asshole. I didn’t think just saying sorry would be good enough. And every time I’ve tried to talk to you about ... what happened that night over Christmas break, I seem to just fuck it up even more. I hate the idea of losing our friendship.” There’s a slight pause right before he says friendship, but he continues before I can think about what that might mean. “You’re important to me, Dani. I don’t want to lose you.”

If I didn’t know better, that almost sounds like some kind of romantic declaration. It’s the type of speech that the guy gives at the end of the rom-com when he realizes he’s messed up and he’s trying to get back with his girl.

Except I’m not Eli’s girl. I’m just his friend who happens to be a girl. We talk football and weightlifting and meal plans and sometimes biology. But we don’t date. We don’t make out. We barely touch except for hugs when someone’s upset. Well, when I’m upset. I suppose I’ve hugged Eli a few times to comfort him, but I can’t remember the last time he was upset.

Usually he's comforting me because I'm mad at Luke for breaking up with me again.

Maybe that's why he didn't just give me a hug after karaoke night. Maybe he's getting tired of the whole song and dance of Luke and I breaking up and getting back together and breaking up and getting back together and breaking up and getting back together. I know *I'm* tired of it.

I guess that's one silver lining of Luke getting together with another girl. It means that he and I are over for good, and that means that I no longer have to ride this roller coaster of wondering if this time the breakup is for good. Because even though I was never fully convinced it was, some part of me always worried that maybe this was the time.

Seeing him with another girl when I was home for Christmas, was all my worst fears come true. It hurt. So, so much.

But now I can move through that hurt once and for all, and I don't have to worry about it ever again.

Now I just have to worry about what the fuck is going on with Eli.

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CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Eli

My throat works as I swallow convulsively. Did I overstate things? I don't think so, but I can't really gauge anything with Dani anymore. She obviously wants to know what I'm thinking, or she wouldn't have asked what we're doing here.

But she still hasn't responded except to stare at me with a blank look on her face. I clear my throat. "Was this a bad choice? Should I not have taken Autumn's advice?"

Finally she gives me a small smile and reaches out to bump my shoulder with her fist. "No, this was a good choice. I get why Autumn suggested it. And why you would've thought it was a good suggestion." She looks all around before refocusing on me. "It's kinda overwhelming, though. If my sister were here, she'd know exactly what to get and the best brands and could give me a detailed list on why. But I was never that girl. I've always been this girl." She gestures up and down her body, taking in her joggers, sneakers, and long sleeve T-shirt under her unzipped puffy coat. "I was the sporty girl, the tomboy. The son my father never had."

Realization dawns like the sun breaking through the clouds. "Is that the deal? He was disappointed he got two daughters so he made you into a son."

Dani's face closes down, and she turns away, looking blindly at the display of makeup in front of her. Reaching out she touches a finger to one of the eyeshadow palettes. "Yeah," she says softly. "Yeah, pretty much."

Sucking in a deep breath, she visibly shakes off whatever feeling that statement brought up, and turns to me with a smile. "But I've decided to be my own person now. And that means I don't have to be the son he never had anymore. I get to be me." And then under her breath she adds, "Now I just have to figure out who that is."

I don't think she intended for me to hear the last part, so I pretend not to. She pulls out her phone and glances at it again, then heads to a different part of the maze of makeup. She quickly selects a few more things, then gives me another forced smile and says, "Alright. I think I have everything I need for now. Let's go."

I gesture for her to lead the way to the checkout counter, following behind her. I'm tempted to put my hand on her back again, but I don't. Not yet, anyway.

This is honestly going better than I expected. When we were at the grocery store a couple weeks ago, it felt so awkward even though we've grocery shopped together a million times. And this? Shopping in a store neither of us feels comfortable in? There are so many opportunities for it to have been horrible. Instead, it feels like we've made some breakthroughs. Or at least I've had some breakthroughs. Realizations of my own issues and shortcomings, as well as how those intersect with Dani's issues.

I just figured she was one of those chicks who like football. They exist. I mean, her roommate Piper is a football fan. Although, to be fair, Piper is definitely more feminine than Dani has ever appeared. I guess I didn't realize that she felt forced into that role. And that maybe she didn't like it. But it's difficult, I would imagine, to break out of a familiar pattern. I feel like it would be a lot like when I was a freshman in high school and my coach made me play a new position. I had to relearn all the plays from a different angle. And it was really hard not to fall back into my old routes and instead stick to the new ones.

And when Dani attempted a new route like at karaoke night or at the party the other night, instead of encouraging her, I did the opposite. I made it harder for her to learn her new routes. Her chosen routes.

God, I'm such an ass.

At least I'm trying to be less of an ass now. Better late than never, right? At least it seems like I have a shot at salvaging our friendship at the very

least. Because what I said to her was the truth. I don't want to lose her. I want more with her.

I guess the real question is, am I willing to risk the relationship we've had in order to achieve the relationship I really want?

* * *

I glance at Dani from the driver's seat as we head back to her place. "So are you gonna wear all of that stuff for me sometime soon?"

She laughs, the sound unrestrained and happy. A welcome change from the tense smiles and silence since the conversation about her dad wishing she were a boy.

Shaking her head, she opens the plastic bag in her lap and peeks inside. "I don't know. The last time I wore makeup in front of you, you didn't seem too enthusiastic about it. What was it you said about that again?"

I groan. "You're never going to let me live that down, are you?"

Another laugh. "Maybe. But it might take a while."

"What else can I do to make it up to you? Do you want me to do your makeup for you?"

She laughs even harder at that suggestion and shakes her head. "God, no. I think that might be worse than me trying to do it myself."

"Who did your makeup before?"

"Who do you think?"

I glance at her out of the corner of my eye, pleased to see that she's still smiling. "Hmmm. If I had to guess, I think I'll say Autumn, at least that karaoke night. Your other roommates weren't around then, after all. And if she did it the first time, I'm guessing you would be most comfortable with her doing it the second time too."

"You know me so well."

She says it as an off-the-cuff remark, but it warms me all the same. I do know her. Really well, in fact. But I'm also realizing that there's a lot more to her that I don't know. That I haven't bothered to try to know, even though I've been half in love with her for ages. I guess I kind of took our relationship for granted as well. I just assumed that she would always be around, that there's nothing that could ruin our relationship. I think, like her,

I assumed she'd always be hung up on her high school boyfriend. So there was never any real risk of our friendship developing into anything more.

Which meant that I never actually tried to develop a relationship with anybody else either. Sure, I'd hook up sometimes. Dani did too, for that matter. When she and Luke were broken up. But since they always got back together, I never tried to turn our friendship into something more. I guess I never thought she would be receptive since I knew she still wanted to be with Luke.

The difference this time is that things with Luke seem to be over for real. I don't think she'd take him back even if he broke up with the other chick that he brought home for Christmas. At least I hope not.

But since I never actually expected to have a shot with Dani, discovering that she was actually available made me lose my head I guess. And so I kissed her.

I was upset when she didn't react positively right away. But I guess I can't really blame her. If the situation were reversed and I were the one in an on-again off-again relationship with a long distance high school girlfriend and she had a crush on me for years, never told me, and then kissed me out of the blue when I announced that my relationship was over for good? I don't know that I would've reacted any better than she did.

"But for real though," I press. "What are you going to do with that makeup you bought today? If you don't know how to put it on, is Autumn always going to do your makeup?"

She gives me a disgusted look. "Seriously, dude? YouTube exists, you know. I'm sure I can figure it out. I'm a fairly intelligent person, after all. Plenty of people learn to put on makeup. I'm just getting a later start than most."

Rolling my lips between my teeth, I bite back a grin. "I'm sure you'll figure it out without any problem. And I'm looking forward to seeing the results." I'm rewarded with a wide smile. While I wish that things had gone differently to begin with, I can't complain about where they are right now.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Dani

Watching makeup tutorials on YouTube has completely changed the recommendation algorithm. Though, to be fair, I'm not entirely upset about that. It's funny though, because if you'd told me even a couple of months ago that I'd be doing this, I'd have laughed in your face.

It's definitely been enlightening, though. I've discovered that I have hooded eyes. Who knew? I don't know, maybe everybody else knows things like that about their eye shape. But I sure didn't. And so my first attempts at using eyeshadow were lackluster at best. And I already feel dope about the fact that I'm just figuring this out at twenty-one years old when it seems like everybody around me has known all of this for years. Or at least all the girls I know, including my younger sister.

I eventually reach out to her for help. I'm home alone, so none of my roommates are available. I chose to do it this way on purpose. I know they're one hundred percent supportive, but I still feel silly. I'm halfway dreading the first time I leave the bathroom with a full face of makeup, because I know they'll comment. But I also know that their comments will all be complementary. So it's a mixed bag.

At least with Anita, I can just text her. Which means that I don't have to listen to whatever teasing she might have decided to do over the phone. But it's hard to know which YouTube tutorials are the best. There are just so many, and it gets overwhelming quickly. A few of the ones that I watched clearly expected the users to have a basic amount of knowledge and skills

that I do not have. I needed something for a complete beginner. And I need someone to send me some good videos to help me figure things out.

When I was having trouble getting my eyeshadow to look like the tutorials, I sent her a picture out of sheer frustration. She responded with a link to a video about different eye shapes. And from there I was able to find tutorials for my specific needs. The results have been much better.

Eyeliner is a little bit more tricky. But after a few rounds of trial and error, I think I've gotten the hang of it. At least enough that I don't think I look ridiculous. I'm glad I went ahead and got the bronze eyeliner. It's more subtle than the black, which is just too much for me right now. Maybe someday I'll be comfortable rocking those dramatic eye makeup looks I found pictures of online. But that day is definitely not today.

My phone alerts with an incoming video call, Anita's name showing on my screen. With a smile on my face, I hit the button to answer. "Hey, Anita. What's up?"

She makes a derisive sound. "Please, Dani. You don't think I'm going to send you a whole bunch of makeup tutorials and not expect to see the results do you? Now go stand facing a window and open the blinds so I can get the full effect."

Laughing, I follow her orders, opening the curtains in my bedroom to let in the weak afternoon sunlight. I hold up the phone, making sure that it's close enough to my eyes so she can get a good look. I blink rapidly, like when cartoon characters are acting flirty. "Well? What do you think? How'd I do?"

She's silent for a moment, studying my face. Then she lets out a satisfied hum. "Well done," she says at last. "I never would've guessed that this is your first attempt at makeup. You did good, kid."

I laugh again, this time at her goofy choices of praise. "Thanks. You sound like Dad, though."

"Yeah, I know. That's what does it for you, right? That kind of praise?"

That stops me short, my mouth open. "Ummm, I guess?"

She snorts. "Please, Dani. That was basically the driving force behind your whole high school career. Everything you did as a teenager was to gain Dad's approval. You started lifting weights because it was something he wanted you to do. And when he heaped on praise, you did it even more.

You started competing because it got you more of his attention. And it got you more of his praise when you did well.”

She leans her chin on her hand, her face thoughtful. “Of course, the flipside of that is that when he was disappointed, you became horribly depressed. Now it also drove you to try even harder to win his approval. But fortunately you realized that he was using his disapproval as a spur to make you push yourself harder and harder and harder. I hated watching you kill yourself for someone who’d dangle their approval in front of you like a carrot that you could never ever reach. I’m not sure what made you choose Marycliff over Michigan, especially considering the fact that Dad wanted you to go there and your boyfriend was going there, but I’m so glad you did.”

Her words slam into me, a series of repeat and unintentional slaps to the face. I blink quickly a few times, no longer trying to imitate a flirty cartoon, just processing everything that she’s just said. “What—what are you talking about?”

Her face mirrors my own surprise. “What do you mean?”

“About Dad using his disapproval to make me work harder. You really think he was doing that on purpose?”

She tilts her head to the side. “Don’t you? It was one thing for him to be disappointed when you didn’t do that well, especially when you both thought that you could do better. But didn’t you notice that he was starting to act disappointed even when you did better than you did during practice? He always acted like you are never good enough. I figured you realized what he was up to, got sick of it, and decided to do your own thing. Didn’t you?”

“Ummmm ...” I’m honestly not sure what to say to that. Because while I did decide to do my own thing, it’s not for the reasons Anita thinks.

“Dani? I mean ...” She lets out a strained chuckle. “If that’s not why you went to Marycliff ...”

Sighing, I close my eyes and shake my head. “That’s not ... I mean, kinda? I did pick up on the fact that Dad was pushing harder and harder and harder, and I got sick of it. But I didn’t realize that he was doing it to manipulate me.” And looking back over all the things that Anita described, I can see that she’s right. My feelings toward my father have been complicated for a while. This just adds a whole new layer to that.

“I’m sorry,” she says softly after a moment. “I thought you’d put that all together years ago. I mean, I figured you stopped competing to make it impossible for him to keep manipulating you.”

“No, I...” I shake my head. “No. I just got tired of him pushing. I never really enjoyed competing anyway.”

Anita sits up straighter, her face blank with surprise again. “Seriously? You didn’t even like it?”

An incredulous laugh shoots out of me. “No,” I state emphatically. “Not at all. I hated all of it. I hated the way he restricted my food when I was cutting. I hated the way he made me eat so many things that I didn’t enjoy when I was bulking. I hated bulking all together, because it always meant a strict cut was coming my way, and it was always so miserable eating the most boring foods and being hungry all the time.”

More than that, I really hated the way he’d always treat me. The disappointment. The inevitable disappointment after every single event. And it only got worse over time. Now that Anita’s connected the dots, I can see exactly when and how and why it all felt so horrible so much of the time.

Would I have enjoyed competing if we’d taken a more reasonable approach? If my dad hadn’t tried to micromanage every aspect of my training and my life? One of the best things about coming to Marycliff was that he has no connections here and no real ability to manipulate me any more than I let him.

When we were still in high school, he liked to use Luke to help pressure me into doing things. The two of them together teamed up to get me to start working on my Olympic lifts, even though I was only entering powerlifting competitions. When I balked at Dad hiring me a separate coach for Olympic lifts, he got Luke to work with me instead. And since Luke was my boyfriend, I was more likely to go along with it since he presented it as a fun thing we could do together.

And to be honest, I actually did enjoy doing those things with Luke. Luke didn’t berate me like my father did. And since Luke wasn’t a real coach, Dad couldn’t pull the whole, *I pay for your services so you have to do what I want*, schtick that he did with my other coaches.

So maybe I would’ve enjoyed competing if I had a normal dad.

Eli brought up competing yesterday. It's funny how the universe seems to be pushing this at me right now. Maybe I should give it a try again.

Everything in me revolts at the thought, though. My heart immediately starts racing, my stomach twisting into knots at just the thought of starting a serious training regimen to get competition ready.

Nope. Not going to do that. That is not my idea of a good time. Maybe it could've been, but it's been ruined. Possibly forever.

"Um, well ..." Anita starts, grimacing at the camera. "Sorry for bringing things down. That wasn't my plan. I just wanted to see your makeup. I have to admit I was really surprised to get that first text from you. It always seemed like you hated makeup and hair and anything girly."

I give a rueful chuckle. "Yeah ... we can thank Dad for that too."

Anita grimaces again. "Ugh. I never understood why he was so down on all of that stuff. I didn't get why he made you hate it too."

"He wished I were a boy. So he did his best to make me the son he never had." It's a painful admission. Some part of me has always known that, but I hadn't ever put it into words until Eli and I went shopping.

"What a dick." Leave it to Anita to sum it up so concisely.

I can't help laughing at her assessment. "Yeah, pretty much."

"Well, I'm glad you're finally figuring out that it's okay to wear makeup *and* be into sports." She makes a sweeping gesture with one arm. "The world is your oyster," she declares dramatically. "You get to do whatever you want. You're young. You're beautiful. Now go out and find a guy who's not a dick. You deserve a dude who's not a douche after putting up with our dad and then your douchey ex-boyfriend for so long."

Laughing more, I shake my head. "Thanks, Anita. I appreciate all your help and your words of wisdom."

"My pleasure." She smiles and waves at the camera. "You can call me anytime you like. Not just for advice about makeup. I miss you."

I give her a warm smile in return. "Miss you too, Nita. I'll talk to you later."

After we hang up, I close my curtains again and flop back on my bed. The last few days have been challenging in a way I didn't expect.

I never would've dreamed that simply deciding to wear some makeup would be a catalyst to reevaluating my entire adolescence. Not just my adolescence, actually, because it started even earlier. My dad did his best to

do all the things he wanted to do with a son starting when I was a toddler. And it may have started out with the idea that gender doesn't actually matter, that little girls can play sports too.

But it took a darker turn at some point, and he began to actively discourage me from doing more traditionally feminine activities. If he found me playing with dolls or when I said I wanted Barbies, he made sure to give me Army men and action figures instead.

I'm not sure if he just didn't bother to do the same things to my little sister or if she rejected those substitutions, but for whatever reason I was the one he chose to make this way. Or maybe Anita has always felt inferior as well and just decided she didn't care about his approval. Whereas I chased after it like a drug.

Coming to college has been like some kind of extended detox. And I finally have the strength to resist the temptation, knowing that the high is so temporary and only rarely achieved.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Eli

I'm working on some biochem homework at the kitchen table, the remains of my dinner on the pushed aside plate across from me, when the front door opens, and Jackson comes in.

Surprised that he's by himself, I set my pen down and sit back in my chair to stretch. "Hey, man. Are you on the outs with Autumn? Or is someone sick?"

Chuckling, Jackson pushes the door closed and takes off his jacket. "Nah, man. Everything's fine. No one's sick. She just had some stuff to take care of at home."

My eyes narrow, and I lean my forearms on the table, examining him for any tells as he folds himself into the seat across from me. "'Stuff to take care of,' huh?"

Jackson chuckles again and shrugs. "That's what she said. It's Autumn, dude. You and I both know that she answers to herself before anyone else. If she says she needs to do something on her own, you think I'm going to try to get in her way? Or quiz her for details?" He leans his elbow on the table and holds up a finger. "If she's being vague, it's either because she doesn't want to share or she thinks I'll be too weirded out by it. Either way, I'm not too worried about it. I don't know why you would be either."

Sighing, I relax. "You don't think her mysterious 'stuff' is quizzing Dani about what's going on with the two of us?"

Another relaxed shrug from Jackson. "Could be. If it is, I'm sure you'll find out eventually, either because Autumn will be using the info to adjust her advice to you or because Dani will tell you herself." Standing, he crosses to the sink and fills a glass with water, downing half of it before resuming his seat. "How are things going with you two anyway? Since she's not here, I'm assuming less well than you'd like but ..." He gestures for me to fill in the blanks.

I pick up my pen and fidget with the cap, figuring out the best answer to his question. "I think things are going okay. I mean, yeah, I'd love it if I could just magically make everything exactly how I want, but that's not how anything works, so ..." I shrug. "We had a good time shopping day before yesterday."

Jackson laughs. "I still can't believe you went to a mecca of all things feminine. And with Dani, no less."

With a disgruntled glare, I toss my pen at him. He laughs and bats it away. "What's that supposed to mean, asshole?"

He laughs again, completely unfazed. "It's just funny. The whole thing. You. Her. The two of you there together. She's the least girly girl I know. And you only have a brother and have never had a serious girlfriend for as long as I've known you, so you're not exactly an expert in that kind of thing either."

"Look—"

Jackson interrupts me by holding up his hands and cutting me off. "Dude. Relax. I know a lot of what this is about. I know why that's where you got the gift card and why you offered to take her. I was here for the entire conversation about it, remember? I'm not criticizing. But you have to admit, it's kinda funny."

After staring at him blankly a moment, a grudging smile tugs at my lips. "Fine. It is. Still, though. Don't fucking say that to Dani. Or in front of Dani. Ever. Got it?"

He holds up his hands again, his smile undimmed. "I wouldn't dream of it." He drops his hands, his smile fading. "Trust me, man. No one knows what it's like to be embarrassed by having all your quirks and oddities pointed out better than me."

I grunt. He's got a point.

He taps his fingers on the table. “But for real, how are things going with Dani? You took her shopping. It went well ... anything else on the agenda?”

Sighing, I sit back in my chair and fold my hands on top of my head. “I’m not sure. I was hoping she might reach out and invite me to study with her or something like we normally do but ...” I shake my head. “So far, no luck.”

“And the reason you haven’t is ...?” Jackson rolls his hand, an expectant look on his face.

I shake my head again. “I don’t want to be the only one trying.”

“Right. But you’re the one who messed up. So if you want to fix it, you’re the one who has to make the effort, right?”

“I guess you’ve got a point,” I grumble.

“So.” He raps his knuckles on the table. “If you want to see her, make the effort. Or”—he spreads his hands—“go ahead and give up. Because expecting her to make more effort than you after you were a dick ...” He tilts his head and presses his lips together. “You’re gonna be waiting a loooooong time.”

Before I can formulate a response, he takes his glass to the sink and disappears into his room.

Dammit. He’s right.

I look at how far I’ve gotten on my biochem homework. I still have the rest of this plus reading to do for western civ. Pulling my phone out from under the edge of my notebook, I stare at it a moment before typing out a quick text telling Dani I’ll be at the library in twenty minutes if she wants to come study with me.

Which means, of course, that I have to get my shit together and get to the library. Hopefully there’s a study room available.

* * *

Because I have shit luck, the study rooms are all full. I guess I shouldn’t be too surprised. By this point in the semester, you have to book those in advance if you want one. Between people who just prefer them for the isolation and groups working on projects together, they fill up fast.

Fortunately, I grab an empty table on the second floor near the windows. Dani hasn't responded by the time I get here, but I text her where I am anyway. Then I stare at my textbook, but the words don't penetrate my brain. I can't focus because I keep hoping that Dani will either show up or text me back and put me out of my misery—honestly a no would even be welcome at this point just so I know she's not coming and I can relax and finish studying.

After ten minutes—and checking my phone a thousand times—I'm ready to call it a day. I don't know if Dani is busy or just ignoring me, but it's clear she's not coming. Maybe this was a mistake. I should've stayed home and kept studying there. I could've texted Dani and invited her to my house, but I worried that might seem too intimate. We're just starting to find our footing again. I didn't want a premature invite to my house to ruin everything. Because we all know that going over to someone's house to “study” is all too often a euphemism for sex.

While I certainly wouldn't object to that kind of studying with Dani, we are nowhere near there yet. The library seemed like the best choice. Except all I seem to have done is wasted the last hour and gotten no further with my homework.

As I'm packing up my books, laptop, and notebooks, I happen to glance up in time to see Dani at the top of the staircase. She looks ... different.

It takes me a second to put my finger on what exactly is different. She's still Dani. But she looks more... polished? Yeah, polished.

She has her hair in a ponytail like normal, but it's less frizzy, less bushy. Instead it flows in soft waves. She's missing her usual hoodie, and instead has on a gray sweater over a pair of black leggings, fur-lined snow boots on her feet. Her white puffy coat is draped over one arm, her usual backpack slung over one shoulder, and she carries two coffee cups.

As she approaches the table, she gives me a wide smile, and I notice that her lips have a slight sheen to them. Her eyes look more noticeable, which sounds stupid, but I can't think of any other way to put it. They're more attention-grabbing. As she sits down, and I have time to really take her in, I realize she's wearing eye makeup. She still looks like her usual self, just a little more put together.

“Hey!” she says, pushing one of the coffee cups toward me. “Sorry it took me so long to get here. I thought it would be nice to have some coffee

to fuel our study session. Do you have a lot of homework to get through?”

“Hey yourself.” I reach across the table and grab the coffee cup she offers, take a sip, and grin. It’s a white chocolate mocha. “You decided I needed a treat, huh?”

She sips her own coffee, her eyes dancing above the rim of the cup. When she sets her cup back on the table, she lifts one shoulder in a shrug. “I thought we could both have a treat.”

I make a show of looking her over again. “You look really nice tonight.”

Her cheeks flush, and she looks at her hands circling her cup. “Thank you.” She takes a deep breath and raises her eyes to mine. “So what are you working on?” Her brow wrinkles, and she looks around the table. “Hang on. Where are all your things?”

Chuckling softly, I pull everything back out of my bag. “I was about to head home.”

“Did you finish everything already? Am I really that late?” She pulls out her phone and checks it, her brow still furrowed. “It hasn’t been *that* long since you texted me.”

“No, you’re right, it hasn’t been that long. But since you didn’t respond to my text and you weren’t here, I assumed you weren’t coming at all.”

“So ... What? You were just going to leave? Don’t you still need to study anyway?”

“Yeah, but I was having better luck studying at home. I figured I might as well go back if you weren’t going to join me.”

She narrows her eyes at me and takes another sip of her coffee. “Now that I’m here, are you going to stay?”

“Of course. I’m the one who invited you to join me. It would be pretty shitty if I left as soon as you arrived. Especially when you brought me my favorite special coffee.”

I obviously said the right thing, because she smiles to herself as she pulls her things out of her own bag. “All right. Let’s get studying. Do we want to do it in timed bursts? Or just go until one of us needs a break?”

Scratching my cheek, I contemplate her question. “Do you have a preference?”

She tilts her head from side to side, her mouth screwed up to one side. She’s so adorable. I wish I could just go to the other side of the table and kiss her right now. But I know that would be a mistake. Maybe one day I’ll

be able to do that. That's the goal. I wonder if Autumn has any new brilliant ideas to help me get there.

Dani picks up her phone, and presses some buttons on the face. "Let's do timed bursts. I'm setting my timer for thirty minutes. Ready?"

At my nod, she taps her screen and bends her head over her book.

I look at her for a moment longer, taking in the subtle changes. While I don't need Dani to be anyone other than who she is, I'm glad she's finally feeling able to explore all of the facets of her personality. And I'm excited to see where all of this might lead.

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CHAPTER NINETEEN

Dani

For years I thought wearing makeup was the most ridiculous thing. I figured it must add so much time to getting ready in the morning.

But now that I have expanded my morning routine to include it, it's really not that bad. I mean, I was already wearing sunscreen on my face every day anyway. It's just that my sunscreen is now tinted. If I'm feeling really minimal, I can just put on a little blush, a little mascara, a tinted lip balm, and I'm out the door. If I'm feeling more adventurous, I'll even wear eyeshadow. Not every day. But more than never.

My roommates have accepted it in stride, barely commenting on the change. Even Eli hasn't said much, just making a point of telling me I look nice almost every time I see him. Which, to be honest, is a new thing. I'm not sure he's ever complimented my appearance before. And now he's doing it all the time.

I'm definitely not upset by it, though. Especially since he's not over the top and weird about it. It's just a passing comment, and then we move on to whatever else we're doing—studying, grocery shopping, playing video games, watching football ...

Because we've started to do those normal Dani and Eli friendship things again. And tonight I'll be going to his place for game night for the first time all semester. I've missed the last few due to the weirdness between us, and I'm excited to get to hang out with all my friends again.

Piper pokes her head through the bathroom door and watches me finish applying my lip gloss. Crossing her arms, she props her shoulder against the door frame. “Looking good, hot stuff.”

Laughing, I replace the cap on my lip gloss and meet her eyes in the mirror. “Thanks, Piper.”

“I’m glad you’re coming tonight. It hasn’t been the same without you.”

I zip closed my small makeup case and turn to face Piper. “Oh yeah? How so?”

She shrugs and straightens, stepping back into the hallway to allow me out of the bathroom. “You’ve always been at game night. It’s weird when you’re not sitting next to Eli on the couch. I’m just glad you’ll be there is all.”

“Well, thanks.” I slip past her and move down the hall. “I’ve missed going. It felt wrong sitting at home while you guys left to have fun.”

Piper gasps and grabs my arm, forcing me to turn around in front of my bedroom door. She glares at me, crossing her arms again and cocking her hip. “You said you were fine with us going.” The statement is an accusation.

I throw my hands in the air. “I was fine with you going. You going was never a problem for me. I just wanted to go with you. But I knew it would be awkward being around Eli again after everything that happened between us. So my choices were to go and deal with the awkwardness—which I had no desire to do—or to stay home and deal with feeling left out. But it was my choice to be left out. Demanding you stay home with me in some kind of weird show of solidarity would’ve only put everyone in a terrible position. Autumn’s dating Jackson, for one thing. Am I supposed to make her stay home and take my side? What good would that accomplish?”

Her expression softens, but her posture doesn’t change. “I would’ve stayed home with you if I’d known you felt that way.”

Turning, I enter my bedroom fully aware that Piper will follow me. “And again, what good would that accomplish?”

I look up in time to see her rolling her eyes. “Well, for one thing, You wouldn’t have felt left out or alone. We could’ve watched a movie together or given each other pedicures or anything really.” She throws her arms wide. “I just don’t understand why you’d choose to be alone when you didn’t want to be. I assumed that you preferred solitude to process all your

feelings about everything. I know you've been going through a lot lately, and a lot of people like to be on their own to deal with that." She reaches out and smacks me lightly on the arm. "The next time you're going through something and don't want to be by yourself, tell me, dammit. I'll cancel my plans and hang out with you. That's what friends are for after all."

"Okay, okay." I hold up my hands in surrender. "I'm sorry. Next time I'm sad but I don't wanna be alone, I'll tell you, and we can watch a movie or whatever."

Piper stands up straight and lifts her chin, staring down her nose at me and sniffing. "Good. That's what I want to hear."

Opening my dresser drawer, I get out one of the new sweaters I bought last week and put it on. "Alright, are you ready to go?"

"Let's grab Ellie and we can go. Autumn is already over there."

* * *

Apprehension tightens my chest as we approach Eli and Jackson's apartment.

It's silly. I'm being silly. There's no reason for me to be nervous to see my best friends. Things with Eli and I are back to normal. Well... maybe not quite *normal*. But we're getting there. Maybe in another few weeks I'll be able to pretend like he never actually kissed me.

For some reason that makes me sad.

Even though I freaked out when it happened, I enjoyed it. I didn't want to pretend like it never happened at the time. I wanted to be able to talk to him about it and figure out what it meant.

But then he said, *Let's pretend that never happened*. Which means that it meant nothing. And if my best friend is going to kiss me, I want it to mean something. I don't care that Eli prefers hookups over relationships, but I don't want to destroy our relationship for nothing more than a hookup.

And it's clear he doesn't want that either, because he hasn't made any moves like that since.

Ellie leads the way into the apartment, a cheer greeting our arrival. It's already pretty crowded, and Autumn, who came earlier, is circulating, a

clipboard in hand. She writes on the clipboard as she speaks to people, and I know she's creating the roster for tonight's matchups.

Ellie approaches her and gives her a quick hug. Autumn waves at Piper and me, scribbling quickly on her paper before coming our way. "Hey, guys. I'm glad you made it." She gives each of us a hug like we didn't see each other just this morning. Then she waves toward the kitchen. "Eli is back there if you want to go say hi."

"Thanks, Autumn," I mumble. She's already moving on, though, and I'm sure she doesn't hear me at all.

Piper trails behind me as we head toward the kitchen. But we don't make it more than a few steps before we're stopped by Jared Ferguson, the left tackle who replaced Simon. He stands, blocking our way forward. Like Simon, he's a mountain of a man, with broad shoulders the size of small hills. Not as trim as the man he replaced, and he hasn't quite outgrown his baby face. His round cheeks bunch into a grin as he looks Piper and me up and down. "Hey, ladies. Can I get you anything?"

Even though he addresses both of us, it's clear his offer is mostly for me.

My brows wrinkle together, confused why he's paying attention to me all of a sudden. Maybe it's because we got here after things have gotten started? Usually I'm here already when other people start arriving, so no one other than Eli or Jackson has ever offered to get me anything before. "Uh, no thanks. I'm good."

He leans closer, almost as though he's trying to separate me from Piper. "Aw, come on. Don't be like that."

A laugh bubbles out of me unintentionally. "Don't be like what, exactly?"

Piper's hand appears on his chest, and she steps in, pushing her away between us. "I think it's pretty obvious she's not interested, Fergs. Maybe take a hint and move on, huh?" She pats him on the chest then pushes past him, glancing over her shoulder to make sure I'm following.

Shaking my head, I give her a *What was that?* look. With her eyebrows raised, she gives me a shrug in return. We get to the kitchen without further interruption.

Eli's face lights up at the sight of me, and he spreads his arms for a hug.

I step into his embrace, enjoying the familiar feel of his chest under my cheek and breathing in the combined smells of his deodorant and fabric softener. He's warm and comforting, a stark contrast to the weird encounter we just had.

"Hey, D. I'm so glad you're here. You look great."

Stepping back, I grin up at him, taking in his fitted dark gray henley and jeans. "Thanks. You look good too."

He glances at Piper and gives her a quick nod. "Hey, Pipes. How you been?"

"Pretty good. Busy schedule as usual. You know how it goes." She glances around the kitchen. "What's on the drink menu tonight?"

Eli steps away from me, though the small footprint of his kitchen doesn't allow him to move far, and he shows Piper the available options. I can't help noticing the way his jeans fit over his round ass, and my cheeks heat up when I realize I'm checking him out.

We're pretending the kiss never happened. Whether I like it or not at this point, that's what's happening. That means I have no business checking out my best friend's ass.

Jerking my gaze away, I look all around, hoping to find something—anything—to hold my attention.

One of the defensive ends catches my eye, his smile going wider when he realizes I'm looking at him. He lifts his drink, then jerks his head in a clear invitation to join him.

I shake my head in a quick negative and look away. That's weird. What is with these guys tonight? They usually say hey or give me a nod or whatever. It's not like they ignore me. But they don't offer to get me drinks or invite me to join them.

"What do you want to drink?" Eli's voice startles me out of my reverie, and I jerk my head around to face him.

"Umm."

He grins at my uncertainty. "Are we watching our calories tonight? Or can you afford to splurge?"

I can't help smiling at his questions. If I didn't know any better, from the way he's smiling at me, I might think he's trying to flirt with me. But I definitely know better. Tapping one finger against my lips, I look over the selection of cans and bottles on the counter. "I think I can splurge tonight."

What about you? Is tonight a cheat night? Or are you sticking to your meal plan?”

Leaning in close, he places his mouth right next to my ear. “Tonight I plan to splurge.”

His words send a shiver down my spine. The way he says them sounds almost seductive. Like the splurge in question is more than just a few extra calories.

But I ignore all that and give him a friendly smile when he pulls away. “I’ll just have what you’re having.”

“That’s what I like to hear.”

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CHAPTER TWENTY

Eli

So far this is the best game night of the semester. I realize it's a bit early to make any such proclamation, but the last two have sucked.

The reason this one's so much better is simple.

Dani's here.

Her presence is further proof that our relationship is back on solid footing. Now I just need to figure out how to take it from this—game nights and study sessions and shopping trips—to what I want—date nights and make out sessions and, okay, still shopping trips. Shopping with Dani is surprisingly fun. Actually everything with Dani is fun. I just like hanging out with her. And having her along for boring chores like grocery shopping makes them much more enjoyable.

The only thing that could ruin this night is if she realizes that half my teammates are trying to get in her pants. So far she seems more confused by their attention than anything, which is both a relief and also really sad. How can she not realize that they're flirting with her?

For that matter, how can she not know when I'm flirting with her?

Although I suppose she can be forgiven for not realizing that I'm trying to flirt. It's not like she expects that from me. We're supposed to be just friends. And to be fair, I've always been kind of flirty with her. She's probably used to it as part of our normal friendship.

But the other guys? How does she not see it?

The only reason I can think of is that she doesn't think *anyone* would want to flirt with her. Like ... maybe she doesn't think she's pretty enough?

Which is absolutely ridiculous. And if anyone tried to insult her looks in front of me, I'd break their face.

Not that anyone would. I mean look at her. She's fucking gorgeous. And that sweater? It makes me want to pet her. It looks so soft, just like the one she had on when we were studying the other night. I'm not sure when she got them, but I really like them. They cling to her curves in the most delicious way. And they make me want to peel them off and discover what's beneath.

Apparently I'm not the only one who thinks that. Because I just heard Tomlinson tell her that her sweater would look great on his bedroom floor.

Before Dani can even respond, I push my way between her and Tomlinson. "What did you just say to her?"

Tomlinson stutters and splutters a few unintelligible syllables before drawing himself up to his full height. He has a few inches on me, but I'm not intimidated. "Butt out, Foster. You don't have a claim on her. She's not your girlfriend."

I lean into him, pressing my chest into his. "I don't care. Don't talk to my friends that way, either. She's not some jersey chaser for you to fuck in the back room. She's not gonna get down on her knees and give you a blowjob either. So get it out of your fucking head before I kick you out of here."

"Whoa, whoa, whoa." Dani lays a hand on my shoulder. "Hey, now. There's no need for that. He was just being nice."

I spin around to face Dani. "I'm sorry, what? You think that was nice?"

Her face closes down as she jerks her hand away from me and looks me over. Licking her lips, she swallows hard. "Well, I mean ...". She grunts softly. "Okay, fine, maybe not *nice*, per se, but I don't think you need to 'break his face' either. It's not like he was trying to force me to do anything I didn't want."

My eyes bug out of my head. "Are you telling me you *want* to go home with him? See how your sweater looks on his floor?"

Her brows pull together, and she falters back a half step in the face of my jealous anger. "No." She shakes her head. "That's not what I'm saying. I'm saying he's not forcing me to do anything. I'm perfectly capable of

saying no and moving on with my evening.” Her face hardens. “Or I was, until you came over swinging your dick around like you need to claim your territory.” She crosses her arms, her chin lifting. “Is that what I am to you? Some kind of territory? I mean, it’s not like you want me for yourself. We all know that. But somehow that means it’s not okay for your teammates to hit on me either? What the hell, Eli?”

I feel like one of those cartoon characters that gets so mad their head turns bright red and steam comes out of their ears like a boiling tea kettle, complete with screaming. In fact, there’s a high pitched scream in my ears overlaying all the other noises. I keep my fists clenched at my sides so I don’t manhandle Dani into my room and show her *exactly* how much I want her. “You—I—he—*aargh!*” Gripping handfuls of my own hair, I tug, hoping the pain will help me get a handle on myself.

“Look, Eli,” Dani starts, trying to sound calm and conciliatory but in that patronizing way when she has to force it. “I know things have been awkward between us lately. But if this is going to work—”

I cut off whatever Dani’s trying to say with a sharp chop of my hand. “My room. Now. We need to talk without an audience.”

Her eyes narrow, and I realize that barking orders isn’t winning me any points. Nostrils flaring, I suck in a few deep breaths, enough to get a handle on my emotions, and force myself to repeat my request softly and as an actual request. “Dani. Please. I would like to speak with you, and I think we’d both like it better if we hashed this all out without everyone here watching. Can we go to my room? Or if you’d prefer, we can go somewhere else. You pick the location, and we can either go together or I’ll meet you there.”

Seconds tick by as she mulls over my words, her shoulders relaxing by fractions until she finally drops her arms. “Fine.” She throws an arm out, gesturing to the hall that leads to the bedrooms. “Lead the way.”

With a tight nod, I do as she says, picking my way through the bodies, ignoring the shocked and titillated looks they’re giving me.

Yeah, we’re giving everyone a show tonight in addition to the games. But not as much of a show as they’d get if we hashed this out in front of everyone. No one here’s so dumb they can’t put two and two together.

Except Dani. She seems to be the only one who doesn’t realize what’s going on. What my end game is. And it’s not because she’s stupid—she’s

really smart, actually. Which is one of the main reasons we started studying together. My friendship with her has done more for my GPA than any of the other resources available to me.

But for some reason, she hasn't caught on to the fact that she's desirable. Or that my behavior is because I'm jealous and want her for myself.

Once inside my room, I stand with my back to her for several moments even after I hear the latch click, indicating she's closed the door behind us. She doesn't say anything either, and I hear her moving around while I take deep breaths with my eyes closed.

The last thing I want is to fuck this up. Which means I need to not act like an asshole. Which means I need to calm down.

"Well?" she finally says, her irritation plain from just that one small syllable. "You're the one who wanted to come back here. And now you're not even talking to me? What the fuck, dude?"

Chuckling, I open my eyes, turning to face her—and stopping short. She's sitting on my bed, her hands behind her propping her up, one leg crossed over the other. She's somehow managed to class up her usual joggers and comfy outfits so that she's still comfortable but also fashionable. It's still totally Dani, just a little more shiny and polished.

I swallow against the sudden dryness in my mouth and ignore my blood rushing south. "God, Dani, you're so beautiful. Do you really not know that?"

She blinks at my declaration, her brows furrowing again in confusion. "Uhh ... thanks?" She looks down at herself and then back at me. "So instead of explaining whatever that nonsense was," she lifts a hand and gestures at the door, "you're going to try to distract me with compliments?"

Sighing, I shake my head and rub the back of my neck. "No. That was just an observation." I sit carefully on the bed next to her, keeping space between us and turning to pull one knee up so I can face her. "Here's the thing." I spread my hands. "I like you."

One brow wings up, a combination of surprise and invitation to explain more.

"*Like* like you. When I see other guys hitting on you—and make no mistake, Tomlinson was absolutely hitting on you—"

“Ha. Yeah. I kinda figured that out with the sweater on my bedroom floor comment.”

I nod sharply. “Right. Good. But that drives me crazy with jealousy.”

She holds up a hand. “Wait, so let me get this straight. First you insult me for looking more girly, and now you’re jealous other guys have noticed? Is that what this is? You finally see me as a girl, and you’re pissed other guys have the balls to try to get with me when you never have?”

“Fuck no. That’s not it at all.” My fingers flex with the urge to grab her arms in an effort to force her to understand what I’m trying to say. “No. I’ve *always* known you were a girl. I’ve *always* been painfully aware of that fact.” I wave a hand around. “You think all this, everything I’ve been doing is just to repair our friendship? I mean, don’t get me wrong, I’ve loved having you as a friend. But I’ve wanted more than that for a long time.”

Her lips part in surprise, and I so want to lean forward and kiss them. But I know that now is definitely not the right time for that.

She shakes her head, her mouth closing, her brows pinching together. “Wait. So this is all so that ... you can get in my pants?”

“God, no.” I slip to the floor and place my hands on her legs. “No, Dani. That’s not what this is about. I mean, well, of course I *want* to do those kinds of things with you. It’s just that’s not *all* I want.”

She shakes her head again. “But you don’t do relationships. You’ve never had a girlfriend for as long as I’ve known you. Wait, have you ever had a girlfriend ever?”

Grinning—I can’t help it, she’s just too cute—I nod. “Yes. I had a couple of girlfriends in high school. But I haven’t had a girlfriend since I met you because I always compared everyone to you and no one could measure up.”

She leans away from me, confusion back on her face as she looks all around the room, as though the walls hold the answers to the questions running through her mind. “No.” She shakes her head once more. “No. That’s not—no.” She finally brings her gaze back to mine. “You’ve always had me firmly in the friend zone. One of the guys. I’m just one of the guys to you.” Her hands come up, and she holds them out as though imploring me to verify the truth of her words.

I squint and tilt my head. “That’s not entirely true. Yeah, you’ve been one of my friends, and we talk about sports and video games like I do with

my guy friends”—I hold up a finger—“which, by the way, is one of the things I find most appealing about you—but you’ve had a boyfriend the whole time. When was I supposed to make a move?”

She scoffs, pushing my hands off her legs and standing to pace the room. “That’s not true.” Whirling around, she points a finger in my face. “You know that’s not true. Luke and I broke up a million times. And you never said *anything*.”

Now it’s my turn to hold up my hands imploringly. “You guys always got back together. Even the first time, when I thought maybe now would be my chance, you talked about how you knew you’d get back together. Since you were clearly still hung up on him, I figured I should wait until you were ready to move on. But that never happened, and then you actually got back together with him like you said all along. So the next time you broke up, I waited again. I wanted to make sure it would stick this time. And of course, it never did.”

I climb to my feet and take a step closer to her. “But this time was different. This time he brought a girl home. This time it seems like it’s over for good.”

She blinks rapidly as she takes in my words, spluttering a little as she tries to formulate a response. Pinching the bridge of her nose, she closes her eyes. “So our entire friendship it’s just a long con? You didn’t actually want to be my friend, you wanted to be my boyfriend.”

As I open my mouth to respond, I realize I’m about to walk into a trap. Closing my mouth, I clear my throat, thinking fast. “I always wanted to be your friend. If I hadn’t wanted that, do you think we would be here right now? Do you really think I would’ve waited around all these years hoping that you would break up with your boyfriend for good? Come on, Dani. You know me better than that. You know I’m not that patient.”

That surprises a laugh out of her, and I breathe out in relief. She waves a hand in the air as though brushing something aside. “Yeah, yeah. Okay. Point taken. Our whole friendship wasn’t a lie. At least not entirely. That’s good to know, I guess.” She spreads her hands in front of her, then lets them fall and hit her thighs. “So what now? I thought we were trying to go back to being friends, but apparently that’s not good enough anymore?”

“Dani, if you only want to be my friend, I’ll still be the best friend you’ve ever had. I’m not going to lie and say that I won’t be disappointed,

but I care about you the most. Is that what you want?”

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CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Dani

I stare at Eli with my mouth hanging open, my eyes bouncing all over his face and body, taking in the hopefulness on his face and the tension held in every muscle. “Eli ...” I breathe. “I’m not even sure what to say. I had no idea you felt this way.”

He throws up his hands. “Seriously? You had no idea? Me kissing you a few weeks ago didn’t give you a clue at all?”

My gaze scrambles all around the room again, hoping to find something to say that will make this all make sense. The problem is that I’m not sure what would make it make sense. I’m not sure it’s possible for it to make sense.

Eli has had a crush on me the entire time we’ve known each other? I’m still reeling from that revelation. So I have no idea what to say about anything.

“I mean,” I start, “Well, uh, I mean. Right. That kiss. You said we should pretend it never happened. That doesn’t exactly match up with your declaration of unrequited love.”

He holds up a finger. “I never said the L word.”

I can’t help laughing, and it seems to break the tension between us, or at least reduce it a little bit. “Okay, fine. I rescind my use of the L word. Regardless”—I make air quotes with my fingers—“‘let’s pretend this never happened,’ doesn’t exactly tell a girl you’ve been wanting to kiss her for years.”

“I figured I’d fucked everything up. You practically sprinted out of here like the place was on fire. And then you wouldn’t respond to my texts. I just didn’t want you to hate me. The last thing I wanted was to lose my best friend. Kissing you then, like that, was a miscalculation on my part. I moved too early. And then I messed everything up. And I’m still trying to make up for the yardage lost as a penalty.”

Grinning, I place my hands on my hips. “Leave it to you to work in a football analogy while discussing the possibility of our friendship turning into a romantic relationship.”

Hope lights up his face. “So it is a possibility?”

Part of me wants to hedge, to drag this out and torture him just a little bit longer. I feel like he deserves it after the shit he’s put me through since Christmas break.

But I can’t keep it up for long. Tapping my chin with one finger, I hum thoughtfully. “I suppose it’s a possibility.”

It has to be, really. Because otherwise? I’m not sure we can have any other kind of relationship after this.

That thought sobers me.

Eli notices the change immediately. “What?”

Shaking my head slowly, I step closer. “It’s just ... this is it. You realize that, right? There’s no coming back from this. Either we ... get together? Or ... I’m not sure what the right term is. Date?”

He shrugs. “That works.”

“Right. Either we date, or we ...” I shrug, my hands spread. “Or we go our separate ways. I don’t think I can just be friends with you knowing that you’ve been secretly harboring feelings for me all along.”

He swallows hard then looks away and squeezes the back of his neck, the motion highlighting his delts and biceps, the waffle weave of his shirt clingy enough to show the muscle definition.

I swallow hard. I’ve always had a thing for a nicely defined set of shoulders, and Eli’s no slouch in that department. (Ha.) He normally works out in a T-shirt, but I’ve seen him shirtless enough times over the years to know how his chest and shoulders and arms look.

I noticed his beauty in the same way one notices the detail of a sculpture—detached and appreciative.

But now? The image of those shoulders rising above me, blocking my view of the ceiling flashes through my mind.

God. Suddenly I'm feeling really warm.

"Well," Eli's voice pulls me out of my horny thoughts. "I mean, it's up to you then, isn't it? You know what I want. The question is, what do you want, Dani? Do you want to date me? Or should we go our separate ways?"

Instead of answering, I step up to him and lay my hand on his chest. His eyes meet mine, confusion and hope warring in them, and when I slide my hand up to his neck and press onto my toes, he brings his head down, his lips meeting mine.

This time there's no hesitation, no burst of *WTF??* in my head. Because I know exactly what the fuck is happening here.

We're doing this.

Starting now.

His hand comes up and cradles the back of my head, holding me in place for the onslaught of his lips and tongue. He nips my bottom lip, making me gasp, and his tongue slips into my mouth.

I meet him, my hand hanging onto the back of his neck, the other holding onto his forearm, my fingers curling around and digging into the soft fabric of his sleeve.

Then his arms wrap around me, and he crushes my body to his, his lips leaving mine and blazing a trail down the column of my neck. "Christ, Dani, I've wanted to taste you everywhere for so fucking long."

All I can do is moan in response. His hands grip my ass, squeezing and tilting my pelvis up to meet his.

A loud knock on the door has us jumping apart, both of us breathing hard. I raise a hand to my lips. I can't believe we just kissed.

Well ... I mean, I can.

I guess I can't believe that I could've had this all along and instead I was holding out for Luke. Luke, who only ever kissed me as a prelude to sex. I mean, when we first got together, he would kiss me all the time. But even that, I think, was really just a prelude to sex. It was just a really long prelude because it took me a while to be ready to take that step.

And even though this was the kind of kiss that definitely leads to sex, I don't think Eli's the type of guy to only kiss me to get something he wants.

No, I *know* he's not that kind of guy.

He's the kind of guy who buys a gift card to a makeup store just because he thinks that's what I might want. Who goes out of his way to take me to said makeup store, even though he knows nothing about makeup and has no desire to learn anything about it. He only did it to make me happy. And to show his support.

"Who is it?" Eli's voice comes out gruff, distracting me from my thoughts. I'd forgotten there was even anybody at the door.

"It's Autumn." She taps at the door again. "Is it safe to come in? Can I open the door?"

Instead of answering, Eli crosses the room and yanks the door open. He leans into the opening, his hand still on the door knob, blocking my view of Autumn. "What do you want, Autumn?"

She clears her throat, which makes her sound almost nervous. Which is strange. I don't think I've ever heard Autumn nervous. "Well, it's just that there's quite a crowd of people out here. And they've started a pool, placing bets on how long you two will be back here. I just thought you might want to know that. And I mean, if you're cool with people betting on how long you last in bed, then by all means, continue. But if you'd rather shut it down, you might need to come out sooner rather than later. Jackson is doing his best, but he's only one guy, and he's not exactly the most forceful." And then she mutters something that sounds almost like, "Except when he's trying to torture me in bed."

Eli rears back. "I did not need to know that last part, Autumn."

I stifle a laugh. It seems I heard her correctly.

Autumn makes no effort to hold back her own laughter. "Well, I'll see you guys out there. Eventually." She manages to peek around Eli and give me a wave, and then she disappears.

Eli closes the door slowly, then turns to face me, his expression unreadable. Then a hint of mischief lights up his eyes. He raises an eyebrow. "Well? What do you think? Should we let them keep placing their bets? We could demand a cut of the money afterward. Or should we head back out and ruin their fun?"

A nervous laugh bubbles out of my chest, and I cover my face with my hands. "Oh my god. I can't believe any of this is happening."

Eli's hands wrap around mine, pulling them away, his smiling face filling my vision. "Which part?"

“All of it!” I pull my hands free to wave them around. “You, me, us, this. A betting pool on how long we’ll have sex! How is this my life?”

His arms cinch behind me, tugging me close again. “I, for one, am glad about the you, me, us part. I could do without the betting pool, though.”

I pat his chest, marveling at the firm muscle beneath his shirt. I’ve felt it before, obviously, but not like this. Not with the freedom to touch and pet to my heart’s content. I mean, not that I’ll do that *now*, of course. But I *could*. I can later, too. “I think that’s decided then.” I circle one of the buttons with my finger, keeping my eyes focused there. “Let’s go out and ruin their fun. We can figure out the answer to how long you last another time.”

When I raise my eyes to his, his grin has a distinctly wicked tinge. “I’m looking forward to it.”

Oh god. “Me too.”

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CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Eli

After adjusting myself to make my hard-on less obvious, I tangle my fingers with Dani's and lead her by the hand back out to game night. We're greeted by a variety of whoops and hollers from everyone, and when I glance back at Dani, she's blushing and ducking her head, but she's smiling. And not a grimace of endurance, but the same delighted smile she wore a few minutes ago when we were still alone in my room.

I'm not embarrassed at all. These assholes can place bets on whatever they want. As long as I'm the one ending up with Dani, I don't give a single solitary fuck.

We make our way to an open spot against the wall. I park myself against it and pull Dani in front of me, wrapping my arms around her and leaning down to kiss her neck, just below her jaw. She tilts her head, giving me free access, but I limit myself to only one more kiss because otherwise I might get carried away. If Dani's embarrassed by some hoots and hollers, she'd turn bright red if we got truly exhibitionistic.

That's never been a particular kink of mine, but at this point I'm so excited to finally get to be with her that if public sex were some kind of requirement, I'd do it happily.

Suddenly I can't wait for game night to be over.

"Do you want me to have Autumn take us off the roster?" I whisper in her ear. "We could leave now and head to your place. Since your roommates are all here, we know we'll have the place to ourselves."

She shifts against me, and I swear to god she's just trying to torture me with her firm ass moving against my dick. But it's actually her indecision dance. If I weren't so horny and dying for her, I would've realized immediately that her shifting her weight from foot to foot is her weighing the options.

Chuckling, I kiss her cheek. "It's fine if you want to stay."

She looks over her shoulder at me. "Are you sure? It's not that I don't want to be alone with you. I do. It's just that I haven't been to a game night in a while, and I was really looking forward to it. And if we leave now ... I'm pretty sure there'd be a new pool popping up immediately."

"You're probably right about that," I murmur against her skin. Hell, there's probably been one going for years about how long it would take us to get together. Maybe all the guys hitting on her lately have had bets going on who could nail her first.

My jaw clenches at that thought. Dammit, if anyone was doing that ...

I need to chill out. I'm making up scenarios in my head to be mad about for no reason. Dani's with me. No one else is going to nail her while I'm in the picture, so even if there was some kind of bet to that effect, they've all lost.

"What I want most is to make you happy," I whisper in her ear. "If staying makes you happy, then I'm happy to stay with you."

With a smile on her face, Dani turns and captures my lips with hers. Just for a second, and then she's facing front again.

Autumn catches my eye from across the room and wiggles her clipboard in the air, then points at Dani and me. "You're next," she mouths in lieu of shouting.

I nod in acknowledgment and herd Dani toward the couch so we can take our place. And once we're playing—*Super Smash Bros* tonight—it's just like old times, with Dani shouting every time anything happens, whether she knocks me out or the other way around.

God, she's so much fun to play with. This is one of my favorite things about her, how into it she gets. How she fiercely devotes herself to anything and everything she does.

What will that be like in bed? I've half wondered that so many times, but now I allow myself to fully contemplate how it'll feel to be the recipient of her undivided attention.

Distracted by my thoughts, I don't react fast enough to her attack, and she knocks me out again. With a whoop of triumph, she stands up and does a little victory dance, her ass shaking right next to my face before she turns and points at me. "Ha! I won! You lost! Eat that!"

Standing, I wrap my arms around her and pull her in for a kiss. "I wouldn't want to lose to anyone else."

There's a collective, "Awww" from the people close enough to hear me, and Dani pushes away, her cheeks pink again.

I let her lead me away from the couch so the next duo can take our place. We end up by the snacks, and Dani snags a small bunch of grapes, her eyes sparkling as she pops one in her mouth. "You want me to forfeit my next fight?" she asks before popping a second one in.

Arching an eyebrow, I shrug, crossing my arms and leaning one shoulder against the wall next to her. "That's up to you, babe. I wouldn't dream of trying to boss you around."

"Oooh, smart man." She grins at me.

"Sometimes."

That provokes a bark of laughter. "No, but seriously. Do you want me to so we can go?"

Straightening, I wrap an arm around her and pull her close, brushing a few stray strands of hair out of her face. She looks up at me, her expression open, her eyes soft. Expectant.

I let out a low grunt. "Do you want to forfeit? Or would you rather keep playing?"

Her eyes drop to my chest, and she raises a hand to trace circles around one of the buttons on my shirt. She tilts her head back-and-forth in a gesture of ambivalence. "Part of me wants to stay," she says slowly, "but part of me really likes the idea of going back to my place." Her eyes lift to mine. "You make a good point about knowing that my roommates will be here and that we'll have the place to ourselves. When else are we guaranteed that kind of privacy?"

I carefully keep my expression neutral, not wanting to pressure her. If she wants to spend time alone with me, I want her to reach the conclusion on her own. "Well, we can weigh the pros and cons of each option if you like."

The grin that takes over her face is breathtaking. But then again, I've always thought she was especially beautiful when she smiles. "A pro-con list, huh? I can see how that might be useful."

Rubbing my hand up and down her back, I dip my head and nip at her earlobe before trailing a line of kisses down her neck. She makes a loud sound of pleasure in her throat, and her hands grip my head as though she doesn't want me to stop. But I do anyway.

I lift my head, a wicked smile playing over my lips. "What are the pros of staying?"

She blinks at me as though my words make no sense. Then she clears her throat once, twice, then, "I'm sorry, what was the question?"

Laughing, I shake my head. "I think that might be the answer to our question. Are there any pros to staying?"

She pulls away. Not completely, but enough to put space between our bodies. I can't say I'm not disappointed. Raising one hand to her mouth, she drums her fingers on her lips. "Hmmm. Well ... normally I would say that staying means I can spend more time with my friends." She glances at me. "But I have a feeling that I'll be spending all my time with you either way."

"I have no objection to that."

That earns me a grin. Serious again, she looks out over the crowd in the living room, her eyes focusing briefly on the game on the television. "If I stay and win, I get bragging rights."

"Are bragging rights that important to you?"

She tilts her head to one side, her eyes narrowed as she hums in thought. "I mean, it *is* fun to brag."

With a laugh, I pull her close to me again, unwilling to allow the space between us to continue for so long for no reason. She melts against me, laying her head on my shoulder. I can't help thinking that's maybe a point in my favor. "Any other pros you can think of?"

She hums again, but eventually shakes her head.

"And what are the pros of leaving with me?"

Her eyes find mine. A smile blooms on her face. "Hmm. Well, let me think." She taps her lips with one finger.

I roll my eyes. "You have to think that hard about it, huh?"

With a laugh, she presses herself against me, going up on her tiptoes to brush a kiss across my mouth. "The most obvious answer is that we'd get to

be alone.”

I tilt my chin up, a minor gesture of challenge. “And what would we do if we were alone?”

Smirking, she gives me a *puh-lease* look. “I’m sure we could find ways to entertain ourselves.”

“Oh, I’m sure we could. But I’d like you to be more specific.”

Her hand trails up my chest and captures my shoulder. “Hmm, well, I was thinking we could go to my bedroom.”

“Yeah? And what would we do there?”

“Take your shirt off.”

My eyebrows raise. “Just my shirt?”

She lifts one shoulder. “To start with.”

“Hmm. Okay. And what would you do with me shirtless?”

“Look my fill.”

That makes me start in surprise, my blood rushing south. “You’ve been wanting to look at me shirtless?”

“I mean ...” Her eyes meet mine briefly before darting away, her cheeks turning pink again. “Of course I have.”

I let out a playful gasp. “Dani Roberts, do you have a crush on me?”

She rolls her eyes, her cheeks even pinker when she meets my questioning gaze. “I guess?”

“And why am I just now learning about this?”

Laughing, she shakes her head. “And when was I supposed to tell you?”

“I dunno. Maybe in my room a little bit ago? When I confessed my undying attraction to you?”

She laughs harder at *undying attraction*. “Were you trying to kill off your attraction?”

“You were pretty well hung up on someone else for years, so kinda, yeah.”

Her arms circle my neck. “Well, I’m glad you never managed to make it happen.”

Dipping my head, I kiss her. “Me too,” I whisper against her lips before kissing her again.

“Well,” a voice breaks into our bubble, causing Dani to pull back quickly. “I guess that answers my question.”

I blink a few times before registering Autumn standing next to us, scratching something out on her clipboard. “No, no. As you were. Don’t mind me. I’m just organizing the next round of the tournament. Feel free to keep making out by the snacks. Just, y’know, fair warning that it does put some people off, and I think a few of the others would like food, they just aren’t sure about entering the snog zone to get it.”

“Snog zone?” Dani repeats, hysterical laughter barely suppressed.

Grinning, Autumn just shrugs. “Do you have a better term? Anyway. I’ve taken you out of the next round. Carry on.” With that, she spins on her heel and heads off to talk to someone else.

“Well,” Dani says after a beat, her voice thoughtful, “I guess that solves that problem.”

“You ready to go, then?”

She grins at me. “Let’s go.”

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CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

Dani

I'm positively giddy as Eli and I leave his apartment and head to my house. He drives, his hand finding its way to my leg when he doesn't need both hands on the wheel. After a moment, I cover his hand with mine, threading my fingers through his. He glances over and grins at me.

My heart pounds in my chest. We're going to my house for the specific purpose of being alone. While I'm sure everyone who was paying attention could figure out where we were going and why, we at least didn't have a chorus of knowing howls chasing us out the door the way they greeted us coming out of Eli's room.

That was so embarrassing.

But I guess it's worth it given the results of our time in Eli's bedroom.

Who knew my best friend could kiss like that? His full lips and the little bit of stubble from shaving so long ago, the way he kisses my neck like it gives him life ...

I can't wait to find out what he'll do without an audience.

Before I know it, he's parked in front of my house and undoing his seatbelt. I hurry to catch up, pulling my keys out of my coat pocket as we approach the front door.

Once we're inside, he backs me against the door, his mouth covering mine. His hands slide under the open halves of my coat and push it off my shoulders. I have to shimmy to get it off since it's trapped between my body and the door, and the action makes him groan.

“Christ, Dani. I’ve waited so long for this. Hoped. Ached. Wished. I’m almost afraid it’s a dream, and I’ll wake up disappointed.”

“Well, if it’s a dream then we’ll both wake up disappointed.” He nips my earlobe again, just hard enough to cause a tiny burst of pain. “It’s not a dream,” I gasp.

“Thank god.” His arms wrap tightly around me, pulling me against him as his lips part mine so his tongue can dive into my mouth.

I meet his enthusiasm with my own, the short hair on the back of his head soft and velvety against my palm.

But he still has his coat on, and as much as I’m enjoying kissing him, I want to do it with far fewer layers between us. And maybe not against the hard, cold door.

Sliding my hands down to his chest, I push enough that he reluctantly breaks off our kiss, though not without stealing another peck or two. “Take off your coat,” I demand, my voice low and husky.

He grins, his eyes gleaming in the low light leaking through the blinds on the big bay window next to our front door. “Yes, ma’am.”

Stepping back, he shucks off his coat and tosses it on the end of the couch. I take advantage of the brief moment of no contact to pick up my own and do the same.

“Now what?” he asks, his chest heaving with his rapid breaths.

“Let’s go to my room.”

His grin grows wider, and he reaches for me, his hands on my hips as he backs up to the hallway, then turns me in front of him, groping my ass as he propels me forward.

Giggling, I open my door and tumble inside, turning in time to watch him kick the door closed and yank his shirt up and off, dropping it on the floor next to him.

“Hang on,” I murmur, moving to the lamp on my bedside table and switching it on before heading to the other side of the bed to close the curtains. No need to give the neighborhood a show, after all.

When I turn to face him again, he has his hands resting on his belt, one eye quirked in question. Biting my lip, I toe off my shoes and climb onto the bed, sitting on it cross-legged and letting my eyes travel over his bare torso.

He's been bulking in the off season so he's not as defined as I know he can get, but he hasn't gained enough fat to completely cover his muscle definition. Especially when he's flexing, like he obviously is now.

"Oooh, is this my seat at the gun show?" I ask, propping my elbow on my knee and my chin on my hand.

Eli chuckles, but lifts his arms to flex his biceps, his pecs popping as well. And damn if that isn't delicious. Yeah, we're both joking around, but also we aren't.

I like seeing him flex, and he enjoys my appreciative gaze on him.

Soon, though, he's ready to be done putting on a show, and he crosses to me, plants his hands on the bed on either side of me, and kisses me again. My hands go to his face, cradling his cheeks as he kisses me, then clinging to his neck as he guides me so I'm lying down, my head on the pillows.

He climbs on with me, his knees nudging my legs apart so he can settle between my thighs, and I feel him hard behind the denim of his jeans.

His hand cradles the back of my head, holding me like I'm something precious while he devours my mouth, then kisses his way down my neck to my chest. He tugs the low scoop neck of my sweater down a little, giving him access to the top of my breasts, his stubble scraping deliciously against my skin.

He adjusts and lifts his head, his eyes meeting mine. "This okay?"

At my nod, my lower lip caught between my teeth, he pulls the neck of my shirt even lower until he's revealed one of my breasts, still safely encased in my light blue heather T-shirt bra.

If I'd known anyone else would see my lingerie choices, I might've chosen something else. But Eli doesn't seem put off by the utilitarian cotton.

He cups my breast, his thumb caressing back and forth over the center until my nipple perks up. Then with his eyes locked on mine, he catches the edge of the fabric in his teeth and tugs it out of the way until my nipple is revealed. He breaks eye contact as he circles my nipple with his tongue and then sucks it into his mouth.

I let out a low sound, something between a grunt and a groan at the sweet sensation of him sucking on my tit, the pleasure sending heat pooling between my thighs. Arching my back, I press my boobs up in wordless encouragement.

To my disappointment, he releases my nipple. But my disappointment is short-lived.

“Take off your shirt,” he says, the words coming out with a rough edge.

I’d normally smile at the fact he’s echoing my earlier command to him, but right now I just want his mouth on me again. He moves back, sitting on his knees and holding out his hands to me to pull me upright so I can do what he wants.

As soon as my shirt is off, he reaches behind me, struggling for a second to unhook my bra, which makes me smile. He grins back with a huff of laughter, then the hooks spring free, and he pulls the straps off my arms and flings the bra away like it offends him.

Before I can react, he’s on me again, his hands cupping my breasts, bowing to tongue and suck and nip at each nipple, and all impulse to laugh flees.

“God, Eli,” I half moan, half whisper.

He grunts his satisfaction as he presses me back down to the pillows, his mouth on mine again, his hands roaming my upper body, then hooking in the waistband of my pants. When he starts tugging, I lift my hips, helping him push the fabric down and off until I’m completely bare before him.

After dropping my pants and underwear on the floor, he sits back and looks at me for a moment. “God, Dani,” he breathes. “You’re fucking beautiful.”

Tears prick the back of my eyes at the sincerity in his voice, the worship in his gaze.

No one else has called me beautiful before.

Cute, sure. Pretty, once or twice. Ellie called me a hottie the other day, and Autumn has called me gorgeous.

But never, ever beautiful.

Beautiful was reserved for Other Girls. The girls that I was distinctly and proudly Not Like.

I was many things—strong, smart, dedicated, tenacious ... but not beautiful.

Which was fine, because it’s not like I ever felt beautiful anyway. Even the other positive adjectives about my appearance never really felt like they fit very well. And under different circumstances I might even try to argue with someone who called me beautiful.

But not Eli. Not now. Not like this.

He definitely means it, and with the way he's looking at me, I actually *feel* beautiful. For the first time ever.

It's heady. And powerful.

I blink away the urge to cry—because now is *not* the time for tears, and I definitely don't want Eli to misinterpret them. That would totally ruin the mood. "Your turn."

Grinning, he stands and undoes his belt, pushing off his jeans and underwear with the same brisk economy of movement as when he removed his coat and shirt.

His dick juts out straight and hard and thick, and it drags up my inner thigh as he climbs back onto the bed with me, getting tantalizingly close to where we both want it, but not so close as to be dangerous.

"I'm not on birth control," I murmur as I welcome him into my arms.

"I have a condom," he responds, dotting kisses down my shoulder. "We'd use it even if you were."

He moves to one side of me, propping himself on his arm, his other hand trailing over my body, exploring my curves, rubbing my nipples, moving to my hip, across my lower belly, then sliding between my thighs until he cups my pussy.

His eyes follow the path his hand travels, but he brings them back to mine when he begins to massage my mound, spreading me open to dip a finger inside me then rubbing my wetness in circles around my clit. "Tell me what you like."

"Mmm." I lift my hips, pressing myself into his hand. "I like this."

His teeth flash in a quick grin. "Good. But don't be afraid to be more specific. Or show me how you like to be touched. I want to know how to give you pleasure."

My cheeks heat, which prompts another grin from him. "You're so cute when you're embarrassed," he whispers. Which only embarrasses me more, and he chuckles when I cover my face with my hands.

He kisses my wrist, his finger dipping inside me again, but this time going deeper so the heel of his palm grinds on my clit and he searches out my G spot. I gasp when he finds it, my hands falling away from my face so I can grip the sheets instead.

“That’s it,” he coaxes. “Show me what feels good so I can keep doing more.”

“Fuck. Yes. That.”

His lips find mine, and he kisses me deeply as his fingers continue their work.

God, I always figured he’d be good with his hands. A starting tight end for a Division I college team? Who cooks for fun in his spare time? And I’ve seen how easily he moves the weight plates and bars around in the gym. He’s got good physical and spatial awareness, and he pays attention.

And now he’s paying attention to me.

He slips another finger inside me, his thumb moving in circles over my clit as he rubs my G spot like he’s beckoning my orgasm to come closer. And it obeys.

My hips move with the rhythm of his fingers, my hands finding his shoulders and tightening in the firm muscle.

He breaks the kiss to whisper filthy things in my ear. “Yes, Dani. You’re so sexy. I can’t wait to feel this tight little pussy wrapped around my cock. But you know what needs to happen before then?”

My eyes pop open in surprise. There are prerequisites for sex?

He gives me that sexy grin of his. “You need to come for me. I want to feel your pussy trying to milk my fingers, and then I’ll give you my cock. Alright? Can you do that for me?”

At my nod, he redoubles his efforts. “Yeah, baby. I know you can.” He continues telling me all the things he wants to do to me, all the ways he wants to fuck me, and all I have to do is have an orgasm as the price of admission.

No one has ever talked to me during sex like this. No one has ever actually cared that much if I got off. Luke made a token effort, but quickly gave up.

Eli seems like he has all the time in the world, and doesn’t seem to mind that I’m not going off in seconds.

Eventually the combination of his words and his fingers has me so close I can taste it. My breath comes in quick gasps, and I couldn’t hold back my moans if I wanted to.

“Yeah, Dani. I can feel you tightening on my fingers. You’re right there, aren’t you? Come for me, baby, and I’ll give you everything you want.”

At his words, my whole body convulses as the pleasure washes through me. He keeps going, whispering filthy encouragement, his fingers still moving, pushing wave after wave of bliss from my center outward until I can't take anymore. Wrapping my hand around his wrist, I push enough that he stops, gently removing his fingers from my pussy and sliding his hand up to cover my belly.

"That was beautiful," he says quietly, bending his head to kiss me again.

Then he rolls away from me, leaning down to get something from the floor. When he comes up again, he has the condom packet in his hand. Sitting up on his knees, he tears it open and rolls it on, then moves between my thighs.

One hand gripping his cock, he runs the head up and down my pussy, his eyes on mine. "Ready?"

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CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

Eli

She nods her answer, and I press forward, both of us gasping as I slide inside her. Just the tip. At least to start with.

I pull back, which prompts a whiny sound of protest from Dani. I don't think I've ever heard her do anything like that before, and I can't help chuckling.

Eyes narrowed, she shoots me a glare. "Are you seriously laughing? Now?"

That just makes me laugh more, which I know doesn't help at all. "Only because I've never heard you whine before. Or anything even kind of like whining. Even when you're tired and overwhelmed and have too much to do. You've complained a bit, sure, but never *whined*. It was unexpected and caught me off guard."

"And you promised me dick." She glares at me, all hint of whining gone. "And then you pull out immediately? What the fuck is that?"

Laughing again, I drop to my hands over her. "I always knew you'd be feisty in bed."

She rolls her eyes. "Oh you did, did you?"

"Mmhhh." I kiss her softly, pressing inside her again. A little more this time, but still not all the way.

When I pull out again, she makes a low sound of frustration in her throat and turns her head away, one hand on my chest pushing me back so she can glare at me again. When I lean away, she props herself up on her

elbows. “You said, and I quote, ‘Just give me an orgasm, Dani, and I’ll fuck you every way possible.’ Remember? It was like thirty seconds ago, tops. I know that everyone says sex short-circuits your brain, but I’d think you’d be able to retain more memory than a goldfish.”

God, I love this woman. I can’t tell her that yet, though. I know it. But it’s been true for ages, and this just cements that fact.

She’s perfect. Everything about her is absolutely perfect, from her dedication and tenacity to the way she’s busting my balls in bed.

I wouldn’t want anything other than this. I can’t imagine ever giving this up. I always knew her ex was a complete toolbag, but this absolutely confirms it. Who would ever choose anyone else when they could have Dani?

“I remember, babe,” I reassure her. “But I plan on making this last. I want it to be good.”

“Oh and you think that whatever bullshit this is where you barely put it in before pulling out again is going to accomplish that?”

I nod, still unable to wipe the grin from my face. “I do. Just trust me, okay?”

She grumbles, but lies flat again and mutters, “Okay, fine.”

I scoop up her legs behind her knees, squeezing her hamstrings slightly. “God, I love your legs.”

That seems to be the right thing to say, because she finally smiles at me. “You do?”

“Fuck, yeah. They’re so strong. It’s fucking hot.” I bend her legs back toward her, pressing inside halfway. “I’ve always loved your legs. Your ass too. One of the best and worst parts of working out together was when you’d wear those tiny shorts and knee socks for deadlifts. I fucking live for those outfits, but I’d have to look away a good chunk of the time so I didn’t have a boner the whole workout.”

She splutters out a laugh.

“Who’s laughing at who now?”

She shakes her head, one of her hands reaching down to caress my thigh. “Aww, poor Eli. Getting all turned on by his workout partner.”

“It was a real problem. Especially since it wasn’t like I could ask you to help me take care of it later.”

Another spluttering laugh, followed by an almost wistful expression. “No, I don’t suppose you could’ve.”

I hum as I press inside her again, letting my eyes fall closed. She flexes her pussy around me, and I swear to god, I’m in fucking heaven. “Next time I will, though,” I murmur.

“Deal.” She sounds smug, but when I thrust into her, it turns into a gasp.

And then I begin to make good on my promise. Obviously I can’t fuck her every possible way in one session. But I’ll do my best to make a solid start.

I move slowly at first, tilting her hips up with one hand palming her ass, making sure I hit her where it counts.

I don’t know if I’ll be able to fuck another orgasm out of her—which is why I made sure she got one before we even started—but I’m sure going to try.

Soon, though, I can’t hold back and I move faster, needing more. More speed, more friction, more *her*.

I want everything she’s willing to give me. Every groan and gasp and whimper. Every scathing comment, every glare, every shudder.

I just want her. Naked and unashamed. And I’ll give her the same in return.

Lowering to my elbows, I gather her chest against mine, burying my face in her neck as I chase my orgasm, loving the feel of her heart pounding against my chest, the softness of her breasts tipped by the hard peaks of her nipples.

Her legs wrap around mine, her feet braced on my calves as her hips rise to meet mine on every thrust, and that’s what does me in. Grinding into her, I empty myself, my whole body contracting with my release.

I take a minute to bask in our closeness, her bare skin on mine, her arms and legs twined around me, holding me close. I want nothing more than to stay here forever. Or at least as long as possible.

After a moment, I place a kiss on her shoulder and roll to the side, pulling off the condom and tying it off before wrapping it in a couple of tissues from the box on her bedside table.

Then I roll back toward her and gather her against me, sighing in contentment.

I had no idea this is where this night would end, but I couldn't pick a better ending if I tried. And I'm looking forward to many more nights like this.

* * *

"We should go on a date." I say it casually—or what I hope is casually—as Dani finishes racking the bar after her last set of squats.

She straightens and tosses me a weird look as she moves to take the weight plates off the end. She's wearing black booty shorts—these are new and form fitting, different from her old school jogging shorts she usually wears. She's paired them with pink knee socks with hearts all over them. A few weeks ago I would've thought they were so not Dani, but now I realize she has an inner girly girl she's been suppressing for a long time. And if there were any doubt in my mind that this outfit is specifically for me, given the fact that we're still in January's icy grip and she's only ever worn shorts in the spring and summer, the only explanation is that she wore them because she knew I'd like them.

"What do you mean by a 'date'?" She holds up her hands and makes air quotes before moving to the other side of the bar to take off those plates.

I grab my gym bag and hers, and we head to the leg press machine to start our accessory work. "Uh, you know, the normal thing? Like dinner and a movie or something?"

She gives me this look that's half smirk, half *you're ridiculous*. "You want to take me to dinner and a movie?"

"I mean ... yeah?"

Laughing, she starts putting forty-five pound plates on the leg press while I drop our bags and wipe the machine down, indicating with a flourish that she should go first.

After her weights are set, she settles in and powers out her reps. She watches me adjust the weights for my reps as she climbs out of the seat and grabs her water bottle. "You don't sound so sure about that."

I shrug and sit down, placing my feet and releasing the safeties, but not starting yet. "We're dating, right? So we should go on a date. Or multiple dates, even."

“Right,” she says slowly, holding her water bottle in front of her mouth but not drinking. “But isn’t the point of going on dates to get to know the other person? And also sort of a prerequisite for sex? You don’t have to buy me dinner to bang me. I’m kind of a sure thing.” Her eyes sparkle as she takes a swig of water.

Shaking my head, I chuckle, then focus on my reps so we don’t hog the machine for too long. “Okay, you make a valid point,” I admit as I climb out of the seat and help her adjust the weights. “But the other purpose of going on dates is to spend time together.”

“True. But we do that already anyway.” She gestures between us before setting her feet. “Case in point.”

I lean against the top of the platform, forcing her to look at me and not letting her start yet. “Do you not want to go out with me?”

She rolls her eyes and shakes her head. “Is that what you think this is? I just think it’s silly that you want to spend a bunch of money on me like that. We already know each other. We already hang out all the time. What’s the point?”

Stepping back, I let her get through her second set before answering. Holding out a hand, I help her to her feet, and instead of releasing her, pull her close. “The point is that I want to spoil you. It’s my money. I want to spend it. And I want to do the types of things that boyfriends do for their girlfriends. So if I want to take you to dinner and buy you flowers and whatever else, I get to.”

Her lower lip disappears into her mouth, and I can see her fighting back a smile. “Alright. If it’s that important to you, we can do that. Do I need to dress up?”

I look her up and down. “Baby, you can wear anything you like. It doesn’t matter to me. Having you with me is the highlight of any day.”

Her head tips back as she laughs, but I can see that she’s pleased with my answer despite her amusement.

Before releasing her, I give her a quick kiss.

“Hey!” shouts Dylan from where he’s sitting on the bench press. “This is a weight room. Not a makeout party.”

Grinning, I flip him off, while Dani gives him a stink eye. “Come off it, Dylan. We all know you’re just jealous.”

“Of who?” he calls back. “You? Or Eli?”

“Me of course.” She does a curtsy. “You only wish you could squat like me.”

He laughs, and sets his water bottle on the floor. “You know it, hot stuff. If only our whole team had legs like yours, we’d be unbeatable.”

“Damn right,” she quips, turning to grin at me.

Once upon a time—very recently in fact—that exchange would have my blood boiling. Dylan was one of the guys who was hitting on her at the party a few weeks ago, and I know I saw him checking her out last night.

But it’s clear to me that she has no interest in him. And despite the fact that I had to convince her to go on an actual date with me, I’m pretty confident I’m the only man she’s interested in at all.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

Dani

After my workout, I come home to find Autumn and Ellie in the living room. Usually I don't have strong feelings one way or the other about the presence of any of my roommates, though I'm mostly happy to have the house to myself.

But this time, I'm glad they're here.

"So, uh," I start as I take off my jacket and toe off my boots. "Something weird happened."

Ellie hits pause on whatever show they're watching—some kind of reality cooking show from the looks of it—and they both turn to give me their attention.

"What happened?" Autumn asks from her usual spot on the armchair while Ellie pats the couch cushion next to her.

I perch on the end of the couch, my hands in my lap. "Eli wants to take me out on a date."

They both blink at me, and then Ellie bursts out laughing.

For her part, Autumn just gives me that Sphinx-like smile of hers and props her chin on her hand. "And why is that weird?" To her credit, she asks the question calmly. Like we're having a normal conversation, even though Ellie's still cracking up on the other end of the couch.

"Well ..." I glance at Ellie, who's now wiping her eyes with the sleeve of her sweatshirt. "I mean it's Eli. And me. We've been hanging out for

years. Even though things have ... changed ... between us, I didn't really think we needed to go on *dates*."

Autumn tilts her head to one side, considering this. "Have you been on a lot of dates in the past?"

My eyes dart around the room, and I rub one palm on my thigh. This feels like some kind of trick question. "Define a lot?"

Waving a hand, Autumn dismisses that. "You dated the same guy off and on for years. What were dates like with him?"

I snort laugh when I think about the idea of Luke taking me on a date.

Autumn just watches me expectantly, eyebrows raised, and Ellie finally stops laughing. In fact, she leans forward, turning to face me. "Hang on, hang on," she says, one hand extended. "Wait wait wait. Why did Autumn asking about your last boyfriend taking you on dates make you laugh like that? He *did* take you on dates, right? Right?" She looks almost panicky as she glances at Autumn, who remains as placid as ever.

Another snort comes out of me, and I shake my head. "I mean, if you count protein shakes at the gym as a date? Sure. Or driving together to lifting competitions." I clasp my hands by my cheek and bat my eyes. "So romantic."

"It could be romantic," Autumn puts in over Ellie's derisive snort. She glances at Ellie. "It could. Think about it. Lifting is a shared interest for them. It would be easy to make it both a romantic experience and one that would strengthen their relationship. I'm sure competitions are stressful, so doing something for your partner to show you care about and support them would be both romantic and sweet."

Ellie relents, tilting her head from side to side. "Okay. I guess that's a good point. Still, though, it's definitely not a date."

"True." Autumn returns her gaze to me. "Did you find traveling to competitions together romantic?"

"Um ..." I hedge. Was it romantic? At the time I was glad to spend time together, but, no, it was never anything I would ever call romantic. "Not so much, no."

Autumn hums thoughtfully, and Ellie remains blessedly silent. "Did you feel supported and cared for?"

I open my mouth, but pause to consider the question before answering. Did I? Was Luke ever supportive?

I mean, on the face of it, yes. He wanted me to do well, pushed me to succeed. But it blended in with my dad's version of support which felt a lot more like berating than encouragement, now that I've gained enough time and distance to look at it objectively. Luke's support, much like my dad's, seemed to hinge around all the ways I could've—should've—done better, and never on celebrating my actual success or accomplishments.

I'm not a world-class lifter. I never have been. And I don't think changing focus to Olympic lifting would've had the results either my dad or my ex boyfriend wanted it to. Which is part of the reason I refused.

That and I was really tired of the both of them trying to tell me what to do, and graduating and going to college somewhere else seemed like the best way to put a stop to it.

I just figured Luke and I both needed some time to grow up, experience more of the world than a tiny town in Montana.

God, I should've cut him loose years ago, shouldn't I? That first time he broke up with me, I should've let him go and gotten over him and moved on.

And while I knew Autumn and Ellie at that point, we were acquaintances who said hi in the dorm halls, not actual friends yet, so I couldn't have turned to them for advice and support like I do now.

I was a loner most of that first semester. My roommate at the time and I tolerated each other, by which I mean we mostly just stayed out of each other's way. We weren't friends, though we didn't hate each other either. But I wasn't upset when she opted to live with one of her other friends sophomore year.

It wasn't until Eli and I became friends that I started having people to hang out with. The girls in my dorm seemed silly—even Autumn and Ellie, while they seemed nice enough, were not people I would've chosen to hang out with, what with Autumn's boho fairy girl vibe and Ellie's classic girl-next-door look, so at odds with my lifetime of cultivating a tomboy persona.

When Piper moved in with me, I wasn't sure how well we'd get along at first. To be honest, the best I hoped for was a repeat of freshman year where we mostly avoided each other. To my surprise, she was as interested in football as I was, though I did think it was kinda weird she went to watch

their practices. That was until I learned that her brother was the new transfer quarterback.

Once we started hanging out more, and I invited her to start coming to game nights and other things Eli invited me to, it was clear that despite her more feminine appearance, we had a lot in common.

I have her to thank for pulling me into the craziness of living with her and Autumn and Ellie. But I wouldn't have it any other way.

Finally I shake my head. "Supportive isn't a word I would pick for Luke. He would say he supported me, but it wasn't the way I wanted to be supported. He was too pushy, and his version of support came with a side of negging."

"That's fair," Autumn says. "What about Eli? Does he support you the way you want?"

"I think so," I say slowly, thinking back over the course of our relationship. I hadn't necessarily thought about it before—so I hadn't realized it—but Eli has always been unfailingly encouraging with whatever I try to do. He's been my hype man this whole time, with no hint of a put-down lingering anywhere.

Until my experiments with a new look at the beginning of this semester, anyway. That's the first time he's been anything other than immediately encouraging. And now I have an answer why. It's not that he didn't like it or only saw me as a piece of ass or whatever other thing I dreamt up.

It's because he was mind-bendingly jealous and didn't know how to deal. At all.

I think that's why it hurt so much for him to react so badly. It wasn't just the betrayal of my close friend—which was bad enough—but it was such a slap for *him*—the only person I've ever truly felt supported by—to not be his usual supportive, encouraging self.

"Yes," I say more firmly. "He does."

"Right. Good. That's good." Autumn smiles.

"It is," Ellie agrees. "And I think you're used to that by now, right?" At my nod, she continues. "But you're used to that in the context of friendship. And now that you're moving into *more* than friendship, you're not used to a boyfriend being sweet and kind and thoughtful that way because Luke is your only frame of reference. *Of course* he wants to take you on a date, Dani." From her tone of voice, I feel like she really wants to sub *silly* or

dummy for Dani in that sentence. “He cares about you. He wants to make sure you know how important you are to him. Frankly, I find it sad that you were in a relationship for as long as you were and your boyfriend never did that for you.”

Before I can respond, Autumn shoots her a look. “We’re not criticizing our friend right now.”

“I’m not!” Ellie protests, holding up her hands. “If anything, it’s a criticism of her dick of an ex. You have to admit, it is kinda sad. Even you’ve been taken on dates plenty of times, and you just finally started your first serious relationship in—well, as long as I’ve known you at least—not too long ago.”

Autumn’s narrowed eyes and pursed lips seem to have no effect on Ellie, who just shrugs and says, “What? You know it’s the truth!”

After a long moment of them staring at each other, Autumn calmly returns her attention to me. “Let Eli take you out. It’ll make him happy”—she holds up a hand and starts ticking off her points on her fingers—“it doesn’t violate your boundaries or personhood, and it’ll help you realize what a healthy relationship could be like. I see no downsides.”

And that’s when we finally get to the real seat of my objection. It’s not that I *don’t* want to go on a date with Eli ...

I throw up my hands, feeling ridiculous for what I’m about to say. “I don’t know what to wear!”

Autumn and Ellie burst into laughter. “Is that the problem?” Ellie asks. “Don’t worry, friend. We’ve got you covered.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-SIX

Eli

I know Dani thinks it's silly that I want to take her out on a date, but I don't care. I've been wanting to do this since we first met. Now that I actually can, I'm not going to just abandon the idea because she thinks it's unnecessary.

Just because something is unnecessary doesn't mean it's not worthwhile.

Game nights on Thursdays aren't *necessary*, but they're fun.

Dates are the same way. Especially with someone you already know well. It's not *necessary* for any of the usual reasons. But I plan on having fun, even if it's something silly.

She didn't seem too excited about my dinner and a movie idea, so I've decided on something different instead.

Grinning, I knock on her front door, then stuff my hands into my coat pockets as I wait for her—or someone, anyway—to answer.

It's Piper who pulls the door open, a wide smile on her face as she looks me up and down, taking in my dark wash jeans, leather shoes, and tucked in button-down shirt showing through the open halves of my leather jacket.

"Hey, Eli. You clean up nice."

"Thanks, Piper. You look nice too."

She laughs and shakes her head, glancing down at her leggings and sweater as she pulls the door wide and steps out of the way. "I look like a basic white girl, but thanks for the compliment anyway."

Chuckling, I follow her gesture inside, stepping in far enough for her to close the door behind me.

“Dani should be out in a few.” She looks me over again, perching on the arm of the chair with her arms crossed. “What are you guys doing? Dani said something about a movie, maybe?”

“Nah.” My smile is irrepressible. “She didn’t seem enthusiastic about that idea, so I’ve changed plans.”

Wrinkling her nose, Piper nods. “You’re right. She really didn’t seem that excited about going to the movies.” She shrugs. “I dunno why not, though. I love going to the movies.”

“Dani likes to be more active, I think. And we’ve watched tons of movies together, though usually at my place, not the theater. She often gives a running commentary, and while I enjoy it, she couldn’t really do that at a theater, you know?”

Piper nods, her gaze both appraising and approving. “You’re right. I’ve noticed that about her too. Good call.”

Just then, Dani appears in the doorway, running a hand down the skirt of a black dress that wraps around her waist and ties at the side. There’s a kind of ruffle along the bottom that travels up to her waist where it overlaps in the front.

She looks gorgeous, and the thought of undoing the tie and unwrapping her like a Christmas present has me shifting my stance, my hand going into my jeans pocket to hide my growing hard-on.

But that will have to wait until the end of the date. I plan on taking her out and showing her off and having a great time.

“You said you’d planned a more active date,” Piper mutters as I move past her to get to Dani. “Is she dressed okay?”

Glancing at Piper, I dip my chin in a slight nod to reassure her that Dani is dressed just fine. Holding out my hand to Dani, I wait for her fingers to touch mine so I can spin her and say, “Damn, D. You look gorgeous.”

She looks down, obviously still uncomfortable with my compliments. Oh well. She’ll just have to get used to it. Because when she meets my eyes again, she’s smiling, and I know she enjoys the compliment even if it still feels a little weird for her.

“You ready?”

She looks at her roommates as though needing confirmation before nodding. "Where are we going?"

But after the way she laughed at my dinner and a movie suggestion, I feel like keeping tonight's plan a surprise. "You'll see."

She laughs, and Ellie splutters from her spot in the hallway. "Seriously? You're not going to tell her?"

"You were the one that said she needs more romance in her life," Autumn says acerbically.

"Well, yeah," Ellie responds defensively. "I'm pretty sure you agree with me about that. I'm not so sure that a surprise first date fits the bill, though."

Autumn crosses her arms and props her shoulder against the wall. She gives me an appraising look while Dani finishes putting on the coat I'm holding for her. "I don't know, El. I think we can trust Eli's judgment here."

I flash her a grin. "Thanks for the vote of confidence."

"Anytime."

Shaking my head, I return my attention to Dani. She's the one I want to pay attention to anyway. And regardless of what Autumn says, I'm not sure I believe that she'll always take my side. In fact I'm quite confident that if it came down to a choice between Dani and me, she'd pick Dani every time.

And honestly, I wouldn't want it any other way. Dani needs other friends to have her back unconditionally too. I'm still a little shocked that Autumn decided to help me win over Dani at all. And I know that the only reason she did is because she believes I'm what Dani really wants. And not only that, but I'm what Dani really needs as well.

Between watching her and Jackson get together and listening to her talk about her friends, it's clear that everything she does is what she believes is in her friends' best interests. According to her, a relationship with me is in Dani's best interest. After I was such a dick to her when she and Jackson started dating, it's amazing to me that she could put that aside to help me out. It just goes to show what kind of person she really is.

At this point I'm glad she's on my team. And I'll do whatever it takes to keep that going for us as long as I can.

Dani zips her puffy coat closed, tucking her phone and keys in her pockets. "All right." She gives me a wide smile. "Ready when you are."

I move to the front door, and open it for her. Her friends shout rowdy clichés like, “Don’t do anything we wouldn’t do!” as I pull the door closed behind us.

Dani chuckles as she leads the way to my car. She glances at me over her shoulder a few feet away from the passenger door. “So how far are we taking this whole gentleman on a date schtick?”

“Gentleman on a date schtick?” I repeat.

She rolls her eyes and makes a sweeping gesture to indicate the house and the car. “You opened the door for me to leave. Are you going to insist on opening my car door? Or am I allowed to do it?”

I jog a couple of steps to get in front of her, my key fob in my hand so I can unlock my car, and open her door as she reaches it. “Oh, I’m going to insist.”

A laugh that’s half disbelief and half pleasure burbles out of her.

I wrap an arm around her waist and pull her against me, dropping a soft kiss on her lips. “I know this isn’t what you’re used to. But I enjoy doing things for you. I’m not opening your door because I think you’re helpless or incompetent, but because I like taking care of you. I know you’re strong. I know you’re a total badass. And I also know that you don’t let people do anything for you if you can help it. But you don’t have to keep up those walls with me. Not anymore.”

Her eyes move back-and-forth between mine, her smile fading as I talk, her expression turning more solemn. When I finish, she nods and clears her throat, dropping her eyes to my chest like she does when she’s uncomfortable or embarrassed. “Okay.” The word is little more than a rasp, but it’s a clear agreement nonetheless.

“Okay,” I repeat.

She nods again and climbs into the car. By the time I’ve climbed into the driver’s side and started the car, she’s regained her equilibrium. “So.” She turns her upper body to face me, her hands folded in her lap. “Where are we going?”

Putting the car in gear, I laugh. “Nice try. You’re not getting it out of me that easy.”

CHAPTER TWENTY-SEVEN

Dani

I spend the entire drive trying to weasel our destination out of Eli. But he won't even give me a hint.

I have no clue where he's taking me until we pull up in front of a bowling alley. "Bowling? You decided we needed to go bowling? And you couldn't have told me sooner so I could dress more appropriately for our activity?"

He glances over at me as he smoothly pulls into the parking lot, his eyes darting down to my bare legs. "I told you, you look gorgeous. It's just bowling. I'm not taking you rock climbing or something. You'll be fine in a dress."

"So says you. Have you ever gone bowling in a dress before?"

The look he gives me is pure challenge. "Have you?"

I narrow my eyes at him, because he knows the answer is no. I can probably count on one hand the number of times I've worn a dress before this year. Even if we add in the two other times I've worn a skirt since coming back to school at the end of Christmas break, we're barely involving a second hand.

Instead of admitting it, though, I deflect. "Who in their right mind would go bowling in a dress on purpose?"

"Well, we're about to find out." He kills the engine and climbs out of the car.

He can do this chivalrous gentlemanly act all he wants, but I'm not waiting for him to walk around the car to open my door for me. I push the door open and climb out just as he gets to my side.

He smirks at me but doesn't say anything, just closes the door and hits the button on his key fob to lock the car. Holding out his elbow, he gives me a look of invitation.

I can't help rolling my eyes at him again. He's so ridiculous. But deep down, I really love it. He was right when he said that I have a hard time letting anybody do anything for me. I have a hard time asking for help. Asking for help was a sign of weakness. I was raised to be strong. To do everything myself. To handle it. No matter what.

But this semester has been one long exercise in learning how to ask for help so far. First with hair and makeup and clothes from my roommates, which still feels silly on some level, but I'm getting used to it. And now, with Eli. Not just help with what to wear, but advice on how to handle everything that's developing between us.

I'd never realized how dysfunctional my relationship with Luke really was until Autumn and Ellie pointed it out. Just like I hadn't realized how dysfunctional my relationship with my dad was until my sister pointed it out. Apparently every relationship with an important man in my life has been dysfunctional before now.

Even my relationship with Eli. Looking back, I can see that our friendship has always been beyond the bounds of normal friendship. All the time we spent together—from studying to parties to game nights—I thought were platonic friendship activities, but he was really falling for me the whole time. I just didn't realize it. And I relied on him the way my friends assure me they rely on their boyfriends. It's like a reverse friends-with-benefits situation, with a deeper friendship and none of the benefits.

At least now we can translate that into something more healthy for both of us.

* * *

Bowling ends up being way more fun than I expected. Eli buys me some ankle socks at the shoe rental counter since I didn't wear socks with my

flats.

I haven't been bowling in ages ... not since maybe freshman year of high school? I think we went bowling for one of my friends' birthdays that year.

That was before my dad went nuts with pushing me to lift and compete and train and watch my diet.

Eli and I don't watch our diet, though. Not tonight. We pig out on fried foods—chicken strips, onion rings, french fries—and soda. We're both terrible bowlers since neither of us do it often at all, but we each manage a couple of strikes and a few spares throughout the night.

My first strike was such a shock and felt like a huge accomplishment, especially when I turned to face him, arms raised in victory, and he rushed me, picked me up and spun me around before planting a kiss on me when he placed me back on my feet.

My borrowed dress—supplied by Piper's closet—doesn't even bother me once we get started. It's long enough that I don't have to worry about flashing anyone while picking up my ball, and soon enough I just get used to it.

Wide grins on our faces, we return our shoes and Eli tangles his fingers with mine as we head for his car. "Want to get dessert?"

"Dessert?" That's not typically on the menu for us. But tonight feels special. "What did you have in mind?"

He screws up his face like he's thinking hard, but it's his fake thinking face, and I know he's already got something picked out. He's probably had it planned from the beginning. "Ice cream?"

"My favorite." I bump his arm with my shoulder. "It's like you know me or something."

He chuckles, dropping my hand in favor of wrapping his arm around my waist. "I know. Crazy, huh?"

"Totally crazy considering this is our first date."

Throwing his head back, he laughs. "I've never had more fun on a first date." When we get to his car, he turns me and kisses me deeply, his hands cupping my head in a way that makes me feel cherished. Then he opens my door for me, waiting behind it until I'm all the way in before pushing it closed and going around to his side.

He takes us to a local ice cream shop where we both get waffle cones and sit at one of the round white tables in the corner to eat them. His eyes gleam as he watches me lick my ice cream.

Grinning, I make a show of licking it again. "Getting ideas?"

He shifts in his seat. "Mmhmm."

Letting out a low laugh, I lick my cone again—I decided on white chocolate raspberry tonight. Fruit's healthy, right? Right. And there are even raspberry pieces in it, so I'm not completely fooling myself about the presence of fruit.

Eli grunts and adjusts his position again, which makes me laugh some more, hiding my mouth behind my free hand.

"Just wait," he mutters in a low voice.

Raising my eyebrows, I drop my hand to the table. "What's that?"

He narrows his eyes at me. "You heard me. Over there torturing me. Payback's a bitch, just remember that."

"Oh it is, is it?" I probably should be a little more worried, but I can't help laughing at the idea of Eli doing anything that could be described as torture. At least where I'm concerned. "Anything in particular you're planning?"

"You'll see." There's a distinct note of warning in his voice, but all it does is make me shiver in anticipation.

"Looking forward to it," I quip, and he returns my grin with one of his own. But his smile looks distinctly more predatory than I'm used to. Which, again, only makes me want to find out what he's going to do to me.

He's right. This is the most fun I've ever had on a first date. It might be the most fun first date in the history of dating. My experience might not be vast, but I've heard enough stories to know that first dates are often awkward and weird. This is the opposite of that.

Turns out dating your best friend might just be the best idea ever.

CHAPTER TWENTY-EIGHT

Eli

Jackson has agreed to let me have the apartment to myself tonight, with the small request that I let him know when we're going to be headed there so he can make sure to clear out and not return at an inopportune moment.

I texted him when we got to the ice cream shop, so I'm sure he'll be gone by the time we get back to my place.

I'm so glad, because the urge to unwrap Dani has only grown as the night's progressed. And watching her lick that ice cream cone was sweet, sweet torture.

When I threatened to figure out a way to torture her in the same way, all she did was laugh. I can't really blame her, though. Some part of me would love to just tease her until she's begging, but I know that once she starts begging, I'll give in immediately.

I'm pretty sure she knows that too.

She's quiet when she steps into my apartment, standing in the space between the kitchen and living room and looking around like she's not quite sure what to do with herself.

After taking off my coat and shoes, watching her the whole time, I approach her. "Hey. Want me to take your coat?"

She startles, offering me a fake smile. "Right. Yeah. Sure. Of course."

Chuckling, I catch the coat she hastily takes off and almost tosses at me. "Relax, Dani. It's just you and me. You've been here with me a million times."

She lets out a nervous laugh, shaking her head and slipping out of her shoes. “I know. This feels different, though. More significant, I guess.”

“Because it’s the end of a date?”

That gets me a lopsided grin. “Yeah.”

Placing my hands on her hips, I pull her close to me. “Is there anything I can do to make you more comfortable?”

She rests her hands on my shoulders, her eyes on the open collar of my shirt. “Hmm. I can think of a thing or two.”

“Oh yeah?” At my question, she finally raises her eyes to mine, fathomless and deep in the low light spilling in from the kitchen. Up close like this I can see the shimmer of her bronze eyeliner. “What’s that?”

In response she slides a hand behind my neck and pulls my mouth to hers, her lips still tasting faintly of raspberries. If this is what she needs to feel more comfortable, I’m happy to oblige.

I tighten my grip on her hips, then shift my hands to her lower back so I can hold her against me, wanting to be as close as possible.

Even though we’ve been friends for years, there’s so much about her body that I need to learn. So much more of her to explore.

Last time was great—everything I could’ve hoped for—but once is barely more than a taste.

Speaking of taste, I didn’t get to taste her last time. I plan to remedy that tonight.

Ending the kiss—and smiling at her reluctance—I gently guide her to the hallway that leads to my room. “Let’s go to bed,” I whisper.

“Oh. Right. Yes, let’s do that,” she whispers back, sounding almost dazed.

It’s satisfying to have that effect on any woman, but especially Dani, who’s usually so unflappable, so in control and stoic about nearly everything. The one exception is when she wins. At anything. Any sort of game, and she turns into a competitive maniac who’ll stop at nothing to defeat her competition.

She’s not an ass about it, though she does like to take the opportunity to do a victory dance and point and say, “Ha!” any time she beats me. But I’ve noticed she only does that to me, so I know it’s just part of our particular dynamic. She feels comfortable enough with me to gloat over her wins. With everyone else, she’s as gracious in winning as defeat.

It's fun to see her flustered in a new way. I wonder how long it'll take her to get comfortable with this new part of our relationship?

I hope soon. As cute as she is when she's shy and uncertain, I want to see her let loose her inner vixen. Especially when I know she's a bombshell all dressed up with her sultry curves and nipped in waist. She's an old school pinup girl come to life.

That would be a fun role-play ...

I think role playing will have to wait for some time in the future, though, when the newness has worn off and we know each other's likes and preferences and want something to spice things up.

Maybe some people think that sounds boring. I can't fucking wait, though. Getting enough time to know Dani's body as well as my own?

Yes, please.

In my room, I close the door then light the few candles I've placed around the room before turning off the overhead light.

Dani turns in a slow circle, her lower lip caught between her teeth like she's trying to hide her smile, her eyes shining in the warm candlelight.

"Who would've guessed you were such a romantic at heart?" she says when she faces me.

I lift one shoulder. "Is that such a bad thing?"

She shakes her head, her wavy hair swishing. "Not at all."

Sitting on the edge of my bed, I beckon her closer. "Come here. Let me get my hands on you."

She obediently steps closer, and I reach for the tie holding her dress closed. "I've been wanting to do this all night."

One gentle tug, and I undo the bow at her waist before separating the ties completely. The front panel dangles from her shoulder, but the other half stays in place.

Laughing at my obvious confusion, she reaches inside the dangling panel. "There's a button in here to hold the inside part closed. See?" She undoes the button in question, and her dress falls open to reveal a matching set of black lace bra and panties.

"God, Dani," I breathe. "I can't believe I get to see you like this."

She lets out a nervous laugh, but I don't let her nerves faze me. I know she wants this as much as I do. She kissed me in the living room, after all. It's just still new.

Slipping my hands inside her open dress, I revel in the softness of her skin under my palms, place my hands at her back, and nudge her closer so I can kiss her belly.

Slowly, I place kisses across her torso, enjoying the way she sighs and drags her fingers over my scalp.

My fingers catch in the waist of her panties and tug them down. She releases my head and steps back enough so I can pull them off, and then she drops her arms and lets her dress fall from her shoulders.

I stand and reach behind her to unhook her bra, my hands immediately finding her tits as soon as they're free. Bending, I kiss each nipple.

"I feel weird being naked while you're fully clothed," she whispers.

"That's easy to fix." I step to the side and gesture for her to climb on the bed, unbuttoning my shirt as she does so.

She watches me with gleaming eyes as I remove my clothes. Under her avid attention, I take my sweet time, wanting to give her a show. Once my shirt is fully unbuttoned, I drop it on the floor with her dress. She sits up straighter when my hands go to my belt, her gaze riveted as the leather slips free.

I have to stop watching her watch me when I bend to completely remove my pants and underwear, but I'm rewarded with her heavy-lidded, lust-filled eyes meeting mine when I straighten, completely naked.

"You're so gorgeous, Eli."

"Thank you." I grab a condom out of my top dresser drawer before climbing on the bed with her. "I'm glad you think so. Especially since I can't get enough of your body."

She grins at that. "Oh yeah?"

I hum my agreement, climbing over her and kissing her. She lies back, her hands sliding from my shoulders down my arms to my elbows and back up again. Settling over her, I take my sweet time kissing her, careful to keep my weeping dick from getting too close to her pussy. I want to make sure she's as turned on as I am—or at least close. Even though the base, Neanderthal part of me wants nothing more than to roll on the condom and plunge inside her, the better part of me wants to make sure she gets off first.

After several moments, I kiss my way down her body until I'm lying on my belly between her thighs. I pet her pussy lips with my fingers, watching her reactions, then spread her open and take my first tentative taste—

tentative only because I like to start gently, not because I'm in any way uncertain about what I'm doing.

Using just the tip of my tongue, I trace the contours of her inner lips up to the hood covering her clit and back down the other side.

She shivers, and I do it again, using a tiny bit more pressure this time. I do it again and again, each time just slightly more firmly, until she sighs when I get to her clit. Then I lick her like she was licking her ice cream cone.

God, I want her to do that to my dick sometime. And then suck on it. Hard.

But I don't think we'll get to that tonight. I'll blow too quickly if she sucks on me.

Maybe next time, though. Especially if I can convince her to stay the night. Next time could be in the morning.

With that thought in mind, I focus all my efforts on this orgasm. Because if I can blow her mind now, I think that'll help my case to get her to stay.

She's panting and moaning as I circle her clit with my tongue again. And when I slip a finger inside her, she's already clenching.

With my free hand, I reach up her torso to tweak her nipple, and she lets out something like a squeak, but her pussy clenches on my fingers again, so I repeat the action, pinching and rolling her nipple between my fingers.

"Oh god," she whispers, and I know she's getting close.

I move my tongue faster, then keep it firm as her hips start moving and let her ride my tongue and take what she needs.

With my fingers curling inside her, her nipple caught in my other hand, and her hips keeping a steady pace on my mouth, she squeaks again, her hips losing their rhythm. I take over, moving my tongue as close to what she was doing as I can, making sure she gets all the way over the edge.

Her legs press tighter and tighter against me, and then all at once her thighs shudder, her whole body shivering as her pussy clamps down on my fingers in a steady rhythm.

I stay with her, bringing her down the other side before stopping. Wiping my mouth on my hand, I climb up next to her. She looks up at me with a muzzy expression, clearly sated.

“Feeling good?” I ask, my hand resting on her belly, then sliding up to her sternum where her heart beats rapidly under my palm.

She chuckles softly. “Very good. Mmm. Soon you’ll feel as good as me.”

I grin. “That’s the plan.”

Rolling to her side, she props herself up on one arm and gestures to my aching dick. “Do you want me to ...?”

I shake my head at her half formed question. “Not tonight.” Grabbing the condom, I roll it on, then lie back on the pillows. “C’mere.”

She takes my offered hand and rolls to her knees where she straddles me. I help her out by holding my dick steady as she lines herself up.

And then it’s just a slow sweet slide into heaven.

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CHAPTER TWENTY-NINE

Dani

Eli's head lifts from the pillow as I slowly take him inside me, his mouth open in a gasp of pleasure.

"Fuck, babe," he whispers. "You feel so fucking good."

I give my hips an experimental swivel and hum. "Yeah. You do too."

His hands grip my hips, but he doesn't make any effort to try to control my movements. So I start to experiment to see what feels best, slow swivels and a little bit of grinding until he's hitting my G-spot, and I'm gasping right along with him.

"Fuck, Dani. You're killing me."

"Well at least it's a pleasant way to go."

He starts to laugh, but it's cut off by another gasp as he lifts his head again. His hands roam my body, squeezing my hips, gripping my boobs when I lean forward so he can hold them steady for his mouth, one palm over my heart when I sit back more. Something about that last one seems so intimate. His eyes locked on mine, his hand over my heart, it's like he's wanting to communicate with more than his words.

It's deep and visceral, that connection. In ways I didn't feel the last time.

I try not to read too much into it, though. I know from painful experience that declarations and promises made during sex don't actually count. Luke made sure I learned that rule.

And while I know that Eli is nothing like Luke, I still know better than to think that this—our second time having sex ever at the beginning of a very new phase of our relationship—means more than us both being caught up in this moment.

Still. It's a really lovely moment to be caught up in.

I'm going to just enjoy it for as long as I can.

Soon Eli's need for control shows itself, and he holds me in place as he thrusts up into me, his chest and shoulders flexing as he chases his release. I brace myself with my hands on his chest, doing my best to keep up with him but eventually giving up and just hanging on for the ride.

As good as this feels, I'm not going to come again. But there's a different sort of pleasure in knowing I'm the reason Eli is unraveling beneath me, in watching the look of discovery that takes over his face just before he reaches orgasm, his mouth open in a silent gasp.

And when he collapses back on the bed, a loose-limbed puddle of well-fucked boy, I gently climb off him and settle next to him. Opening his eyes, he gives me a sleepy smile and pulls me close, his breathing deep and even like he might be falling asleep. Except a moment later, he releases me to deal with the condom, stepping out of the room for a moment followed by the sound of running water in the bathroom across the hall.

For my part, I sit up and get under the blankets, enjoying being wrapped in the warm, comforting smell of Eli—fabric softener, the slight spice of his deodorant or cologne, and underneath, the scent of clean male skin.

When he steps back into the room, he pauses a moment before closing the door and gives me a satisfied smile.

"What?"

He hums, stalking to the bed. "I like seeing you in my bed."

"That works well, then, because I like being here."

Lifting the blankets, he slides in, turns me so he can be the big spoon wrapped around me, and kisses my shoulder. "Stay the night?"

I could ... Tomorrow is Sunday, so I don't have to be anywhere at a particular time. "I didn't bring a change of clothes."

"I'm sure we could find you something to wear if you need it. But you can stay naked most of the time if you want."

Laughing, I turn onto my back so I can look at him. "You don't think Jackson would have an issue if I wandered around your apartment naked?"

He props his head on his hand, his other hand still resting on my rib cage, his thumb moving slowly back and forth like he can't get enough of touching my skin. "Jackson would probably turn as red as a tomato if he saw you naked. He's less easily embarrassed than he used to be now that he and Autumn are together, but I think their nudity is all he can reasonably be expected to handle. But Jackson's not here. And I'm sure your roommate wouldn't mind him staying there if we wanted the place to ourselves all night."

"That's true," I say slowly, not entirely comfortable with the idea, but uncertain how to articulate that or why.

"Why does that make you feel bad?" Eli asks softly, all too good at reading me like a book.

I flare my nostrils. "Sometimes it's annoying that you know me as well as you do."

That makes him laugh, and he answers me with a lingering smile on his face. "I'd apologize, but I'm not actually sorry about that. I like that we know each other really well already. It makes this"—he makes a circle with his hand, encompassing us—"easier in so many ways. There's so much less awkwardness and weird get-to-know-you stuff. I know you. I mean, there are definitely things I'm still discovering, but I know the most important things."

"Oh? And what are the most important things?" The question comes out more archly than I intend. It's a defense mechanism. I'm not used to people saying sweet things to me. I'm asking so he'll continue, because I like it. It's healing long forgotten places deep inside that want approval and praise. But the part of me that's so used to looking for approval and instead receiving criticism is still very present.

He gives me a lopsided smile like he sees right through me. He probably does. His fingers trace up and down my arm. "I know that you're smart and strong and beautiful. And I know that you have difficulty with compliments." His eyes flicker up to mine, then back to the path his fingers are tracing. "I know you care deeply about your friends and generally take no shit and that you have a huge competitive streak that you mostly keep under wraps until you feel safe enough to let it out." He slides his arm around me and tugs me against him, his eyes on mine. "I know that you feel

safe enough with me to do that. And it makes me happy knowing that I'm special enough to be let into that very small inner circle."

I blink, a bit overwhelmed by that recitation of Eli's view of me. And I'm grateful he doesn't seem to need a response, because he covers my mouth with his and kisses me deeply.

When he settles in again, once again turning me over so he can spoon me, he sighs, sounding content. "You never answered the question, though," he says lazily. "Will you stay the night? Or would you rather go home?"

I don't really have to think very hard about the question. The temptation of more of this is far too great.

"I'll stay."

* * *

I come home the next day around noon, wearing the same dress I left in last night. Eli offered to let me borrow some of his clothes, but I didn't think that would actually be any better.

Piper and Autumn are in the living room when I arrive, and they both look me up and down from my obvious sex hair to my second-day clothes and immediately let out whoops of excitement.

I can feel my cheeks getting hot from their assessment. It's not like they don't know what I was doing. I mean, Autumn had Jackson here last night so that I could stay over with Eli. I know they know.

That doesn't make their enthusiastic response to my arrival any less embarrassing.

"So," Piper starts, "I take it things went well."

I can't help laughing. "Yeah, I guess you could say so."

Grinning, Autumn shakes her head and takes a sip out of the mug in her hand. "As always the queen of understatement."

I do a little curtsy that makes them both laugh.

"No, but seriously," Piper says. "You have to give us more details than that."

I tilt my head to one side, face screwed up in thought, and tap my lips with one finger. "Hmm. You know? I'm not sure that I do."

“Dani!” Piper shouts as I head down the hallway for my room. Of course I’m not off the hook that easily. Piper follows me. And when I glanced back over my shoulder, I see Autumn sipping her tea at the entrance to the hallway. They’re both dying for me to dish. The problem is, I’ve never had a lot of female friends. I have no idea how to dish, even if I wanted to.

Turning, I stand in the doorway to my bedroom with my arms crossed. “What is it that you want to know, Piper? It’s not like you don’t know what we were doing. Do you really need to make a huge production of my first walk of shame?”

She holds up one finger. “First, I’m not sure it counts as a walk of shame if you’re actually in a relationship with the guy. I’m pretty sure walk of shame only applies to one-night stands.” She holds up a second finger. “Second, I want to know what you actually did on your date last night. We got you all dressed up, and all I know is that he said you weren’t going to dinner and a movie. Apparently you shit all over that idea when he brought it up? Or at least that’s what he said. And he also said that it was okay because he knew you liked to be more active than that. So what did you end up doing? And was it okay that you were in a dress? I know that you’re not big on dresses in general so I hate to think that you were miserable all night because of us. Because we assumed it was a standard dinner date and based on what Eli said, I don’t think it was.”

My frustration and embarrassment melts under Piper’s obvious show of concern. “We went bowling.”

“Bowling?” Autumn repeats from her spot at the end of the hall. She’s taken a few steps inside, but hasn’t come much closer.

Ellie appears behind her, clearly attracted by the sound of raised voices. “Who went bowling?”

“Eli took Dani bowling last night,” Piper throws over her shoulder in a rush.

“Ohhhh. That sounds fun. Did you have fun?”

Leave it to Ellie to get to the most important part. “I did. We had a lot of fun. We ate junk food, we bowled terribly, and when I got a strike, Eli celebrated with me like it was the winning throw at some massive bowling tournament.”

My roommates are all grinning like this is the best news they've heard all year. "And?" Piper prods. "What happened after that?"

"After that, we went back to his place."

"Bow chicka wow wow," Ellie sings.

Autumn whacks her on the shoulder, and Piper rolls her eyes. "Seriously?"

"What?" Ellie protests.

"And?" Piper prompts again.

Before I can answer, my phone vibrates in my hand. Thankful for the distraction, and assuming it's Eli, I glance at it. But it's not Eli. Eyebrows furrowed, I read the text three or four times, trying to make it make sense.

Luke: I made a mistake. I miss you. Can we talk?

"What is it?" Piper asks, the sentiment echoed by Autumn and Ellie.

I show her my phone, the text from Luke open on the screen.

Piper grabs my phone out of my hand. "That bastard," she mutters.

Autumn and Ellie flank her, reading the text over her shoulder. "Are you kidding me with this shit?" Ellie exclaims. "How dare he come crawling back now trying to get you to take him back?"

If I weren't so irritated by Luke and his terrible timing, I'd be entertained by how incensed Ellie is.

Autumn shakes her head. "I can't say I'm surprised. This is his MO after all."

"True," Piper agrees, handing me back my phone. "What are you going to do?"

"Block him," Ellie says before I can answer. She crosses her arms. "You're going to block him, right?"

I look at the phone in my hand, not sure what to do. I don't really want to talk to Luke. Piper is right. He's a bastard. Now that I have something to actually compare him to, I realize that he never treated me very well. But I was so used to being treated badly anyway, so used to being ignored by guys I was attracted to, so used to just being One of the Guys and Not Like Other Girls that I was grateful for any amount of attention I received. Luke was the first boy who ever expressed any romantic interest in me.

But was it really romantic?

Nothing he ever did for me could be considered romantic by any definition of the word. He never took me out on dates. He never made me a priority. If I didn't feel like doing something he wanted to do, he bullied me into doing it anyway. He broke up with me when it was convenient for him, so that he could fuck whoever he wanted guilt-free, while still keeping me hanging on, waiting around for him to come back.

Of course he thinks I'll still be waiting around this time too. Why wouldn't he think that? I always have before.

While all of that seems to support Ellie's position that I should block him, we do have a lot of history together. And that history makes me feel like I at least owe him a response to let him know that I've moved on and to leave me alone.

"Yes. Yes, I will block him. I'm just going to let him know that while he might miss me, the feeling is not mutual. I'll send the message, and then I'll block him."

I look up to see varying expressions of approval on the faces of my roommates. Autumn gives me a wide smile. "I like that plan. Good for you for moving on."

Quickly typing out the message, I hit send without a second thought. And I open his contact card, scroll down to the bottom, and hit block. "There. Done. Now, is the shower free? Or is Jackson in there? Because I would like to take a shower and change clothes."

Everyone laughs. "I'll tell Jackson to finish up," Autumn says.

"Thanks, guys. I know I'm not the best at expressing it, but I really do appreciate all of your help."

My roommates let out a collective, "Awww," and try to suffocate me with a group hug. "You're one of us now, Dani," Piper says. "Whether you like it or not."

Good thing I like it.

CHAPTER THIRTY

Eli

I've spent most of the semester so far wishing my relationship with Dani could go back to normal. It's still nothing like normal, but it's far better than that. I'm finally getting what I've wanted for years. Dani and I spend as much time together now as we did before, but it's so much better.

We still spend most of our time doing boring everyday stuff, just like we always have. We study, we work out, and we eat together more often than not. When Autumn and Jackson are home, or when we're at Dani's and they're there too, it feels more like a double date than being third wheels. I like it. I like it a lot.

I especially like that Dani is more comfortable with PDA than I would have guessed. She lets me kiss her pretty much anywhere. I mean, we're not exhibitionists or anything. It's PG-13 stuff at the most. And yeah, the guys still hassle us when we kiss in the weight room. But we both know they're just jealous of what we have. Hell, it's possible a few of them are jealous of me. Our loudest hecklers are also the ones who tried to hit on her when she showed up at team events all dressed up.

And I get to take her out on dates on the weekends. Even though she gave me grief about dinner and movies and boring traditional dates, I still do it because it's fun. I like movies. She likes movies. And there was a new Marvel movie we both wanted to see. It's way more fun to experience those types of movies on the big screen anyway. She managed to rein in her running commentary. For the most part, anyway. She did lean over and

whisper her thoughts to me a few times. But for me, that just enhances the experience. I enjoy getting her take on the things that we do.

Once it warms up, we'll be able to do more active, outdoor things. It's still too cold out for most of those activities. Although ...

"What do you think about going tubing?" I ask while we're supposed to be studying for our biochem test. We're in one of the library study rooms. I have it reserved three days a week for two hours in the afternoons. This way we're more likely to actually study together instead of making out or having sex. We usually do those things too, to be honest. We just do them afterward. At home.

Even here in the library, I'm having trouble staying focused. I'm feeling antsy for some reason. Now that we're into February, the endless cold is getting to me. Too many days with a low ceiling of clouds, sunset still ridiculously early, not enough sun, and too much dreary cold. Plus, I get the feeling sometimes that something might be bothering Dani. She hasn't said anything. At least not to me. And that, more than anything, makes me a little nervous. If she's not telling me what's wrong, then am I part of the problem?

So instead of studying, I'm spending my time thinking up fun activities for us to do together. And low-key planning some extravagant thing for Valentine's Day. It's less than two weeks away now. I need to figure things out quickly.

"Hmm?" She lifts her head and blinks at me, clearly having no idea what I just said.

"Some of the ski resorts around here offer tubing during the winter too. What do you think? Do you wanna go?"

A slow smile spreads across her face, and she sits back in her chair. "You want to take me tubing?"

"Yeah." My smile matches hers. "I think it would be fun."

"That does sound fun. I haven't gone tubing in a really long time."

I pull out my phone and open the website for the ski resort I was looking at last night. "They still have times available this Saturday. Should I get us tickets?"

She nods. "How much is it? If it's really expensive, I'll split it with you."

I wave her off. "I've got it covered. Don't worry about it."

Her brows wrinkle together. “Are you sure? Because you pay for a lot of things. I don’t mind contributing.”

I finish buying the tickets and set my phone on the table before answering. “Would it make you feel better if you covered dinner the next time we go out?” It goes against my somewhat traditionalist ideas about dating to let her pay for our meals, but it’s obviously important to her to share the expenses. So I can set aside my issues if it’s important to her.

She nods. “Yes. It would. Now that that’s settled, we should get back to studying. We only have the room for another forty-five minutes.”

At my dramatic sigh, she laughs and shakes her head before returning her attention to her textbook.

“Hey,” I say, ignoring the way she rolls her eyes as she lifts her head again. “Why don’t we quiz each other? Then we’re still studying and making good use of our time, but it’s a lot less boring.”

Chuckling, she shakes her head at me. “What is with you today? You usually don’t have this much trouble studying. Especially when we have a test.”

I shrug. “I don’t know. Just distracted, I guess. Is that a no to the quizzing?”

She shakes her head again. “No. It’s not a no. Do you want me to quiz you first, or do you want to quiz me first?”

“How about I quiz you first?”

“Good idea, since I’ve actually studied the material. You’ve apparently been daydreaming about going tubing.”

Unrepentant, I shrug again, then look over the textbook to find something to ask a question about. When I look up, I find her glaring at her phone. “Is everything all right?”

She flips her phone facedown, expression grim. “Yep,” she says, though the angry tone of her voice suggests otherwise. “Everything’s fine. Are you going to ask me a question about biochem?”

I study her for a moment, debating whether or not I should push the issue.

But she gives me an expectant look, and glances pointedly at my textbook. So I decide to let it go and focus on biochem. At least for the next forty-five minutes.

* * *

“What was that text earlier?” I ask while we wait for dinner at a drive-thru an hour later.

“Huh? What text?”

I study her for a moment, then have to look away so I can pull forward and pay for our food. While I’m pulling out my wallet, Dani smacks my arm and shoves her debit card in front of my face.

Rolling my eyes, I take it and pass it to the guy at the window, swallowing my automatic protest. She said she’d get our next meal. This is our next meal, I guess. I was thinking our next sit down meal, but if this makes her happy, then this makes her happy.

After we get her card back and are waiting for our food, I watch her put her card back in the slot in her phone case. “Earlier. At the library. You were glaring at your phone like someone texted you something that pissed you off. Your roommates harassing you or something?”

She chuckles and shakes her head, glancing out her window when she answers. “No. Nothing like that. My roommates sometimes annoy me, but they don’t actually piss me off.” She doesn’t elaborate further, though, about what actually upset her.

“Your dad?” I guess.

That gets her to look at me, her smile tight. “Good guess.”

I let out a rueful chuckle. “See? Another reason why it’s nice we know each other so well.”

That same tight smile again that makes me wonder if my guess was actually right, but then we get our food.

Dani opens the bag and pilfers a few fries.

“Hey! No fair!”

Laughing, she holds the bag out to me so I can grab a few as well. “So what time are we going tubing on Saturday? And when do we need to leave?”

CHAPTER THIRTY-ONE

Dani

Saturday is a blast.

I stay the night at Eli's to make it easier to get up and leave in time to make the nearly two hour drive to the ski resort. We plan to get there with plenty of time to spare so we can ride the bus up the mountain from the base.

We put on our snow gear when we park, and Eli looks cute in his black snow pants and gray parka, his head covered by a black fleece beanie. He grins at me over the top of the car as I pull the suspenders up on my snow pants and put my coat back on. "You ready to have some fun?" he asks.

"Yeah. Have you been here before?"

He glances around at the parking lot ringed with pine trees and up at the mountain looming over us. "Nope. This'll be my first time too."

"Well hopefully everything's clearly marked when we get up there."

He laughs. "I'm sure we'll be able to figure it out."

The bus arrives a few minutes later, and we file on along with several other skiers and snowboarders getting a midday start. As we head up the steep switchbacks, I'm glad that I'm not the one having to navigate this. Forty-five minutes later, we're deposited in front of the main lodge, looking around to try to get our bearings.

People are everywhere, skating past on skis, little kids dragging skis behind them, groups of guys shouting at each other and being rowdy just like groups of guys everywhere.

“Let’s go inside and figure out where to go,” Eli says into my ear.

Nodding, I follow him in. We find a smiling twenty-something woman behind an information desk, and she gives us directions to the tubing yurt.

Back outside, we have to make our way across the area between the ski lifts, dodging skiers and snowboarders zipping past us on either side, but eventually make it unscathed.

After a brief orientation, we get our tubes and make it to the top of the run. We wait behind a mom and her two kids who are lashing their tubes together with the help of the resort employee who’s managing the run.

Eli grins at me. “Wanna go down together like that? Or do you want to go by yourself?”

“Let’s go down together the first time at least.”

We watch the mom and her kids slide down the hill, the kids’ gasps and cries of excitement reaching us. We step up to the top of the run, and Eli threads the leash from his tube through the handle of mine, then takes mine and does the same. He holds them in place while I sit down, and a smiling employee steps up and holds the tubes in place with his shins while Eli climbs into his tube.

“Do you guys want a push? Or do you want me to just let gravity take you?”

Eli glances at me.

“Give us a push, please,” I say confidently. “A hard push.”

Eli lets out a whoop of excitement as the guy moves behind us and grabs ahold of our tubes. “Hang onto your hats,” he says as he begins pushing us forward, getting up to a run before giving a big shove to send us down the hill.

Despite our running push start, it takes a moment before we really begin to pick up speed. The cold air bites at our cheeks as we slide laughing down the hill.

When we reach the bottom, I roll ungracefully out of the tube. Eli laughs as he does the same, and we both scramble to untie our tubes and drag them to the bottom of the tow rope off to the side. Eli gestures for me to go first. After I hand the leash to the attendant, she gestures for me to sit down in the tube.

“Ready?” she asks once I’ve settled in place. At my nod, she attaches the plastic end of the leash to the tow rope, and with a jerk, I head back up

the mountain. When I get to the top, I scramble out of the tube again and wait for Eli, who's coming up behind me.

We watch a few other people go down, one very large group all holding onto each other's tubes and a few individuals, including one guy who runs and dives onto his tube, heading down the run face first. Next up is a kid, probably about twelve or thirteen, who asks for the attendant to spin him around as he goes down the hill.

Another smaller kid wants the same thing, but when he gets spun, he goes flying out of the tube and lands in the pile of snow between the runs. I stifle a laugh behind my hand, feeling kind of bad for the kid. He doesn't seem to be hurt though. He stands on wobbly legs and makes his way back to the top, having only gone a couple of feet.

His mom calls to him and asks if he's okay, and the attendant checks on him as well saying, "Let's try a bigger tube this time. You'll have an easier time staying in."

The mom gives her tube to the little boy, and this time he successfully stays in as he goes spinning down the hill.

Raising my eyebrows, I glance at Eli. "Are you going to do that?"

"Go spinning down the hill?" At my nod, he laughs and shakes his head. "Nah. I might do the run and jump headfirst one though."

I gesture for him to go in front of me. "Have fun."

He tells the attendant what he wants to do, and we all move to the side to give him room for his running start. He makes it seem effortless and goes flying down the hill, his laughter floating up behind him.

It's my turn next, but I'm not up for spinning or jumping. "Just a hard push, please," I say to the attendant.

We spend our two-hour time slot getting dragged up the hill and sliding back down, sometimes together and sometimes separately.

At the end of our time, we stack our tubes in the corral and head back toward the lodge, the light getting that wintry purple tinge as the sun heads toward the horizon.

"Do you want to grab something to eat here?" Eli asks. "Or wait until we get back down the mountain?"

We saw several fast food places along the highway as we passed the town at the base of the mountain on our way to the parking area. I'm not sure I want fast food, though.

“Let’s see what they have here. If nothing looks good, we can get something when we get back to the bottom.”

Eli nods and reaches for my hand. Our snow gloves prevent us from threading our fingers together, but it’s sweet all the same. He leads the way across the gauntlet of skiers and snowboarders, most of whom barely seem to register our presence.

We enter the lodge, stomping the snow off our boots and removing our hats and gloves. It feels so warm in here after being active outside in the cold for hours. Eli looks around, then confidently leads us in the direction of the restaurant.

My eyes widen when I catch sight of the prices on the menu. I didn’t think about the fact that we’re essentially captive clientele. It’s like in airports or movie theaters where they can charge an arm and a leg for the most basic food and drinks.

Eli doesn’t seem bothered, though. And I know he’s planning on paying. Despite letting me get dinner the other night, he still pays for most of the things that we do together.

“How about a pizza?” he asks. “That sounds really good to me right now.”

I hum in thought and look over the menu. I had kind of hoped to avoid junk food by eating here instead of at McDonald’s or wherever at the base of the mountain. But the choices here don’t seem to be significantly better—pizza, burgers, pasta. They do have salads, though. I guess I can live with that.

I nod my agreement. “Pizza’s fine. I’m going to get a salad, too.”

Eli grins at me. “Look at you, always trying to stick to the meal plan.”

“Meal plans have been my life for too long to give them up entirely.” I shrug. “Besides, I feel better when I eat vegetables.”

“Good point. I do too. One of the things I’ve always liked about hanging out with you is that I’ve never had to defend my need to follow my nutrition plan. If anything, you’ve helped keep me on track better than my teammates even.”

Smirking, I shake my head. “It doesn’t surprise me that your teammates like to slack off. Except for Jackson. I feel like he probably enjoys having a meal plan. It’s a system for him to follow. And I’ve noticed that he likes those.”

Eli laughs. “He definitely likes systems.” He gets a thoughtful look on his face and covers his mouth with his hand. Then he places his forearms on the table and leans closer to me, pitching his voice low, his eyes twinkling as he fights a smile. “Do you think ... do you think Autumn gave him a system?”

Surprised laughter bursts out of me. “Ummm, you know? That’s not something I’ve ever thought about. And as happy as I am for the two of them, that’s not really something I want to think about.”

“I know... same. It’s not really something I’ve ever thought about either. But now that the thought’s entered my head, I can’t get it out. Do you think she gave him diagrams and written instructions? Did he study it like the playbook or a textbook for class?”

I shake my head, unable to fight back the smile on my face. This is the most ridiculous conversation. “You’re not going to let this go, are you?” I look off to the side of the room, unfortunately considering Eli’s questions. “Autumn doesn’t seem like the diagram and written instructions type, though. But I’m sure she gave him plenty of verbal directions.”

Eli burst out laughing. “That gives a whole new meaning to oral.”

I know my face is bright red, and I’m dying laughing along with Eli despite my embarrassment. “Can we please talk about something else?” I manage to get out eventually.

A smiling waitress approaches our table, clearly picking up on our hilarity. “Hey, guys. Having a good time?”

We both nod. “We just wanted to grab some dinner before heading back after an afternoon of tubing,” Eli tells her.

“Perfect. What can I get you?”

Eli places our order—a chicken Alfredo pizza and two salads with just water to drink.

The waitress smiles again. “I’ll have that right out.”

“You’re a terrible friend,” I tell Eli as soon as the waitress is gone.

His mouth drops open, and he places a hand on his chest. “A bad friend? How so?”

I wave my hand between us. “This whole conversation. Speculating about Jackson and Autumn in the bedroom. Furthermore, you’re making me be a bad friend, too.”

Pulling his head back, he gives me side-eye. “Fine. We’ll stop speculating about what goes on between them. I will say, though,” he holds up a finger, “it’s not all speculation when you can overhear them.”

I shake my head. He makes a good point, but I’m not telling him that.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-TWO

Eli

One of the best parts about spending the day outside with Dani is that neither of us have looked at our phones much. So whatever's been making her glare at her phone periodically hasn't disrupted our day.

I've gotten her all to myself in a way that I rarely get outside of the bedroom. There I always have her undivided attention. But the rest of the time, there's school, friends, family, all the usual things that pull at everyone.

It all ends once we're back in the car. Dani pulls out her phone and scowls at it.

"Everything all right?"

"Hmm?" She looks up and blinks at me. "Oh. Yeah." She stuffs the phone under her thigh. "Everything's fine."

I slowly back out of the parking spot, keeping my voice light and my attention on my rearview mirror as I say, "Somehow I don't really believe you."

She waves a hand, dismissing my concern. "I promise, everything's fine. My sister's just keeping me updated about something back home."

"You can tell me about it if you want to. You know that, right?" I glance at her, unable to make out much of her expression in the twilight. Or it might be that she's keeping her face carefully blank. It's really starting to mess with me that something is clearly bothering her, but she won't tell me what it is.

She lays a hand on my arm. “Eli, I appreciate your concern. I really do. But it’s not something you need to worry about. I promise. Everything is fine.”

I take my hand off the steering wheel so I can hold her hand for a moment. The roads through town aren’t terribly windy, but I do have to make several turns, so I can’t hold her hand for long. I give her hand one last squeeze before letting go. “Okay. But I’m always happy to listen. You know that, right?”

She nods and starts talking about how much fun she had today, whatever caused her to glare at her phone forgotten.

* * *

When we get back to my apartment, we’re both worn out.

Dani drags herself dramatically to the couch and flops down, one arm flung across her face. “I am so tired,” she moans.

Chuckling, I pass her in favor of heading to my bedroom, where I drop my armload of snow gear in front of my closet. When I return to the living room, she’s still lying on the couch, unmoving.

“Come on,” I tell her. “You can crash in my room.”

All I get from her is another wordless moan.

“Oh, I get it. You want to do this the hard way. All right. I can work with that.” Bending over her, I grab the wrist of the arm across her face with one hand, and place my other hand under her side and hoist her to a sitting position.

She squawks out a protest, but I ignore her. I scoop both hands under her thighs, my shoulder against her belly, and in one smooth motion, I pick her up fireman style.

“Hey!” she protests again. “Put me down!”

“If you’re too tired to walk to my room, I’m happy to carry you.”

She’s laughing now more than anything. “This is not the romantic way I’ve always dreamed of being carried to bed.”

With a grin on my face, I push my way through my bedroom door and deposit her on the bed. “You’ve never struck me as the kind of girl who dreams of being whisked away to bed anyway.”

She glares at me. “I think if the semester’s taught us anything, it’s that you don’t have a solid handle on the type of girl I really am.”

“Touché.”

She bends to untie her snow boots and take them off while I close the door. “Do you want to just stay here again tonight?”

When I turn back around, she’s standing and undressing. “I’d love to.”

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CHAPTER THIRTY-THREE

Dani

I wake up the next morning to my phone ringing. Which is weird, because I have it on Do Not Disturb. The only reason it would be ringing is if somebody called me two times in a row. And the only reason someone would do that is if it's an emergency.

Sitting up, I scramble for my phone, panic clearing the lingering grogginess. But when I get my hands on my phone, I'm surprised to see it's Ellie calling. I figured it would be one of my parents, or maybe my sister, with bad news about a family member. Did Dad get in a car accident? Mom? Anita? Our grandparents?

But clearly not if it's Ellie.

Eli tightens an arm around my waist. "'S'matter?" he mumbles into his pillow.

Shaking my head, I hit the button to answer. "Hello?"

"You need to come home," Ellie says breathlessly in my ear. "There's a, uh, situation." I hear noises in the background and familiar male voices. Not just Jackson, though.

My breath freezes in my chest.

Oh my god.

It's Luke.

Luke's at my fucking house.

How does he even know where I live?

Scalding rage and icy panic flow through my veins in alternating currents, making it hard to even move.

The background noises get abruptly cut off, and when Ellie speaks again, she's quieter. "Did you hear that?" At my mumbled affirmative, she continues. "He says he won't leave without talking to you. We called the cops, but since he's just standing in the yard and yelling, it's not a priority. After the snow last night, everyone's working accidents. Their estimated arrival is still like forty-five minutes away." She sighs, sounding frustrated. "I hate to ask you this, but he's disrupting the whole neighborhood. Do you think you can come home and tell him to get bent? Or, you know, maybe a little nicer if you think that'll work better. Just, maybe if you actually talk to him and tell him you've moved on, he'll leave?"

"Right." I clear my throat, already pushing my way out of Eli's bed. "Yeah. I'll be right there."

"Where are you going?" I glance over my shoulder as I'm picking up my clothes to see Eli sitting up and rubbing his eyes.

Shit. I haven't told him that Luke's been messaging me. After I blocked his number, he started using different social media apps and even going so far as to message my sister to ask her to get me to talk to him. Of course, she's entirely supportive of me blocking him everywhere possible and moving on with Eli.

But now he's here?

And I have to go deal with his bullshit. And Eli has no idea.

He's going to be pissed. If I tell him now, he'll insist on coming with me, and that's just going to make things worse.

"There's some kind of crisis with my roommates," I hedge. It's not a lie, but it's definitely not the whole truth. "Ellie called. I need to get home."

"Is everything alright?" He throws back the blankets. "I'll come with you."

"No!" He gives me a funny look at my over-the-top refusal. Taking a breath, I calm myself down and offer what I hope is a smile. "It's, uh, Piper. And it's kinda personal? I don't think she'll want anyone else there."

He frowns. "Is she okay?"

"Yes. I mean, I think? I'm not sure. That's why I have to go home." I hurry to get the rest of my clothes on and lean over the bed to give him a kiss. "I'll fill you in on everything I can later, okay? Promise."

That does nothing to ease his frown, but he murmurs, “Okay,” and watches me leave the room without further protest.

When I pull up outside my house, my roommates are standing in the open door of our house, arms crossed over sweaters and sweatshirts, staring at Luke, who’s pacing on the sidewalk.

He turns when I park and watches me climb out of my car, relief swamping his features.

“Dani-bear,” he says, his voice dripping with affection, but the old nickname makes me recoil.

“Don’t call me that.” The command comes out cold. Firm.

Good.

I’m trembling with the need to make him go away. To get him to leave me alone. Forever.

Crossing my arms, I stay on the street side of the car, using it as a barrier. “What do you want, Luke? Why are you here?”

He steps closer, into the crusty snow covering the grassy patch between the sidewalk and the curb like he means to come to me, but he stops when I hold up a hand. Stuffing his hands back into his coat, he lets out a harsh exhale like he’s frustrated, his breath forming a cloud in front of his face. “I came to see you.” He says it like that’s explanation enough.

I let out a dry chuckle. “Yeah, okay. But why, Luke? Why come to see me? You literally never have before. How do you even know where I live?”

“Your dad gave me your address.”

“Oh my fucking god,” I mutter, staring up at the cloudy sky. “Of course he did.” Refocusing on Luke, I shake my head. “You broke up with me, Luke. Remember? What was it the fifth or sixth time? And then you brought your new girlfriend home. Where is she? Why aren’t you with her?”

“Look, I know I hurt you.” He takes another step, and I shake my head.

“Don’t come closer to me.”

“Dani, please. You know I wouldn’t hurt you.”

Another harsh laugh. “You’ve done nothing *but* hurt me. Our whole entire relationship was you hurting me!” I look him over, the sneer I know is on my face entirely involuntary. I’m so disgusted by him that I couldn’t hide it even if I wanted to. “Even if we both know I could drop you like a sack of potatoes if you *tried* to lay hands on me, that doesn’t mean I want

to. Mostly I just don't want you anywhere near me. *You* ended things between us. For some stupid reason, you had me convinced I couldn't do better. Didn't deserve better. And so I always took you back. But why should I? Before you at least had the decency to break it off with whoever you were hooking up with by the time you came crawling back to me."

A look of guilt passes over his face, and I still.

"I see," I say quietly. Apparently I was wrong about that assumption. "Are you even broken up with whatever her name is? Sydney or Sandy or whoever?" I wave a hand, brushing away the annoyance of trying to remember her name.

"Yes." The word is a protest, aggressive and combative all at once. "Of course I am."

"Well how should I know it's 'of course' when your face basically just admitted you were cheating with me on your other girlfriends?"

"That's not—"

I cut him off, uninterested in whatever he has to say. "It really doesn't matter, Luke. At all. You moved on, many times it seems. And now, at long last, I have too. I would've thought that a text telling you to leave me alone plus blocking you everywhere I could would've clued you in, but I guess you need me to tell you to your face." I lean over the hood of my car and enunciate clearly. "We are over. You are not welcome here. Leave before the police arrive and arrest you for trespassing and harassment."

He sneers. "If you've moved on, where's your boyfriend? Why isn't he here defending your honor? I never would've let you face your battles alone like this."

Rolling my eyes, I step around the back of my car to head up the driveway to the front door. I keep my eyes on my roommates, but have all my senses on high alert to make sure that Luke doesn't try to do anything to stop me from passing.

"Don't even try it, buddy!" shouts Piper when he takes a couple of steps toward me on the sidewalk.

He stops and holds up in his hands.

"Go home, Luke," I call as I walk up the front steps. "We're over. You should know. You decided it a long time ago." Turning around, feeling stronger with my friends flanking me, I stare him down. "We should've gone our separate ways years ago. You were right." That statement

provokes some jostling and mutters behind me, unhappy with me giving him any credit, I guess. But I ignore them and give Luke an icy smile. “A long distance relationship is too much work. I’m not sure why you think that would be any different now.”

I turn around and head inside, my roommates making way for me to pass.

“You stupid bitch!” he yells as they’re filing in behind me.

“Ignore him,” I murmur, gesturing for them to come inside.

“I was only ever with you out of pity! No one thought you were hot. You were completely unfuckable until I came along! But I knew that would just make you an easy lay!”

I tense at the horrible things coming from Luke, and Autumn steps closer, rubbing my back in comforting support.

“Maybe if he screams loud enough, the neighbors will call the cops too and they’ll come sooner,” I mutter, hating that his words have the power to hurt me. But they hit me in that deep, wounded part of me that’s only starting to heal.

“That’s a good point, actually,” Autumn says, wrapping her sweater around her again. “I hate listening to that bullshit, though.” She examines me. “You know he’s just mad at you for rejecting him, right? It’s a classic narcissist move—insulting and belittling the person who won’t serve as their supply anymore.” She glances at the closed front door that Piper deadbolted when she closed it. “None of it’s true.”

Jackson appears in the doorway from the kitchen, nodding at me, then frowning. “Where’s Eli?”

“At your apartment,” I answer, still distracted by Luke’s vitriol. I can’t hear it as well, but every once in a while a few words and phrases make it through. “Cunt ... stupid whore ... can’t do anything ... should just do what you’re told. Your dad and I know what’s best for you ... go home.”

That last part has my blood boiling, and I barely notice the anger on Jackson’s face before he disappears down the hall.

“Let’s go to the kitchen,” suggests Ellie. “Have you had coffee yet? Or breakfast? Do you want something? I can make some coffee cake. That sounds good. Piper, you start the coffee. I’ll put on the kettle for Autumn’s tea, and then we’ll have coffee cake, okay?”

Ellie best expresses her care and concern through baked goods, and I smile and nod, the four of us heading into the kitchen, where we can still hear Luke's voice, but the specific words can't be picked out, and I can finally relax. At least a little.

True to her word, Ellie puts on the tea kettle while Piper gets coffee going. I sit at the table, grateful to have my friends around me and supporting me. I honestly don't know how I would've handled any of the drama with Luke since Christmas break without them, and I'm once again intensely grateful that chance brought Piper to my dorm and we actually became friends. I never would've thought I'd appreciate female friendship so much after avoiding it for so long, but I'm glad I've changed.

Once the kettle is on the stove, Ellie pulls out a mixing bowl, a square glass baking dish, and the ingredients to make coffee cake. Jackson appears a moment later, gives me an inscrutable look, then bends and kisses Autumn on the head before taking the seat next to her.

He taps his fingers on the table top. "What are we doing now exactly?"

Piper takes the remaining chair. "Well, Ellie is baking, I just started the coffee, and otherwise we're waiting for the douchebag out there to either clear out on his own or get arrested."

Jackson makes a face like he's not a fan of this course of action. "Seriously? We're just gonna wait him out?"

An incredulous look on her face, Piper glances between Jackson, Autumn, and me. "Do you have a better idea?" She spreads her hands palms up on the table. "Dani did her best to try to get him to leave, but he's determined to make a scene. He obviously wants the attention. If we deny him that, he might go away on his own. I mean, technically he got what he came for. He said he wanted to talk to Dani. She came. She talked to him—or at least *at* him. It's not her fault he didn't like what she had to say." She turns to me. "Is he usually the type of guy who won't take no for an answer?"

I shift in my chair, wishing the coffee were ready, and clear my throat. "Yeah. He's never much liked being told no." I lift one shoulder in a half shrug. "It was usually easier to just give him what he wanted."

The look Piper gives me can only be described as horrified. "Seriously?"

Autumn clears her throat next to me. “I think it’s important that we focus on the fact that Dani is no longer in a relationship with him and also that she did an admirable job standing up to him today.”

“Here here,” contributes Ellie as she measures out the flour and adds it to the mixing bowl.

That provokes a round of subdued laughter, and then we all grow quiet.

In the silence that follows, the sound of raised male voices reaches us from the front of the house. Standing, I head through the living room, assuming the police have arrived to deal with Luke. Since he came to see me, I suspect they’ll want to speak to me.

But when I open the front door, the scene in front of me is the last thing I expected to see.

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CHAPTER THIRTY-FOUR

Eli

I have to admit that I'm more than a little disappointed about Dani's departure. Climbing out of bed, I scrub my hands over my face again, trying to decide what to do now. I'd planned on taking her out for breakfast. There's a diner not far from here that makes killer French toast, which I know is Dani's favorite breakfast food. Thick slices of bread covered in powdered sugar, whipped cream, and berries is definitely not on the meal plan. But I have an overwhelming desire to spoil her, especially since I know no one's ever really done it before.

Starting in high school, her life's been all about discipline and making other people happy. I just want to make Dani happy.

While I know we can't eat like this all the time, I feel a little bit like I'm making up for lost time. And also that I need to show her what she has every right to expect from a boyfriend. The kind of relationship that she truly deserves.

Pulling on a fresh pair of joggers, I shuffle out to the kitchen to stare at the pantry and the refrigerator. Should I just make myself some breakfast?

Probably. I have no idea how long whatever crisis her roommates are having is going to take. There's no telling if I'll see Dani again today at all.

That's even more disappointing to consider.

My phone alerts with a text, and anticipation makes my stomach swoop. Could Dani be done already?

But no. It's not Dani. It's Jackson.

Jackson: I can't believe you let her come here by herself. What the fuck, man?

Confused, I read his text a few times before taking out my response.

Me: she told me it would be better if I stayed home.

Jackson: and you went along with it? You let her confront her stalker ex by herself without putting up any kind of fight?

“What?”

Instead of typing out the many questions running through my head, I go back to my room and finish getting dressed, all thoughts of breakfast completely forgotten. As soon as I'm ready, I stuff my feet in my boots and grab my keys and coat and head out the door, barely remembering to lock it behind me in my hurry.

Dani's ex is here? He came to see her? Jackson called him a stalker, but what if the real reason she didn't want me to know he's here is because she hasn't actually gotten over him?

What if I was just a placeholder? Someone to fill in the gap until Luke decided he wanted her again?

Or worse, a way to get back at him since he brought his new girlfriend around at Christmas?

Would she use me like that?

I don't want to believe it, but why wouldn't she tell me what's really going on?

I think back over all of the texts and alerts that she's gotten the last week or so and how she'd always hide her phone, dismiss my concern, and change the subject.

The longer I think about it, the clearer it becomes that those things were all about him.

And the only reason I can think of that she wouldn't tell me is because she still has feelings for him. I mean, she's taken him back countless times already. I've sat through her talking about all of her breakups in the past.

And I've watched as every time she's gotten back together with him. Why would I really think this time would be any different?

Because I wanted it to be different. I hoped it would be different. I wanted her to be mine. Maybe I moved too fast. Again.

"Stupid stupid stupid," I mutter to myself, operating more on autopilot to get to her house.

Maybe I should've waited until she was all the way over him before confessing my feelings. Maybe I should've let her date someone else first. Have a rebound and get that out of her system so that she could be ready for us to have something real.

Did I screw up my chances with my impatience?

And what am I even doing now? What's my plan here? Jackson said I needed to come, and I'm just rushing headlong into god only knows what. What if the reason she didn't tell me to come is because she really doesn't want me there?

Part of me wants to turn around and go home. Would that be the smart move?

Maybe. But I also need to know what's happening. I deserve that much, at least. Don't I?

When I reach Dani's house, I find her car parked on the street and park behind her. There's a guy in a black coat with dirty blonde hair peeking out from under a gray beanie pulled low on his forehead.

It's hard to tell with the winter layers, but he looks to be in decent shape. About my height, maybe an inch or two taller.

He turns and watches as I climb out of my car, a look of contempt on his face. Turning his head slightly, he spits on the sidewalk, his eyes never leaving mine.

Classy.

This is Dani's ex? He looks like a complete douchebag. What did she ever see in him?

I look around the front yard and take in the closed front door, the curtains drawn over the front window. Where's Dani?

"Who are you?" demands the douchebag on the sidewalk. He scans me as I walk up the driveway. "You must think you're something special. But you're not. She's just an ugly little whore, who can't keep a guy interested for long."

Rage—blazing, white hot, incandescent rage—floods my system, narrowing my vision to only this asshole's face.

Is he talking about Dani that way?

The wind whips at my face, biting my cheeks and the tip of my nose as I rush him. Shoulder down, I wrap my arms around his middle, driving him to the ground.

He lets out an *oof* of surprise, but he's fighting back immediately, shoving at me, hammering at my spine with his fist. "Get the fuck off me, you piece of shit. You think you can steal my girl?"

I pull myself off him enough to land a punch to his middle. Unfortunately it doesn't quite have the effect I wanted—knocking the wind out of him and paralyzing his diaphragm for a second to shut him up—because he's curling up and his abs are flexed, muting the worst of the blow. Dude obviously works out.

"Shut the fuck up!" I shout, scrambling to my feet as he does the same. "She's not your girl. She hasn't been for a while now. You dumped her. Again. Are you really surprised that she didn't just sit around and wait for you to come crawling back this time? Seriously? Are you that dense?" I look him up and down. "I know they say steroids shrink your balls. I hadn't heard they shrink your brain too."

He rushes me, and I swivel away, easily dodging his heavily broadcasted attempts to tackle or punch me. He might have muscles, but he doesn't have the skill to take down an opponent.

"Stop!" Dani screams from the front door. Rushing down the steps, she places herself between us, her back to me, her arms spread like she's trying to defend me from her rabid ex. "Luke. What the hell?"

Scowling, he jerks his head at me. "I could ask you the same thing. You called *this guy*? You haven't punished me enough so you bring him over to—what? Rub my face in the fact that you don't want me anymore?"

"Oh my fucking god," I groan, but Dani ignores me, instead keeping her focus on her ex.

She laughs, shaking her head in disbelief. "Un-fucking-believable," she mutters, obviously to herself. I can't help agreeing with the sentiment. This fucking guy.

Her shoulders droop as she wraps her arms around herself and shakes her head. "Just go, Luke. It's over. *We're* over. Even if I weren't with Eli, I

wouldn't want you back. You've fucked me over for the last time. Just leave." A fine shiver makes her look like she's trembling.

Without even thinking about it, I strip off my coat and step forward, dropping it around her shoulders. She glances back at me with a distracted smile of thanks, one of her hands covering mine on her shoulder as she refocuses on Luke.

He sneers at the both of us. "How fucking sweet." He says it like it's a dirty word. But he finally turns and walks toward the car parked across the street, shaking his head and muttering, "Bitch."

When I start pulling my hand away, taking a step after him, Dani tightens her grip on me and shakes her head. "Let him go. Let him have the last word. It's all he has left, after all."

It grates, because I'm not okay with anyone calling Dani names, least of all that complete toolbag, but I clench my jaw—and my fists—and force myself to stay put and keep my mouth shut.

Once he's climbed into his car and gone, a police cruiser pulls up.

Dani sighs, releasing my hand to rub the spot between her eyebrows.

An officer climbs out of the car, a tall, light-skinned man with a bit of a paunch, his eyes wary and his hand on his sidearm as he approaches us and scans the street. "I got several calls about a disturbance?" His eyes flick to me, but he addresses Dani. "Is this young man bothering you?"

She shakes her head. "No, officer. He's my boyfriend." There's a slight hitch before she says *boyfriend*, and I know the officer catches it too, because his eyes flick to me again, his eyebrows raised. But when Dani continues, his suspicions are—hopefully—laid to rest. "My ex came and was harassing my roommates and refusing to leave until he spoke to me. I spent the night at my boyfriend's." She nods to me, and I step close, placing my arm around her to demonstrate my support. She leans subtly into me, but her back stays straight and proud all through her explanation of what happened to the police officer.

He asks a few more questions while jotting down notes in his notebook, then approaches the house, where he interviews everyone inside.

The whole process takes far longer than I'd like, because I really want to get Dani alone to figure out what the fuck happened.

I mean, I know the broad strokes, obviously. But the important question for me is, why didn't she tell me? Why did I have to find out what was

going on from Jackson?

She called me her boyfriend, but that brief hesitation makes me wonder what she's really thinking.

Was that a title chosen for expedience? We haven't discussed labels before now, so I suppose it's fair that she might be uncertain, especially claiming me that way in front of me without knowing my thoughts on the matter. Which, incidentally, are yes, absolutely we're together, even if I think the terms "boyfriend" and "girlfriend" sound entirely juvenile and far too pathetic to encompass the feelings I have for her.

But it's possible the hesitation was because she just went with the most succinct explanation. Plus it's more socially acceptable than calling me a fuck buddy or similar, especially since she's filing a police report against her ex. Having a boyfriend is more respectable than me just being a friend with benefits, and after being called a bitch and a whore by her ex only moments ago, surely she'd be extra aware of the need for her to look as respectable as possible.

When the officer finally leaves, after assuring Dani there'll be a record in case Luke decides to repeat the behavior, there's a palpable release of tension as everyone sags in relief.

Dani and her roommates exchange looks, and Ellie and Piper stand together. "I'm starving," Ellie says. "One slice of coffee cake wasn't enough. Piper and I are going to go pick up some pizzas. Today started off so stressful, we all deserve some cheesy, carby comfort food." They both hug Dani before putting on their coats and boots and leaving.

Autumn glances between Dani and me and clears her throat before turning to Jackson. "Didn't you say you needed to go get something from your place? We should do that now."

His brow rumples in confusion, but then clears when she gives him a pointed look. "Oh. Yeah. Right. That, uh, that thing. For sure. Let me change into pants, and then we can go." He lifts his chin at me before disappearing down the hall, reappearing a moment later wearing track pants in place of the athletic shorts he had on when I arrived, his keys in his hand.

And then we're alone. Finally.

CHAPTER THIRTY-FIVE

Dani

Once everyone's gone, I turn to face Eli, my lips twitching with suppressed amusement. "I guess they thought we needed privacy."

His face stony, Eli crosses his arms and dips his chin in a nod. "Yeah." His voice sounds like he swallowed gravel.

My brows wrinkle. I hadn't expected Eli to be ... mad? Is he mad? I thought he'd share my amusement.

But as I take in the tension still radiating from him, I realize I must be the only one who didn't pick up on it. *He's* the reason everyone cleared out. They all could tell he was ... angry? Frustrated? Maybe both? And left to give us the time and space to sort things out.

I'm just ... a little bit lost about what the problem is, exactly.

But I'm not in the dark for long.

"Why didn't you tell me?"

The question is quiet, but no less forceful for it.

I open my mouth, my arms spread, a passionate defense on the tip of my tongue, but then I realize that's entirely the wrong approach. He doesn't deserve to be met with my anger—especially when I'm not really angry and only mirroring his emotions. I left. While I didn't *technically* lie, I definitely didn't tell him the truth.

If the situation were reversed, I'd be upset too.

Dropping my arms, I shake my head. "I don't know."

He scoffs, and I can't blame him. It's a crap answer. I know it. But it's the best one I have.

"I'm sorry, Eli." I sink onto the couch, uncertain what else to say. What he wants to hear. How to make this better.

Arms still crossed he studies me, his jaw clenching, the muscle on the side of his face bulging rhythmically. "For what?"

I spread my hands. "Everything?"

He barks out a laugh. "Everything, huh? How convenient. Everything." The last word is muttered more to himself than anything, and he shakes his head. "And that's it, huh?" He shrugs dramatically. "You're sorry. Problem solved?"

"Well, obviously not." I pull the sleeves of my sweatshirt over my hands. "You're clearly still mad. I'm just not sure what you want me to say."

His eyes bulge a little bit. "I just want you to talk to me, Dani." He throws a hand out to the side. "You left this morning. Told me your *roommates* were having a crisis, not that the crisis was your douchebag of an ex coming and demanding to speak to you. Why didn't you tell me everything? Why didn't you let me come with you?"

It's my turn for my eyes to bulge, and I poke a thumb out of my sleeve and hitch it over my shoulder. "Um, do you remember what happened when you got here? You got in a fight with Luke the minute you laid eyes on him. Ellie had already called the cops before calling me. If you'd still been fighting when the police arrived ..." I press my lips together and shake my head, my nostrils flaring. "Look, I don't give a shit if Luke gets arrested. But the last thing I want is *you* getting arrested."

"Oh, so you were just trying to protect me, is that it?"

"I was trying to protect *everyone*!" The declaration practically explodes out of it, the force of it pushing me to my feet. "Luke is *my* problem, and it's up to me to deal with him. He shouldn't be harassing my roommates or attacking you. Or provoking you into tackling him. Which, I'll admit was satisfying to watch, but shouldn't have happened."

He rubs a hand over his face, his eyes glittering, and I can't quite parse what he's feeling right now. Which makes me kinda nervous, to be honest.

"Because you should've dealt with it. That's what you're saying. Right?"

I nod, and he sighs. “Dani, you’re allowed to accept help, you know that, right? You don’t have to handle everything on your own.”

My mouth opens, but nothing comes out. Because what he says makes logical sense, but not emotional sense.

He comes all the way into the living room and sinks onto the couch next to me, close enough to clasp my hands between his. “When Jackson told me your ex was here and I realized you’d gone off to him on your own, I worried it was because you wanted to take him back. That I’d just been a placeholder. The whole way here I wondered what I’d find when I arrived. What you’d say to me. And then I found him outside saying awful things about you.” He sucks in a deep breath, his spine straightening and chest puffing out, like the memory of that makes him want to fight all over again.

His breath comes out in a gust, and he shakes his head. “I couldn’t let him say that shit about you.”

On impulse, I kiss him. At first he freezes, but then his lips soften, and he kisses me back. He cups my jaw with one hand, holding me while he kisses me, and it’s so sweet and tender that tears sting my eyes.

When he pulls away, he rolls his lower lip between his teeth, like he wants to savor our kiss just a second longer.

“I’m sorry I didn’t tell you what was happening,” I whisper. “I didn’t want you to worry. I wanted to be able to handle it and come back to your place and pretend Luke wasn’t an asshole who doesn’t know when to give up.” I shake my head, looking down at my hand still clasped in his. “I just wanted it—everything to do with him—to be over.”

“Well, hopefully it is now.”

Glancing up, I give him a quick half smile. “Yeah. I’m sorry I made you worry, though. I never meant to do that. I—” I swallow hard, not sure this is the right time, but needing to say it anyway. “I love you. I only want you. I’d never take Luke back in a million years. I never should’ve taken him back the first time he broke up with me. If anyone was a placeholder, it apparently was me for Luke. And I don’t want to be anyone’s placeholder ever again.”

He kisses me again, fierce and passionate, his arms crushing me to him and pulling me into his lap. I go willingly, wanting to be close to him too.

When he ends the kiss, his eyes roam my face. “God, Dani. I’ve wished you would say that to me for so fucking long. I’ve wanted you for so

fucking long. I've loved you since ...” He shakes his head slowly, at a loss. “I don't even know exactly when it happened. I just know that you've never been a placeholder for me. You're the one I've waited for. I still can't quite believe we've actually made it here.”

I grin at him. “It's surprising to me too. I'm happy though.”

He laughs. “Good. Me too.” And then he kisses me again, this time his tongue parting my lips, his hips lifting and pressing into where I'm straddling him. “You know the other thing I was bummed about when you left,” he murmurs against my lips.

“What's that?”

“No morning sex.”

I laugh again, but he doesn't. Instead, he gets a firm grip on my ass and scoots to the edge of the couch.

“What are you doing?” I ask, even though I'm pretty sure I know what he's doing. I'm just too stunned to believe it.

“Hold on,” is all he says in response, and then he stands, holding me.

A small gasp of surprise has him sealing his mouth over mine again, but he breaks away with a curse as he bangs his shin into the coffee table.

Burying my face in the space between his neck and shoulder, I stifle my giggle in his shirt. He gives my ass a hard squeeze in retaliation, which doesn't feel like any kind of punishment at all.

He makes quick work of the distance between the couch and my bed, his grip on me loosening and allowing me to slide down to the floor. No one's ever carried me anywhere like that before, and it makes me feel small and feminine in a way I didn't realize I needed.

“I love you, Dani,” he whispers before kissing me again.

“I love you, Eli,” I whisper back when I can pull away long enough to get the words out.

Bending his knees so his face is on the same level as mine, he wraps his arms around my rib cage and squeezes gently. “Say it again.”

Grinning, I obey. “I love you.”

He kisses me, soft and slow and deep, his hands sliding up under my sweatshirt and the tank top beneath it. I raise my arms as he tugs it all up and over my head, his hands immediately finding the clasp of my bra and undoing it, tossing it aside once I pull my arms free.

His hands cup my breasts, his thumbs grazing the nipples, and he leans in to kiss me again, but before he can, I'm clawing at his shirt, needing it gone. Needing to feel his skin on mine.

With a grin, he obliges, reaching behind his neck and yanking it off, then pressing his chest to mine. Bending his head, his lips find mine, his hands roaming up and down my bare back. I wrap my arms around him, gripping his shoulders, then sliding behind his neck, my fingers sliding through the soft velvet of the short hair at his nape.

God, I love kissing him. I love the way he touches me. Kisses me. Makes me feel like the singular focus of his world.

I've never experienced that before, and at first it was overwhelming. Now I finally feel like I can just sink into it. Relish it. Enjoy it, secure in the knowledge that we're on the same page. We both want the same things.

He lays me back on the bed, his fingers catching in the waistband of my pants and undies, pulling them off before shucking his own.

Climbing over me, he slides his hands beneath my shoulders, gathering me to him as he settles between my legs, the tip of his cock bumping my clit as he presses it between us. He groans into my neck, kissing, the scrape of his stubble sensitizing my skin.

He kisses his way down, lingering at my breasts, sucking each nipple into his mouth and tugging before releasing them. His big hands grab my thighs, pushing them back and opening me up to him so he can trace the outline of my pussy with the tip of his tongue.

It's so fucking hot watching him go down on me, the way he devours me like I'm his favorite meal, the way his eyes, nearly black with desire, flick up to mine every so often, checking in, making sure I'm enjoying myself.

And I am. Oh god, I so am.

He grabs my ass with both hands, tilting my hips so he can get a better angle, sinking his face in my pussy and fucking me with his tongue before returning to my clit. Two fingers slide inside me, working my G spot as he sucks on my clit. My hips move against him without my conscious direction, instinct taking over as I chase my orgasm on his face and fingers.

My fingers curl into the sheets, trying to ground myself as Eli drives me higher and higher, my muscles winding tighter and tighter, the tension coiling deep in my core. When my orgasm hits, the tension releases like a

spring being let go, my pussy clamping down on his fingers. He doesn't stop, though, carrying me through the orgasm until I reach down and push his head away.

“Stop, stop,” I pant. “Need you. Inside me. Now.”

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CHAPTER THIRTY-SIX

Eli

Wiping my mouth with my hand, I sit back on my knees and reach for a condom.

Dani's reaching for me, making grabby hands to get me to hurry up, and I can't help chuckling. "Greedy little thing, aren't you?"

As soon as the condom's on, I guide myself to her entrance, pressing forward slowly and steadily. We release matching groans of pleasure, and I set up a slow rhythm to start.

"Tell me what you're feeling," she whispers, her hands sliding over my triceps and shoulders and down my back.

"You," I whisper back. "All of you, everywhere." Her heat encompasses me, and I don't want to think about or feel anything else.

Everything that's passed between us this morning has deepened what we have. In a way, I'm almost grateful to Luke for showing up like that, because it clarified everything, distilled us down to our essences, and now we both know where we stand with each other.

"I love you," I murmur, grateful to be able to say it freely, holding her eyes while I move inside her.

She doesn't shy away, a smile tipping up the corners of her mouth. "I love you too."

It's a dream come true. A fantasy I held close and barely dared consider.

She loves me.

She's mine.

At last.

* * *

Grinning, I watch from the edge of the living room as Dani does her victory dance after beating Piper at *Super Mario Brothers*.

We're doing a series of throwbacks for game night and working our way through some of the old eight-bit video games from the original Nintendo system. It's old school, but it's fun. When I told my parents about it, they both waxed nostalgic about playing those games as kids.

Piper heckles Dani's victory dance, but it's all in good fun, and they both end up laughing.

"Alright, alright," Autumn says, making shooing motions at them. "Dani, you advance. Piper, sorry, but you're out for the rest of the night. Both of you clear out. Dylan and Charity need room for their turn!" She says the last sentence loud enough to carry through the room, and my buddy Dylan makes his way to the couch, a petite girl I don't recognize joining him and trying to murder him with her eyes.

He doesn't seem bothered by it, though, wrapping an arm around her and pulling her close before saying something I can't hear and laughing.

She shoves him away, causing a round of, "Oooh," to go up from the people around them.

I'm distracted from their antics by Dani arriving at my side and stealing my drink. Wrapping an arm around her waist, I pull her close and kiss her, quick and hard, not wanting to get too carried away in front of everyone.

This is our third game night since we got together, so people still watch us pretty avidly, and it embarrasses Dani when I do more than give her quick kisses.

I tilt my head toward the couch. "Do you know what that's about?"

Eyes narrowed, she studies the pairing. I'm not sure if Dylan decided to let the girl go first or if they did rock-paper-scissors to decide—our usual way of deciding who's player one or player two—but she's currently playing as Mario. The objective is to get farther through the game than whoever's playing Luigi in the three lives granted by the game.

As I'm watching she runs into a Little Goomba and dies. Furious, she turns and smacks Dylan on the arm, who just laughs.

"I don't think they get along very well," Dani muses next to me.

With a chuckle, I turn to her. "You think?"

"I made it all the way to World Three this time." Her eyes are wide as she tells me this. "I can't believe it."

"Congrats, babe. It probably helps that you're over here all the time playing all the vintage games to beat everyone at these things."

She shrugs, dismissing my statement. "It's not my fault that I make time to practice more than anyone else. And besides, it's not like you and Jackson haven't had that advantage since you started hosting these. It's about time someone else got in on it."

I hold up my hands in surrender. "I'm not criticizing."

"That's right you're not," she mutters, but it's with a grin on her face, and she kisses me.

I sigh when she pulls away, placing her in front of me so she can lean against me. Wrapping my arms around her, I rest my chin on her shoulder. "Any way I can convince you to forfeit and go to your place like we did that one time?"

Her laughter resonates through my torso, and she shakes her head. "Not this time. We'll have plenty of time after everyone's gone. Plus, we'll be spending the whole weekend together."

"Fine, fine," I grumble, but not seriously. I mean, I'd happily take her back to her place and spend the rest of game night playing hide the sausage, but I'm not upset about staying either, even if she did knock me out in the first round.

When I kiss her neck, she tilts her head, giving me access. So I take advantage, running my lips up and down the soft skin between the collar of her shirt and her jawbone. "I can't wait to get you alone," I whisper against her skin.

She grins. "You never can."

That makes me grunt. "Oh, because you don't like sex at all, huh? It's all me?"

Turning in my arms, her grin grows wider. "I didn't say that. You know it's not all you. But I do like winning."

Her arms loop around my neck, and my hands settle on her hips. I dip my head for a kiss, this one lasting longer than our usual public kisses.

This right here is the fantasy, though. The thing I've always wanted. Us. Together. With our friends.

She's been my best friend for years. And I've finally managed to make her my girlfriend.

At last.

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EPILOGUE

Charity

The girl with teal and pink streaked hair looks up from her clipboard and calls my name, giving me a big smile as I make my way to the game couch and try to suppress my groan.

Because I'm paired with Dylan.

This guy. He's such an ass.

We went to the same high school, though we moved in vastly different social circles. And I never had any desire to change that. I figured he'd stick close to home. Imagine my surprise to discover that he's not only here at Marycliff, but friends with the guy my friend wants to date.

He grins at me too. If he had a different personality, I'd find him attractive.

But he's a complete douche. And while I know there are people who can be physically attracted to people they hate, I'm not one of them.

On him that grin—mocking and douchey—is just salt in the wound.

“Come on up here, Chastity,” he calls, holding out an arm.

The girl with the clipboard wrinkles her brows as she looks at her roster then back at me.

“Inside joke,” he tells her, his voice a stage whisper.

“Fuck off,” I tell him, giving him a shove when he tries to wrap his arm around me. “Let's play the game and get this over with, and then I can return to my corner and you can return to yours.”

His douchey grin never falters. “Aw, Chastity. You know I love it when you’re feisty. I’ll even let you go first.”

God, I hate this guy.

When Isabelle begged me to come with her, I agreed, knowing how much she didn’t want to come alone. Her crush, the second-string tailback Andrew Maloney, invited her yesterday. And while they’ve been flirting and texting, he hasn’t actually asked her out.

And game night at his teammates’ apartment isn’t actually a date either.

“Please come with me,” she’d said. “Andrew is the only one I know for sure. I don’t want to be there following him around like a weirdo if he doesn’t actually want to spend time with me.”

With a laugh, I’d agreed. “Fine. If he’s inviting you and you really don’t know anyone else, I doubt he’d find it weird that you’re hanging out with him. But I’ll come as backup if you need it.”

She’d thrown her arms around me. “Thank you! Thank you! Thank you!”

What I hadn’t considered is that I’d have to encounter her crush’s asshole friend. And even worse, I’ve ended up on a couch with him taking turns playing *Super Mario Brothers*.

I have no idea how I won the first round. We can either chalk it up to beginner’s luck or the girl I was playing against has even less experience with video games than I do. Maybe a combination of both. Neither of us made it past the second level. I only won because I managed to get a little bit farther than her.

I was Luigi last time, but due to Dylan’s magnanimous gesture, I’m now getting to be Mario.

Goody.

Not wanting to drag this out any longer than necessary, I press start as I’m sitting down.

“Oooh, eager. I like it,” Dylan leans over and practically purrs in my ear.

“Back off, or I’ll elbow you in the throat,” I mutter.

That only makes him laugh. “Told you, Chastity. I like this feisty side of you.” He drags a finger down my arm and makes a cat sound.

Pausing the game, I smack his hand away. “Seriously, dude. No means no.”

He holds up his hands, palms out. “Right, right. You’re playing. You take your video games *very* seriously, I can tell. No touchy.”

And while he doesn’t touch me again—thank sweet Baby Jesus—he’s not shy about his commentary.

When he beats me—soundly—he stands and stretches, a smug smile on his face as he holds out a hand to me. “Good game, Chastity. I look forward to many more rounds with you.”

Smacking his hand instead of shaking it, I stand. “I hope to see you never the fuck again.”

Dylan Thompson is the *worst*. The actual, literal worst. I disliked him when we were in high school, but now that our paths have crossed in college, I discover how terrible he truly is ...

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Dear Reader,

Thank you so much for reading Eli and Dani's story! It's been a while since I wrote a friends to lovers story, and I had so much fun with this one. I hope you enjoyed it too! If so, please go leave a review somewhere. I'd appreciate it so much!

Don't forget to grab your [free bonus scene](#). I promise you don't want to miss it ;-). It asks for your email address, but you'll only get emails from me if you click the box saying you want them (and if you already get my emails, you don't need to sign up again). Otherwise it's just for Bookfunnel to email you the download link.

Though if you want to keep up to date with new releases, like when Dylan and Charity's story comes out (which you totally do) definitely click the box. You won't be sorry. Or if you already know you want it, you can [preorder it here](#).

For more sports romance, check out [Off Limits](#) or [Summer Fling](#)! Both are fabulous stories (or so people tell me), and I know you won't be disappointed!

As always, thanks for reading!

Until next time ...

Jerica

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Every book has its ups and downs, but for a variety of personal reasons, I struggled to write this book. Dani and Eli are just so chill and undemanding that they were happy to wait patiently for me to find my motivation.

Several people were key in encouraging me along through writing this book.

Thank you to Deb for always helping me with ideas and forcing me to clarify all the wishy washy parts of the story.

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To Jen for your unfailing encouragement any time I need it.

To my Junkies for your enthusiasm for all of my books.

And to you, dear reader, for spending time in the world I've carved out of my imagination. I hope you've enjoyed it.

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You're also invited to join my closed reader group on Facebook, [Jerica MacMillan's Book Junkies](#).

Or, if you want to speak to me directly, feel free to email me at contact@jericamacmillan.com.

Did you enjoy this story? Please leave a review at Amazon, Bookbub, or Goodreads!

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Jerica MacMillan has been reading romance since she stumbled into the paperback section of the library as a middle schooler. And it's been an ongoing love affair ever since!

You can frequently find her sipping coffee out of snarky mugs while dreaming up stories and trying to bring them to life on the page. Join her Book Club at www.jericamacmillan.com/book-club and get a free book!

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Chapter One

“Hey! Watch it!” Abby shouted at the oversized asshole stumbling through the room with his buddies, drinks in hand. He didn’t even bother turning around. Fuming, she switched her red Solo cup to her other hand, shaking off the Jack and Coke that had spilled all over her thanks to the inconsiderate jackass now howling in the middle of the room. What a moron.

She glanced down in disgust at the dark stain all over her pink tank top that skimmed over her curves and made her feel effortlessly pretty. She’d paired it with her favorite denim shorts and the new gladiator sandals she’d scored on clearance just a few days ago. And now they were all equally covered in sticky brown liquid.

With a sigh and a roll of her eyes, she started to weave her way through the crowd of drunken Marycliff University students to find the kitchen. It was a big frat house on the edge of campus—she couldn’t remember which one with their strings of incomprehensible Greek letters. Actually, it’s not that she found them confusing. She just didn’t care. At all. The rooms all led one into the other like a big maze. She’d ended up somewhere near the

front of the house where Douche Mc Doucherson and his crew were still howling and knocking into anyone and everyone. The kitchen was at the back. Megan, her roommate and best friend, had dragged her there as soon as they got to the house to get drinks. And then they went in search of Isaac, the reason Megan had wanted to come tonight.

He was her boyfriend? Fuck buddy? Abby wasn't sure. All she knew was that Megan desperately wanted her to come along as her wing woman, and then promptly abandoned her as soon as she caught sight of Isaac.

One thing for sure, this was the absolute last time Abby let Megan convince her she'd have fun at one of these parties. Abby wasn't a frat party kind of girl. She'd much rather stay home and watch a movie or read a book. Small parties with people she knew were fine. But this collection of drunken idiocy and shameless grinding?

No thanks.

She finally managed to break through the throngs and find the kitchen, as stuffed with bodies as everywhere else. A breakfast bar with cups and drinks scattered across it dominated the room. The real attention grabber was the keg and another group of morons, with a central moron doing a keg stand. Abby elbowed her way through the crowd, uncaring who she bumped into anymore, trying to get to the sink to clean up as much as possible. Fingers crossed they stocked paper towels here. The prospect of spending the rest of the night sticky didn't sound appealing, especially considering she'd probably have to walk home since she'd come in Megan's car. She'd be a walking bug magnet like this.

A guy stood at the sink. A tall guy with his back to her. A white T-shirt stretched taut across his broad shoulders and faded jeans clung to his ass. And what a nice ass it was. She allowed herself a moment to admire it, a smirk flitting across her mouth before she approached him.

"Excuse me." She tried to pitch her voice loud enough to be heard over the noise of the party without shouting. No response.

She tapped on his shoulder, stretched up on her tiptoes, and practically yelled in his ear. "Excuse me!"

As he turned, someone knocked into Abby from behind. She lurched forward against the guy's chest, crushing her cup against his abs and splashing the remains of her drink all over them both.

He let out a surprised shout, grabbing her upper arms to steady her when she fell into him, but pushed her away when the cold liquid soaked his shirt.

“Oh my god, I’m so sorry.” Abby covered her mouth with her hand, feeling like a complete moron. He stood there with his arms out looking down at the mess on his shirt. Then he noticed the matching stain on her shirt, and his lips twitched like he might be suppressing a smile.

He cleared his throat. “It’s okay.” There was laughter in his voice.

Abby crinkled her brows in confusion. *Why is he laughing at me? I just spilled my drink all over him.*

Then she realized that his eyes were glued to her chest.

Abby looked down and gasped. Her light pink tank was more or less see-through now that it was wet. She could clearly see the pattern of the lace on her bra, as well as her pointed nipples. *Great. Just what I always wanted—to participate in a wet T-shirt contest at a frat party.* With a frustrated sigh, she reactively crossed her arms over her chest. Having random dudes talk to her boobs wasn’t a new thing, but it always made her uncomfortable, like her entire worth to some guys was as a walking pair of tits. But covering herself had the opposite effect of making the guy snort, starting to lose the battle to suppress his laughter.

“Can you move, please?” She put an edge on her demand, giving free rein to her irritation. The smug bastard was still snorting with barely suppressed mirth and staring at her boobs, not even trying to hide it. The fact that he was disgustingly attractive somehow made it worse—dark hair, square jaw, a dimple in his left cheek that gave him a hint of boyishness belied by his height and obvious muscles.

He stepped to the side and leaned one hip against the counter, allowing Abby access to the sink and himself a front row seat. His snorting turned into chuckling and quickly progressed to full-blown laughter. Abby shot him a glare while she turned on the sink and looked for a towel or paper towel or something to use to wipe off the soda.

“Sweetheart, I don’t think you’re gonna be able to do much to help your shirt.” A slight drawl stretched and flattened the vowels of his voice low, rumbling voice. When he leaned forward to talk to her, his breath fluttered the tiny hairs on the back of her neck that had escaped from her ponytail.

“Yes, I realize that.” She spit the words through clenched teeth while suppressing a shiver at his nearness. “But I’d like to at least get the stickiness off my skin before figuring out how to get home.” When she turned to look at him, his face was only inches away from her own. His dark brown eyes had flecks of gold in them this close, and his dark brows arched high at her words. If either of them moved an inch or two closer to the other, their lips would meet.

Before she could react to his closeness, he leaned back and snagged a roll of paper towels off the counter. The move caused his shirt to lift, revealing an appealing strip of tanned skin. Her eyes snapped back up to his face as he handed her the paper towels. Amusement still glinted in his dark eyes.

Annoyed and off-kilter, Abby ripped off two or three paper towels, got them wet, and started mopping up the worst of the mess on her arms and legs. She had to use more paper towels when she got to her sandals. After trying and failing to wipe her sandals out, she gave up and just stuck them under the running water, leaving them soaked but clean.

And now she was ready to go home. Though walking home with wet sandals sounded like a recipe for blisters. Was it worth it to try to find Megan?

Charlie Chuckles’s laugh track next to her while she attempted to de-soda-ify herself didn’t help with the decision-making process. He might have a nice ass, and okay, nice arms, and, if she were honest, a nice everything else, but he didn’t have very nice manners. She was getting sick of that smile and that laugh that she’d otherwise enjoy if they weren’t being used to embarrass her.

“Enjoying the show?” Abby reached for more paper towels.

“Very much.” He didn’t even bother to hide his smile, but it somehow seemed more disarming now and less mocking. Abby huffed in annoyance and turned back to her sandals, the corners of her mouth twitching in response. She wanted to hold onto her irritation, but found it difficult when he kept grinning at her like that.

“I’m Lance.” Chuckles stuck out his hand when she was done with her sandals. Glancing at his face and then his hand, she placed her hand in his and gave it a quick, firm shake.

“Hi.” Abby dropped his hand right away, ignoring his firm grip and the slight callouses on his palm. She turned away from him, trying to plot the best route to get to the front door through the drunken bodies clustered around the room.

“Usually when someone introduces himself, it’s polite to give your name in return.”

She didn’t spare him more than a glance, still scanning for an opening to make her escape. “When someone’s covered in soda, it’s polite not to stare at their see-through shirt and laugh at them while they clean their shoes.”

He laughed softly, the sound just reaching her ears over the noise. “Touché.”

Spotting a hole, Abby started to go, but stopped when he put his hand on her shoulder. “Do you need a ride?” All trace of laughter vanished from his voice with the question.

She turned back to face him, surprised to find him unsmiling now. “What?” He stood close beside her, his head bent toward hers to talk into her ear.

“You said you’d need to find your way home. How’d you get here?” His hand lingered on her shoulder, heavy and warm, holding her in place.

“I came with a friend. She drove, but judging by the last time I saw her, I don’t think she’ll be driving home anytime soon.” She’d found Isaac and they’d been getting ready to do body shots, giggling and heading for a room so they could strip and get drunk in private. “I have no idea where she is now, but I’m ready to leave.” She gestured to her shirt.

“Let me give you a ride.” Those gold-flecked brown eyes swept over her face, sincerity shining in their depths.

“I don’t even know you.” She shrugged off his hand, disconcerted by his continued touch and proximity. She didn’t like when people insisted on touching her for no reason, especially random strangers. Turning toward the crowd again, she was disappointed—but not surprised—to find that the gap she’d intended to use had vanished, a new cluster of drunk people filling the empty space. Nature hates a void, after all.

And fate must hate her, because Hot Laughing Guy was still talking to her.

“Sure you do,” he said, his voice taking on a cajoling quality. “I’m Lance. On the other hand, I don’t know you, so maybe you’re right.” He

stood close behind her, and she only had to turn her head to see him grinning again.

“Right, you’re very funny.” She sighed. “Fine. I’m Abby.”

Lance threw an arm around her shoulders and started steering her toward the door. He just laughed again when she once again shrugged out of his hold. His shoulders shook as he walked in front of her, his broad frame clearing a path for them both.

Once outside, Lance turned to her. “Do you need to find your friend and let her know you’re leaving?”

“No, I’ll just text her. There’s a good chance I don’t want to find her right now anyway.” Lance waited while Abby pulled out her phone, texted Megan that she was leaving, and slipped her phone back in her pocket. “Thanks,” she said, grateful that he gave her a little more space than he had inside.

It was after ten now, and the late twilight of June had finally given way to night. The concrete and asphalt radiated the heat from the day, but the darkness and cool breeze were a relief after being in a house full of the fug of bodies and alcohol.

She followed Lance to his car about a block away. The slight breeze plastered her still-wet shirt against her body. She plucked it away, grimacing at the way it stuck to her skin, painfully aware of her erect nipples.

She didn’t know what to make of Lance. He made her feel by turns embarrassed and flattered by his attention. She wasn’t used to being the center of attention and didn’t crave the spotlight. And while he wasn’t the first guy to ever flirt with her, he was the first to be so brazen in his appraisal of her body and not a complete douchebag. At least she didn’t think he was. He seemed genuine about offering her a ride home, and his hilarity at her expense quickly turned to concern when he found out she didn’t have one.

That was the problem, though. While his looks were very attractive, she was self aware enough to know that she didn’t belong with someone like him. But for some reason, his arm had felt right around her shoulders. She’d enjoyed the warmth of his body pressed against hers, the feel of his hand where it rested on her arm, the hardness of the muscles hidden by his shirt. The guy obviously worked out.

And liking the feel of him disconcerted her so much that she had to put space between them.

Lance walked a few steps ahead of her, leading the way to his car. He didn't say anything, but glanced her way now and then to make sure she still followed him.

Stopping halfway down the block, he used a key to unlock the passenger side door of his car. Like actually stuck it in the lock on the door and turned to unlock it. His car wasn't at all what she'd expected. She'd pegged him as driving a flashy sports car—something red, maybe, and fast. Definitely with automatic locks. But the door he held open for her belonged to a beat-up old muscle car. It was some indeterminate yellowy gray rust combination that she couldn't quite make out in the light from the nearby street lamp. She looked at him for a minute before sliding into the car.

Abby waited until Lance got in the driver's side. "Why did you do that?"

"Do what?" He sounded genuinely confused.

"Open my door for me."

Lance flashed that grin at her again. He probably thought he was charming. He wasn't wrong. "My mom taught me to always open the door for a lady. She'd whoop me if she found out I did anything else."

"So you have to open the door for me, but staring at my bra through my wet shirt is fine? How does that work?"

"She'd probably whoop me for that, too." The grin never left his face. He didn't even pretend to be sorry.

Abby shook her head, trying not to grin back. "Should I save her the trouble and do the honors myself?"

Lance laughed. "I wouldn't mind a bit if you decided to try." He turned and winked at her. Abby snorted, crossing her arms. And immediately uncrossed them because that just trapped the sticky, wet fabric against her chest.

Lance started the car and pulled away from the curb. He'd rolled down his window while they talked, and now the wind blew in, playing with the wisps of hair that had come loose from her ponytail.

"Where are we going?" She realized he'd never asked her address.

"We just need to make a quick pit stop." Abby examined his profile as he drove, wondering where he could be taking her, but decided not to push

it. The guy was giving her a ride home, and while he acted flirtatious and cocky, she didn't get a bad feeling about him. For some reason he made her feel comfortable and safe. It was strange, since she didn't normally trust people she didn't know, but she decided to just go with it for now. It wasn't like she'd see him again after he dropped her off at home. She rolled down her window and rested her arm on the ledge, letting her hand ride the stream of air flowing past.

After a few minutes Lance pulled into the driveway of a one-story brick house. It appeared well kept up, if a little shabby around the edges, with a crack in the driveway and weeds in the yard. They were in an older neighborhood with big trees, mostly pines, but a few maples here and there.

Lance cut the engine and looked at Abby. "Do you want to come in? My roommates should be gone, so you won't have to deal with any other random guys."

"Uh, no. I'll just wait in the car." Lance examined her face, lingering on her lips for a second longer than necessary. Then he shrugged.

"Okay. Be back in a sec." He got out of the car, and only hit two of the three steps to get to the front door.

Abby looked around the interior of the car now that she had nothing else to distract her. It was surprisingly comfortable and clean compared to the rundown look of the paint job. The tan vinyl was torn in a couple places, but there no clutter or trash lurked in the corners or on the floor.

Lance came back out a few minutes later wearing a clean T-shirt. He carried another shirt in one hand, flipping his keys around the first finger of his other hand as he jogged down the front steps. He slid into the car and put the extra shirt on the bench seat next to him, turning his body to face Abby.

"I wondered if you wanted to go hang out somewhere. I brought an extra shirt for you in case you said yes."

"Where would we go?" Her tone of voice betrayed her surprise, but she was curious too.

"Wherever. We could get dessert somewhere or something. I'm not ready to be home for the night."

"You could just drop me off at home and go back to the party." Abby felt compelled to point that out.

Lance nodded slowly. “Yeah, I guess. I was bored at the party, though. The friends I came with were already wasted, but I’m too picky about my booze to get drunk on crappy beer and bottom-shelf liquor. I was looking for an excuse to leave when you crashed into me.”

Abby reached out and picked up the shirt. Staring at it in her lap, she fingered the soft blue fabric while she considered her answer. Did she want to go out with this guy she’d just met? Or would she rather go home? Since Megan was still at the party, she’d have the apartment to herself.

“You could just take me home and let me change into one of my own shirts and then we could go out.” She looked at his face, gauging his reaction.

Lance still faced her, his eyes locked with hers. A small smile curved his lips. “I could.” He drew the words out. “But then you might overthink it and tell me no. This way you change and we can go. Plus, there’s a twenty-four-hour diner with great pie not far from here, and I’m hungry now. It’d take too long to drive you home first.”

Abby thought about it for another minute. “Can I at least change inside? I don’t make it a habit to flash guys I’ve just met.” *Even though you’ve pretty much seen it all already.* She stopped herself before she said the last part out loud.

Lance opened his mouth like he was about to say something, a mischievous look on his face. Then he seemed to think better of it, his expression clearing. “Sure. Come on.”

Abby followed him up the front steps, his pace less hurried than the first time. The front door opened into the living room. College guys definitely lived here. It was comfortable enough, but mostly utilitarian, with no concern for décor. A large flat screen TV dominated the wall to the right, with wires, gaming consoles, and controllers in a jumble around the small entertainment center. Battered and mismatched furniture completed the room, looking like hand me downs or thrift store finds. There were no pictures on the walls, and the curtains covering the large bay window had either come with the house or were hand-me-downs from someone’s mom.

Lance opened a door to the left of the TV. “This is my room.” He reached in and turned on the light. “You can change in here.”

“Okay. Thanks.”

The comfortable and utilitarian theme extended into the bedroom, with a queen-sized bed, a nightstand, a dresser, and a bookshelf crammed with books the only furniture. Discarded clothes littered the floor between the bed and the door to the bathroom.

Abby went into the small bathroom. It was surprisingly clean from what she knew of college guys' bathrooms. No globs of toothpaste left in the sink, and only a few items on the small counter—hand soap, deodorant, shaving cream, aftershave lotion, and a razor. The soap sat on the edge of the sink, the other items clustered neatly in the corner next to the wall.

Abby stripped off her tank top, dropping it on the floor. She grabbed a washcloth from a pile of mismatched towels under the sink, got a corner of it wet, and wiped up the soda that had seeped through her shirt. She slipped Lance's T-shirt on and looked at herself in the mirror.

She snorted when she saw the Superman logo in the middle of her chest. Well, somewhat below the middle of her chest, because the shirt swallowed her. The shoulder seams came almost halfway down her upper arms, and the shirt covered her shorts.

She tried pulling the shirt tight around her torso, twisting the extra fabric behind her and tucking it in at the small of her back. She'd seen other girls do that and look cute. On her, she thought it just looked silly. She fidgeted with the shirt some more, folding here, tucking there, trying different things so she didn't look like a toddler wearing her dad's clothes. With a huff of annoyance, she gave up and let the shirt hang loose.

"It's not like I'm trying to impress anyone." Abby reached up and redid her ponytail as she talked to herself in the mirror. "I've already dumped soda over both of us and treated the guy to a personal wet T-shirt contest. Worrying about making a good impression on the hot guy sort of went out the window already."

With that little pep talk, Abby went back out. Lance looked up from his phone and smiled at her. He stood up from the couch. "Ready?"

"Sure."

Lance opened the door and gestured Abby through, locking it behind him. He jogged to catch up to her to open the car door before she got in.

Abby gave him a confused look. What was with this guy and his insistence on opening doors? She'd agreed to get dessert with him, but it

wasn't like this was a date. He was just bored and didn't want to be home yet. That's what he'd said. That didn't make this a date, right?

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